CASSANDRA: BORN TO BE A STAR

A Cinematic, Choice-Driven Adventure

Genre: Feel-good comedy, inspirational drama, friendship, family, and celebrity fantasy.

Setting: Pan-Atlantic University, Lagos, Nigeria, and the beginning of a journey that will eventually take Cassandra to the biggest stages in the world.

CHAPTER ONE

THE GIRL WHO WAS GOING PLACES

Every superstar has a beginning. Some begin in Hollywood. Others begin on Broadway. Cassandra's journey began with a ringing alarm clock, an unforgiving university timetable, and a lecturer who had absolutely no interest in her excuses.

SCENE ONE: FIVE MORE MINUTES, LORD.

At exactly 6:15 a.m., Cassandra's alarm began ringing.

She opened one eye.

The alarm rang again.

She closed the eye.

It rang a third time.

Cassandra reached for her phone and silenced it with the determination of a woman who had finally identified the source of all her problems.

"Five more minutes," she whispered.

Five minutes later, she was still asleep.

At 6:27 a.m., her phone began vibrating against the bedside table.

Cassandra ignored it.

It vibrated again.

She ignored it with greater commitment.

Then came the call.

She answered without opening her eyes.

"Hello?"

"CASSANDRA!"

She recognised the voice immediately.

Sarah.

Her coursemate.

A wonderful friend.

A genuinely caring person.

And, at this particular moment, the human equivalent of a fire alarm.

"Why are you shouting?" Cassandra mumbled.

"Because I've been calling you for ten minutes!"

"Maybe the network is disturbing you."

"The network is disturbing me? Cassandra, what time do you think it is?"

Cassandra opened one eye and looked at her phone.

6:28 a.m.

She exhaled.

"Good morning, Sarah."

"GOOD MORNING? WE HAVE LECTURE!"

Cassandra sat upright.

"What lecture?"

Sarah went silent.

It was the kind of silence that usually preceded either a prayer or an insult.

"Film Production."

Cassandra stared at the wall.

Then she looked at the time again, as though the numbers might rearrange themselves out of respect.

"Jesus."

"Jesus is not registered for this course! Get up!"

The call ended.

Cassandra threw off her bedsheet.

The next few minutes were a blur of activity.

She brushed her teeth while mentally revising yesterday's lecture notes. She searched for her other shoe while wearing the first one. She picked up her notebook, dropped her pen, found the pen, and then discovered that the notebook belonged to a completely different course.

At one point, she stood in front of the mirror holding two earrings.

She stared at them.

They stared back.

"One of you will have to understand that we are running late."

She put one earring on and threw the other into her bag.

The missing earring would later be discovered inside the bag three weeks from now, having apparently decided to pursue a degree of its own.

Finally, Cassandra grabbed her bag and hurried outside.

She was going to be late.

Again.

But in her defence, the morning had started with an unreasonable amount of morning.

Cassandra was a 200-level Film and Multimedia student at Pan-Atlantic University. She had dreams of becoming an actress, the sort of actress whose performances made audiences forget they were watching someone pretend to be somebody else.

She wanted to tell stories that made people laugh, cry, think, and remember how they felt long after the credits rolled.

She wanted to walk into a cinema and see her name on the screen.

She wanted to stand beneath bright lights and hear an audience applaud.

And one day, she wanted Nelson and Kayla to watch one of her films and understand that their mother had dared to dream about something extraordinary.

For now, however, her immediate ambition was considerably less glamorous.

She needed to reach the lecture hall before her lecturer noticed her absence.

One dream at a time.

SCENE TWO: A LECTURE AND A PUBLIC EXECUTION

By the time Cassandra arrived on campus, the morning sun was already behaving like it had a personal disagreement with everybody in Lagos.

She hurried across the compound, adjusting her bag and trying to look as though she had not just run a marathon.

Sarah was waiting outside the lecture hall.

She folded her arms.

Cassandra slowed to a walk.

"Why are you standing like a disciplinary committee?"

"Because somebody has decided that time is a suggestion."

"I was preparing mentally."

"For what?"

"Academic excellence."

Sarah looked at her.

"Your academic excellence almost missed the venue."

Cassandra grinned.

They entered the hall just as Professor Adeyemi placed his notes on the desk.

Professor Adeyemi was a serious man. He believed in education, discipline, punctuality, and the fundamental principle that students should never become too comfortable.

He looked up.

"Miss Cassandra."

Cassandra froze.

There were approximately eighty students in the hall, but somehow, her name had travelled directly to the front.

"Sir?"

"How kind of you to join us."

A few students chuckled.

Cassandra smiled politely.

"Thank you, sir."

Professor Adeyemi raised an eyebrow.

"I wasn't complimenting you."

"I know, sir. I was trying to make the moment less painful."

The class erupted.

Even the professor's mouth twitched, although he quickly rearranged his face into the expression of a man whose professional reputation could not survive being amused by a student.

"Since you have arrived with so much energy, perhaps you can help us. What makes a good actor?"

Cassandra straightened.

This was her subject.

Her territory.

She thought for a moment.

"A good actor makes the audience believe the character, sir. Even when the story is fictional, the emotions should feel real."

Professor Adeyemi nodded.

"Good. And how does an actor achieve that?"

"Observation, preparation, understanding the character's motivations, and emotional truth."

"Very good."

Cassandra relaxed.

Then he added, "And attending class on time, so the actor can hear the lecture."

The room erupted again.

Sarah leaned over.

"International superstar."

Cassandra whispered back, "Keep talking. I'll use your face for my next villain role."

The lecture continued.

For the next hour, Cassandra took notes, asked questions, and became so absorbed in the discussion that she forgot about the embarrassment.

Then Professor Adeyemi announced a practical exercise.

The class would form small groups and perform a short scene demonstrating how actors could transform an ordinary situation into something emotionally engaging.

Each group had ten minutes to prepare.

Sarah immediately turned to Cassandra.

"We're doing a breakup scene."

"Why?"

"People like romance."

"People also like comedy."

"Fine. Romantic comedy."

"Excellent. Who's playing the boyfriend?"

They looked around.

Every male student suddenly became fascinated by the floor.

One began searching his bag for an item that clearly did not exist.

Another developed an urgent interest in the window.

Cassandra watched them.

"Interesting. The entire male population has developed a fear of cinema."

Eventually, they recruited Abiodun.

Abiodun agreed to play the boyfriend after asking three important questions.

"Will I have to cry?"

"Possibly," Sarah replied.

"Will anybody record it?"

"Possibly."

"Will this affect my future?"

Cassandra smiled.

"Only if you're planning to become president."

Abiodun sighed and accepted the role.

The scene began.

Cassandra played a young woman confronting her boyfriend about a secret he had kept from her.

She entered the scene smiling, then gradually allowed her expression to change.

Her voice softened.

Her eyes betrayed the hurt she was trying to hide.

She looked at Abiodun.

For a few seconds, the lecture hall became completely quiet.

"You told me you trusted me," she said. "You told me that whatever happened, we would always tell each other the truth."

Abiodun looked appropriately uncomfortable.

"And I believed you."

Cassandra took a slow breath.

"Do you know what hurts the most? It's not even what you did. It's that you looked me in the eyes and thought I wouldn't notice."

Silence settled over the room.

Sarah stopped fidgeting.

A few students leaned forward.

Even Professor Adeyemi watched with interest.

Cassandra had their attention.

Then Abiodun delivered his next line.

"I didn't tell you because I was afraid."

Cassandra turned back toward him.

"Afraid of what?"

He swallowed.

"Your cooking."

There was a moment of absolute silence.

One second.

Two seconds.

Then the lecture hall exploded.

Cassandra stared at him.

"Abiodun!"

"I'm sorry!"

"We are breaking up in a dramatic scene!"

"I forgot my line!"

"You replaced emotional betrayal with food poisoning!"

The students were practically falling out of their seats.

Sarah bent forward, laughing so hard that she could not speak.

Professor Adeyemi removed his glasses and rubbed his eyes.

"Mr. Abiodun," he said, fighting a smile, "I hope you never become a professional actor."

Abiodun nodded.

"Thank you, sir."

"That was not a compliment."

"I know, sir. I was trying to make the moment less painful."

The room erupted again.

Cassandra covered her face.

She was laughing too hard to remain angry.

The exercise was a disaster.

A magnificent, unforgettable disaster.

But while the class was busy recovering, somebody sitting near the back of the hall had noticed something important.

A woman in an elegant navy-blue outfit had been watching the entire performance.

Her name was **Amara Okafor**.

She was an award-winning Nigerian film producer, known for discovering promising young performers and giving them opportunities to prove themselves.

She had come to the university to meet the department head.

She had not planned to watch a student exercise.

She certainly had not planned to laugh until her eyes watered.

But she had watched Cassandra move from heartbreak to outrage to uncontrollable laughter without losing the audience for a single moment.

And beneath the comedy, she had noticed something else.

Presence.

Cassandra knew how to hold attention.

She could make a room laugh, silence it, and make it laugh again.

That was not something a camera could manufacture.

It was something an actor had to bring.

Amara leaned toward the department head.

"Who is that young woman?"

The department head glanced toward Cassandra, who was currently informing Abiodun that his acting career had been cancelled by unanimous decision.

"Cassandra. Two hundred level. Film and Multimedia."

"Does she act professionally?"

"Not that I'm aware of."

Amara watched Cassandra for another moment.

"Interesting."

Across the room, Cassandra sneezed.

Sarah looked at her.

"Somebody is talking about you."

Cassandra shrugged.

"Probably Abiodun's ancestors. They're coming to collect him."

Neither girl noticed Amara leave the hall.

Neither knew she had already made a decision.

And neither had the slightest idea that Cassandra's life was about to become considerably more interesting.

In a good way.

Mostly.

SCENE THREE: FOUR FRIENDS, ONE DREAM, AND NO MONEY FOR CELEBRATION

After the lecture, Cassandra, Sarah, John, and Abiodun headed toward the student café.

John had spent most of the practical exercise recording ideas for a short film he wanted to make.

Abiodun, meanwhile, was still defending his performance.

"Honestly, I think I brought something fresh to the scene."

John looked at him.

"You brought food into a breakup."

"Exactly. Unexpected symbolism."

"What symbolism?"

"She was cooking. I was afraid. It represents the collapse of trust."

Cassandra nearly choked on her drink.

Sarah slapped the table.

"Please, somebody give this man an award!"

Abiodun leaned back proudly.

"Thank you. I accept."

John shook his head.

"You're the reason the film industry needs an entrance examination."

They laughed.

For a while, they discussed lectures, assignments, and the short films they hoped to make before graduation.

John wanted to experiment with cinematography.

Sarah was interested in production and directing.

Abiodun claimed he could act, direct, edit, produce, and manage a film studio, although nobody had yet seen evidence of these abilities beyond his willingness to volunteer other people's time.

Cassandra listened, smiling.

Eventually, Sarah turned toward her.

"Seriously, though. You were good today."

Cassandra looked up.

"Good?"

"Very good. Before Abiodun committed his crime against storytelling, I actually felt the scene."

John nodded.

"Your expressions were natural. You weren't just saying the lines. You understood what the character was feeling."

Cassandra smiled.

"Thank you."

Abiodun raised his hand.

"I also contributed."

"You contributed to the national laughter index," Cassandra replied.

He nodded thoughtfully.

"Every industry needs innovation."

They laughed again.

Then Sarah's expression softened.

"You should audition for something serious."

Cassandra looked down at her drink.

"I want to."

"Then do it."

Cassandra was quiet for a moment.

It was easy to talk about dreams.

It was harder to know where to begin.

She was still a student. She had assignments, exams, family responsibilities, and a future that had not yet revealed its plans.

The acting industry seemed enormous from where she stood.

Sometimes, she wondered how people crossed the distance between wanting something and actually becoming it.

John leaned forward.

"You know what your problem is?"

Cassandra looked at him suspiciously.

"Please don't say money. I already know."

"You keep thinking about the entire journey before you've taken the first step."

Sarah nodded.

"Exactly. You don't have to become a superstar tomorrow. Just start."

Cassandra smiled.

"That sounds suspiciously like advice from a motivational speaker."

John extended his hand.

"I'll send you my invoice."

"Please send it to my manager."

Abiodun sat up.

"Who's your manager?"

Cassandra pointed at him.

"Not you."

"Your loss."

Sarah suddenly lifted her phone.

"Wait! Look at this!"

She had opened the department's student group chat.

A new announcement had appeared.

URGENT CASTING OPPORTUNITY: STUDENT ACTORS WANTED FOR UPCOMING FEATURE FILM

Cassandra leaned closer.

The production company was looking for young actors for a romantic comedy. The audition would take place the following morning.

Applicants needed to prepare a short monologue and attend a screen test.

The project was being produced by Amara Okafor.

Cassandra read the announcement twice.

Then a third time.

John whistled.

"That's a serious production."

Sarah grabbed Cassandra's arm.

"Apply!"

Cassandra stared at the screen.

"What if I'm not ready?"

Abiodun looked at her as though she had just announced plans to marry a traffic cone.

"Nobody is ready for anything in this country. People enter university without knowing where their department is. People start businesses without knowing where their profit is coming from. People even get married because their friends have started asking questions."

John nodded.

"That last one is not advice."

"I'm saying life is unpredictable."

Cassandra laughed.

Sarah pointed at the application button.

"Apply."

Cassandra's thumb hovered over the screen.

She imagined standing in front of a panel of professionals.

She imagined forgetting her lines, stumbling over her words, or discovering that her acting was not as good as she believed.

Then she imagined the opposite.

A camera.

A character.

A story.

The chance to do the thing she had been dreaming about.

She took a breath.

And pressed **APPLY**.

A confirmation message appeared.

APPLICATION RECEIVED.

For a moment, Cassandra simply stared at it.

Then Sarah screamed.

"MY FRIEND IS GOING TO HOLLYWOOD!"

"Please reduce your volume," Cassandra said, laughing.

"WHEN YOU BECOME FAMOUS, REMEMBER WHO SUPPORTED YOU!"

John raised his hand.

"I also supported you."

"You laughed at Abiodun," Cassandra replied.

"I can multitask."

Abiodun leaned forward.

"When you win your first award, I want you to mention my contribution to your success."

"What contribution?"

"I helped you understand the importance of good dialogue."

Cassandra stared at him.

"Abiodun, you are one more statement away from becoming a documentary about unemployment."

They burst into laughter.

Then Cassandra looked at the confirmation message again.

Tomorrow.

Her first major audition.

A real opportunity.

Something had changed, even if the world had not noticed yet.

For the first time, her dream was no longer just something she imagined when life became quiet.

It had a date.

A location.

And a very inconvenient deadline.

SCENE FOUR: THE BUSINESS ADMINISTRATION DEPARTMENT OF GIST

By late afternoon, Cassandra had returned to her hostel.

She had approximately six hours of peace before the next assignment, three messages from her class group, and an urgent reminder from her department that students were expected to submit something nobody had mentioned in class.

She was about to begin researching her audition when her phone rang.

Rebecca.

Cassandra answered.

"Hello, bestie."

"CASSANDRA, MY FAVOURITE HUMAN BEING!"

Cassandra smiled.

"How much do you need?"

Rebecca gasped.

"Is that how you see me?"

"Last time you called me your favourite human being, you wanted me to help you choose between two outfits."

"And you did an excellent job."

"You wore neither."

"They didn't match my shoes."

Cassandra laughed.

Rebecca was a 200-level student at Pan-Atlantic University too, studying Business Administration. They were in different departments and lived in separate hostel buildings on campus, but distance had never been a serious obstacle to their friendship.

They had previously shared a hostel room, back when they had the privilege of discovering each other's sleeping habits, questionable midnight decisions, and ability to turn a five-minute conversation into a two-hour discussion.

Now they lived in different buildings.

This meant fewer arguments about whose belongings were occupying whose side of the room, but it had done absolutely nothing to reduce the volume of their conversations.

"How was your day?" Rebecca asked.

Cassandra told her about the lecture, the practical exercise, and the audition opportunity.

Rebecca went quiet.

Cassandra frowned at her phone.

"Rebecca?"

"I'm here."

"Why are you silent?"

"I'm processing."

"You're processing what?"

"The fact that my best friend is about to become a celebrity while I'm still trying to understand why our lecturer gave us an assignment that looks like a business proposal for the United Nations."

Cassandra laughed.

"Please. I haven't even auditioned yet."

"And? The journey of a thousand miles begins with one step."

"Who told you that?"

"Google."

"At least you're honest."

Rebecca continued, "Listen to me. You're going to prepare properly, go there, and do your best. Don't go and stand in front of those people behaving as if they are gods."

"What if they are intimidating?"

"Then remember that they also have to eat, sleep, and use the toilet."

Cassandra burst out laughing.

"Rebecca!"

"What? Is it not true? Some of these people will enter a room and start behaving like they personally invented oxygen."

Cassandra wiped her eyes.

"You're not helping."

"I'm helping spiritually, emotionally, and academically. Financial assistance is currently unavailable."

"Naturally."

Rebecca's voice softened.

"Seriously, though. I'm proud of you. You should do this."

Cassandra smiled.

"Thank you."

"And when you become famous, please don't start pretending you don't know me."

"How will I pretend not to know you when you have already announced our friendship to the entire university?"

"Good. I have evidence."

Cassandra shook her head, still smiling.

Then Rebecca added, "By the way, Vikksy knows?"

Cassandra paused.

"Not yet."

"Tell him."

"I will."

Rebecca hummed.

"Good. Because if I hear that you're auditioning tomorrow and he doesn't know, I will personally organise an emergency meeting of the people who care about you."

"Which department will chair the meeting?"

"Business Administration. We will develop a five-year strategic plan for your success."

Cassandra laughed.

"Please go and read your notes."

"I am reading them."

"You're on the phone with me."

"I can multitask."

Cassandra smiled.

"Goodbye, Rebecca."

"Love you, babe. Go and conquer."

The call ended.

Cassandra looked at her phone.

Then she opened her messages and searched for Vikksy's name.

She paused for a moment before typing.

CASSANDRA: Something happened today.

His reply arrived a few minutes later.

VIKKSY: Good something or the kind of something that requires me to start investigating?

Cassandra laughed.

Apparently, people who knew her had developed a common method of communication.

CASSANDRA: Good something.

VIKKSY: Proceed, madam.

She told him about the practical exercise, the producer, and the audition.

This time, the reply took a little longer.

VIKKSY: Wait. You're auditioning for an actual film production tomorrow?

CASSANDRA: Yes.

VIKKSY: Cassandra.

CASSANDRA: What?

VIKKSY: Why are you telling me this as if you just remembered to buy bread?

She laughed.

CASSANDRA: I haven't even started preparing.

VIKKSY: Then we have work to do.

CASSANDRA: We?

VIKKSY: You think I will allow you to walk into an audition without at least checking your monologue? I have a reputation to protect.

CASSANDRA: YOUR reputation?

VIKKSY: I'm your unofficial manager.

CASSANDRA: I never appointed you.

VIKKSY: The appointment was approved by the committee.

CASSANDRA: Which committee?

VIKKSY: Me.

Cassandra laughed so hard that she had to put her phone down.

Then another message arrived.

VIKKSY: Seriously. Send me the audition details. Let's prepare properly.

She looked at the message for a moment.

Vikksy had been part of her life through difficult seasons and good ones. He knew how much acting meant to her, how often she thought about the future, and how easily she could start doubting herself when an opportunity became real.

Their relationship had changed, but the care between them remained genuine.

He wasn't offering to help because he expected anything in return.

He was offering because he wanted her to succeed.

And that mattered.

CASSANDRA: Thank you, Vikksy.

VIKKSY: No problem. Now send the details before I start charging consultation fees.

CASSANDRA: I will pay you with exposure.

VIKKSY: In this economy? I reject the offer.

She smiled.

Tomorrow was going to be a big day.

And she wasn't going into it alone.

SCENE FIVE: THE PLAN

That evening, Cassandra settled down with her phone, a notebook, and the casting announcement.

She had chosen a monologue about a young woman who discovers that the people she loves have underestimated her.

The character wasn't angry because she wanted to win an argument.

She was hurt because she had spent too long trying to prove that her dreams deserved to be taken seriously.

Cassandra understood that feeling.

She read the monologue aloud.

The first attempt was stiff.

The second was better.

The third sounded almost natural.

Then her phone rang.

Rebecca.

Again.

Cassandra answered with a sigh.

"Madam, is there an emergency?"

"Yes."

"What happened?"

"I have a question."

"That is not an emergency."

"It is to me."

Cassandra closed her eyes.

"Proceed."

Rebecca took a dramatic breath.

"What are you wearing tomorrow?"

Cassandra stared at the wall.

"Rebecca."

"What?"

"I am going to an audition, not the coronation of a queen."

"Exactly. So you need to look like a queen who can act."

Cassandra laughed.

They spent the next several minutes discussing outfits, presentation, and the importance of looking professional without trying so hard that the audition panel became distracted by her clothes instead of her performance.

When the call ended, Cassandra returned to her monologue.

She practised her expressions.

She studied the character's motivations.

She recorded herself reading the lines and watched the playback, making notes about her pacing and delivery.

Then she wrote a new list.

1. Understand the character.
2. Speak clearly.
3. Listen before responding.
4. Don't rush the emotional moments.
5. Remember to breathe.
6. If Abiodun somehow appears, do not let him improvise.

She laughed at the last point.

Then she put her phone aside and looked at the ceiling.

Tomorrow, she would walk into a room filled with people who might decide whether she was right for a role.

She couldn't control their preferences.

She couldn't guarantee the outcome.

But she could prepare.

She could show up.

She could give herself a chance.

And perhaps that was how extraordinary things began.

Not with certainty.

Not with a guarantee.

But with a dream, a little courage, and the willingness to take one step toward it.

Across Lagos, Amara Okafor reviewed the audition applications.

When she reached Cassandra's name, she paused.

Then she picked up her phone.

"Make sure this applicant receives her confirmation," she told her assistant.

"Any particular reason?"

Amara smiled.

"I watched her perform today. I want to see what she can do when she has a script and nobody is trying to break up over cooking."

Her assistant laughed.

Amara returned to the list.

Tomorrow, she would meet a room full of hopeful young performers.

One of them might be exactly what her film needed.

And somewhere on the campus of Pan-Atlantic University, Cassandra was practising her monologue, completely unaware that her first real opportunity was already waiting for her.

She finished the final line, lowered her notebook, and smiled.

Then she checked the time.

11:48 p.m.

She immediately put her phone away.

The future could wait until morning.

Even future superstars needed sleep.

END OF CHAPTER ONE

CHAPTER TWO

AUDITION, CONFUSION AND OTHER NATURAL DISASTERS

The next morning, Cassandra discovered that becoming an actress required three things: talent, courage, and the ability to remain calm while strangers stared at you as if they were calculating your market value.

SCENE ONE: THE MORNING AFTER THE DREAM

At 6:30 a.m., Cassandra was awake.

Not because her alarm had rung.

Not because Sarah had called.

Not because she had suddenly developed a passion for punctuality.

She was awake because her brain had decided that today was an excellent day to replay every possible way she could embarrass herself.

What if she forgot her lines?

What if she spoke too quickly?

What if the audition panel asked her to perform a scene she didn't understand?

What if she arrived and discovered that everybody else had graduated from an acting academy in London, New York, and Wakanda?

She sat up and rubbed her face.

"God, please."

Her phone lit up.

A message from Vikksy.

VIKKSY: Good morning, superstar.

Cassandra smiled despite herself.

CASSANDRA: Don't start.

VIKKSY: Have you practised?

CASSANDRA: Yes.

VIKKSY: How many times?

CASSANDRA: Enough.

VIKKSY: That is not a number.

CASSANDRA: Why are you behaving like my lecturer?

VIKKSY: Because your lecturer is not currently available to disturb you.

Cassandra laughed.

VIKKSY: Send me a voice note of the monologue.

She hesitated, then recorded herself performing the piece.

She sent it.

A few minutes later, her phone rang.

"Good morning," Vikksy said.

"Good morning."

"I listened to it."

"And?"

"You have a good foundation. Your delivery is natural, and you understand the emotion. But you're rushing the middle."

Cassandra sat up straighter.

"Which part?"

"The moment where your character realises the other person isn't listening. You move straight into the next line. Give the emotion time to land."

She considered that.

"So I should pause?"

"Not because the script says you should pause. Pause because your character has something to process. There's a difference."

Cassandra opened her notebook and wrote it down.

Vikksy continued.

"Also, don't spend the entire audition trying to prove that you're a good actress. Focus on telling the story. If you believe the character, the audience has a better chance of believing her too."

Cassandra smiled.

"That was actually good advice."

"Actually?"

"Don't let it enter your head."

"Too late. My ego has already booked a flight."

She laughed.

They spent a few more minutes discussing the monologue.

Before ending the call, Vikksy added, "And Cassandra?"

"Yes?"

"Don't compare yourself with the other applicants. You don't know what they can do, and they don't know what you can do. Concentrate on your own performance."

She nodded, even though he couldn't see her.

"Okay."

"Go there. Do your best. Learn whatever you need to learn. The outcome is important, but it doesn't determine your worth."

Cassandra was quiet for a moment.

"Thank you."

"Now go and become famous so I can start charging people for motivational speeches."

She laughed.

"Goodbye, Vikksy."

"Goodbye, madam."

The call ended.

Cassandra looked at her notes.

She was still nervous.

But now she had something to do with the nervousness.

She could prepare.

She could focus.

She could show up.

And that was enough to begin.

SCENE TWO: THE ARRIVAL OF THE BUSINESS ADMINISTRATION MINISTER

By 8:10 a.m., Cassandra had dressed, packed her things, and checked the audition address so many times that her phone probably thought she was planning to build a house there.

Her outfit was elegant without being excessive.

She wanted to look professional, not as though she had mistaken the audition for a luxury fashion campaign.

She checked herself in the mirror.

Adjusted her hair.

Checked again.

Then she heard a knock.

She opened the door.

Rebecca stood outside, dressed for her own day of lectures, carrying a bag and wearing the expression of a woman who had travelled to deliver important national news.

"Cassandra!"

Cassandra stared at her.

"What are you doing here?"

"Supporting my best friend."

"Your first lecture is in less than an hour."

"I have checked my timetable."

"And?"

"I have made peace with my academic consequences."

Cassandra burst out laughing.

Rebecca walked in and looked her over.

She circled her once.

"Turn around."

Cassandra turned.

"Good."

"Thank you, fashion police."

Rebecca adjusted a small detail near Cassandra's shoulder.

"You look beautiful. Professional. Confident. Like someone who knows what she's doing."

Cassandra smiled.

"Thank you."

Rebecca stepped back.

"Now, if they don't give you the role, I will need a detailed explanation."

"Rebecca."

"What?"

"They don't owe me a role."

"Fine. Then I will request a meeting with management."

"Please don't."

"I will arrive with documents."

Cassandra laughed.

Rebecca grinned.

Then her expression softened.

"Seriously, babe. I'm happy for you."

Cassandra hugged her.

"Thank you for coming."

"Anytime."

They separated.

Rebecca checked her phone.

"I should go before my lecturer begins to wonder whether I have withdrawn from school."

"Good idea."

Rebecca walked toward the door, then stopped.

"One more thing."

Cassandra sighed.

"What now?"

"When you become famous, I want a management position."

"You study Business Administration."

"Exactly. I'm qualified."

"You haven't graduated."

"Neither have you."

Cassandra stared at her.

Rebecca smiled sweetly.

"See you later, superstar."

She left before Cassandra could respond.

Cassandra shook her head, laughing.

For all Rebecca's nonsense, her presence had helped.

The room no longer felt quite so intimidating.

Cassandra picked up her bag and headed out.

Today, she was going to audition.

And for the first time, she was beginning to believe she might actually be ready.

SCENE THREE: WELCOME TO THE WAITING ROOM OF DESTINY

The production company had rented a modern office space in Lagos for the auditions.

By the time Cassandra arrived, the waiting area was already crowded.

Young men and women sat along the walls, rehearsing monologues, adjusting outfits, and occasionally staring into the middle distance with the intense expression of people who had just remembered every mistake they had ever made.

A young man near the entrance was practising a dramatic speech.

"YOU CANNOT TAKE MY CHILDREN FROM ME!"

He pointed at an imaginary opponent.

A receptionist looked up from her computer.

"Sir, this is an audition for a romantic comedy."

The young man lowered his hand.

"Yes, ma'am."

He glanced at his script.

"I am demonstrating emotional range."

"Please demonstrate it quietly."

Cassandra pressed her lips together to keep from laughing.

She checked in at the reception desk and was given a number.

AUDITION NUMBER 17.

She looked at it.

Seventeen.

Not too bad.

She could handle seventeen.

She sat down and began reviewing her monologue.

A few seats away, a young woman was practising a romantic scene with a friend.

Another applicant was recording herself on her phone.

A young man in a perfectly tailored suit sat with his legs crossed, looking as though he had already negotiated his first international contract.

Cassandra tried not to compare herself with anybody.

Then the receptionist called out, "Applicant number six!"

A young man stood up.

Before entering the audition room, he turned to the other applicants.

"Wish me luck."

"Good luck," several people replied.

He nodded solemnly.

"If I don't come back, tell my story."

Cassandra laughed.

The door closed behind him.

A few minutes later, he returned.

He was smiling.

"How was it?" somebody asked.

He sat down.

"They asked me to introduce myself."

"And?"

"I forgot my surname."

The waiting room erupted.

Cassandra laughed so hard she nearly dropped her script.

The young man raised a hand.

"Please, don't judge me. Pressure is a wicked thing."

"What's your surname?" somebody asked.

He stared at them.

"Give me a moment."

More laughter.

Cassandra felt some of her nervousness dissolve.

These were ordinary people trying to do something extraordinary.

Some were talented.

Some were nervous.

Some were probably reconsidering every decision that had led them to the waiting room.

But they had all shown up.

And so had she.

A production assistant approached.

"Applicant number seventeen?"

Cassandra stood.

"Yes."

"Please follow me."

She took a breath, straightened her shoulders, and followed the assistant toward the audition room.

Her heart was beating faster now.

This was it.

The first real test.

SCENE FOUR: THE PANEL

The audition room was bright and spacious.

A camera stood on a tripod near the centre. Several chairs had been arranged opposite a long table.

Three people sat behind it.

At the centre was Amara Okafor.

To her right sat a casting director named **Tunde Balogun**, a veteran professional with an observant gaze and a reputation for spotting performances that others overlooked.

To her left sat **Mrs. Bisi Akinola**, the film's director, who had a notebook open in front of her.

Amara looked up as Cassandra entered.

For a moment, recognition flickered across her face.

"The student from yesterday."

Cassandra smiled politely.

"Good morning, ma."

"Good morning, Cassandra. Please, have a seat."

Cassandra sat.

Tunde checked the application form.

"You're a 200-level Film and Multimedia student at Pan-Atlantic University?"

"Yes, sir."

"Have you acted professionally before?"

"No, sir. I've participated in student productions and practical exercises, but this would be my first professional film role."

Mrs. Bisi nodded.

"Why do you want to act?"

Cassandra had prepared an answer.

She had practised it in front of the mirror.

She had discussed it with Vikksy.

She had rewritten it twice.

But now, sitting in front of the panel, she decided not to recite it word for word.

"I love the way acting allows people to experience lives beyond their own," she began. "A good performance can make someone laugh, understand another person's perspective, or feel less alone. I want to tell stories that people can connect with. And I want to keep learning until I become good enough to tell those stories properly."

Mrs. Bisi studied her.

"Good enough?"

Cassandra smiled.

"I don't think an actor ever finishes learning, ma."

Amara exchanged a brief glance with Tunde.

"Interesting answer," he said.

He gestured toward the camera.

"Whenever you're ready, you may begin your monologue."

Cassandra stood.

She took her position.

For a moment, she looked at the camera.

Then she let herself settle into the character.

The monologue began quietly.

Her character was a young woman who had spent years trying to prove herself to someone she loved. She had always been the dependable one, the forgiving one, the person who accepted disappointment and pretended it didn't hurt.

Now, for the first time, she was choosing to stand up for herself.

Cassandra spoke.

At first, her voice was gentle.

Then her words grew firmer.

"You keep telling me to be patient. To wait. To understand. To give you more time."

She paused.

"But when I ask you to believe in me, suddenly I'm asking for too much."

The room was silent.

Cassandra looked down, gathering herself.

"I don't need you to promise me that everything will work out. I don't even need you to understand every dream I have."

She looked up.

"I just need you to stop making me feel foolish for having them."

The final words came softly.

Not as an accusation.

As a truth the character had been afraid to admit.

Cassandra allowed the silence to remain for a moment.

Then she lowered her gaze.

The monologue ended.

Nobody spoke immediately.

Cassandra's heart hammered against her ribs.

She had finished.

She hadn't forgotten her lines.

She hadn't fainted.

As far as she knew, she hadn't committed any crimes against cinema.

Tunde made a note.

Mrs. Bisi leaned forward.

"Thank you, Cassandra."

Cassandra nodded.

"Thank you, ma."

Amara smiled.

"That was good."

Cassandra tried not to look too relieved.

"Thank you, ma."

"But I want to try something."

Cassandra straightened.

"Yes, ma?"

"Your monologue was emotionally controlled. You understand the character. Now I'd like to see how you handle a different direction."

Amara glanced at Mrs. Bisi.

"Can we try the café scene?"

Mrs. Bisi smiled.

"Absolutely."

Cassandra blinked.

"The café scene, ma?"

"The one in the script where the character discovers that her date has been lying to impress her."

Cassandra hadn't prepared that scene.

Naturally.

Because why would life allow a person to prepare for one thing without immediately introducing another thing?

Mrs. Bisi handed her a few pages.

"Take a minute to read it."

Cassandra scanned the scene.

Her character was meeting a young man who had exaggerated almost everything about himself. He had claimed to own a luxury car, know several celebrities, and have connections in the film industry.

Unfortunately, the truth was considerably less impressive.

The character was supposed to discover the lies gradually, then confront him with a mixture of disbelief, amusement, and genuine curiosity.

Cassandra looked at the pages again.

Then she smiled.

This was something she could enjoy.

Mrs. Bisi called for an assistant to read the other character's lines.

A young production assistant stepped forward.

He looked at Cassandra.

"Ready?"

Cassandra nodded.

"Ready."

The scene began.

The assistant delivered his first line with exaggerated confidence.

"I don't usually come to places like this."

Cassandra looked around the room, then back at him.

"Really? Because you seem very comfortable."

He smiled.

"Well, I know the owner."

Cassandra's eyebrows rose slightly.

"Interesting. What's his name?"

The assistant hesitated.

Cassandra waited.

He cleared his throat.

"He's a very private person."

Cassandra nodded slowly.

"Of course."

She glanced at the imaginary menu.

"And does this very private person know that you're using his name to get free water?"

A laugh escaped Tunde before he could stop himself.

Cassandra continued, playing the scene naturally.

She wasn't forcing jokes.

She was listening, reacting, and allowing the character's intelligence to come through.

When the assistant claimed to have driven there in a luxury car, Cassandra looked toward the imaginary window.

"Where is it?"

"Where's what?"

"The car."

He hesitated.

"Parking."

Cassandra smiled.

"Wonderful. What's the registration number?"

He stared at her.

She nodded sympathetically.

"Take your time. Luxury vehicles have very complicated numbers."

The room laughed.

Even Mrs. Bisi covered her mouth.

Cassandra delivered the final line with a perfectly measured expression.

"You know, I was prepared to forgive you for lying about the car. But pretending to know the owner of a restaurant where you're asking me to buy your drink? That's a level of ambition I almost respect."

The assistant broke character and laughed.

Cassandra laughed too.

Mrs. Bisi clapped once.

"Good."

Tunde leaned back.

"Very good."

Cassandra tried to keep her face composed.

Inside, however, she was celebrating.

She had made them laugh.

She had enjoyed herself.

And she had discovered something important.

She didn't have to become a different person to be a good actress.

Her own sense of humour, her observations, and her natural reactions could become strengths when she learned how to use them.

SCENE FIVE: THE QUESTION SHE DIDN'T EXPECT

After the second scene, Amara asked Cassandra to sit again.

"Tell me something," she said. "If you don't get this role, what will you do?"

Cassandra considered the question.

"I'll be disappointed, ma."

Amara nodded.

"Understandable."

"But I'll continue practising and auditioning. I'll ask for feedback if it's available, and I'll work on whatever I need to improve."

"Even if it takes years?"

Cassandra smiled.

"I hope it doesn't take years."

The panel laughed.

"But yes, ma. I want to become an actress. I know one audition won't determine my future."

Amara watched her carefully.

"And if you do get the role?"

Cassandra's smile widened.

"Then I'll work very hard not to disappoint you."

Tunde chuckled.

"Good answer."

Mrs. Bisi closed her notebook.

"Thank you, Cassandra. We've seen what we need to see for today."

Cassandra stood.

"Thank you for the opportunity, ma. Thank you, sirs."

She turned toward the door.

Then Amara spoke again.

"Cassandra?"

She turned back.

"Yes, ma?"

"Don't stop acting."

Cassandra's expression softened.

Amara smiled.

"You have something worth developing. Keep working on it."

For a moment, Cassandra forgot to respond.

Then she nodded.

"Thank you, ma. I will."

She left the room.

The door closed behind her.

And only then did she allow herself to exhale.

She had done it.

She had actually done it.

Whether she got the role or not, she had walked into the room, performed, listened to feedback, and given herself a chance.

That was already more than the frightened version of herself had believed possible.

SCENE SIX: THE WAITING GAME

Cassandra returned to the waiting area.

The young man who had forgotten his surname was still there.

He looked up.

"How did it go?"

Cassandra smiled.

"I think it went well."

"Did they ask you your surname?"

She laughed.

"Yes."

"Did you remember it?"

"Thankfully."

He nodded solemnly.

"Then you've already done better than me."

Cassandra sat down to wait for the next instruction.

She checked her phone.

There were messages from Sarah, John, and Rebecca.

SARAH: How did it go???

JOHN: Give us the full report.

ABIODUN: I hope my acting inspiration helped.

CASSANDRA: Your acting inspiration nearly got us expelled from the national film industry.

ABIODUN: So you're saying I made an impact.

CASSANDRA: I'm saying you need help.

A message from Rebecca appeared.

REBECCA: BESTIE. STATUS REPORT.

CASSANDRA: I'm done with the audition.

REBECCA: AND?

CASSANDRA: I think it went well.

REBECCA: I KNEW IT.

REBECCA: BUSINESS ADMINISTRATION NEVER LIES.

CASSANDRA: How does that even relate?

REBECCA: IT DOESN'T. I'M CELEBRATING.

Cassandra laughed.

Then she sent a voice note to Vikksy, explaining how the audition had gone.

His reply arrived a few minutes later.

VIKKSY: I'm proud of you.

Cassandra smiled.

CASSANDRA: Even if I don't get the role?

VIKKSY: Especially then. You showed up, prepared, and performed. Whatever happens next, you now have experience you didn't have yesterday.

She read the message twice.

Then another arrived.

VIKKSY: But if you get it, remember that your unofficial manager is available for negotiations.

CASSANDRA: You're not negotiating anything.

VIKKSY: We will discuss this at the next board meeting.

Cassandra shook her head, laughing.

She put her phone away and looked around the waiting room.

Some applicants were leaving.

Others were still waiting.

The atmosphere was filled with nervous anticipation.

She wondered how many of them had dreamed about this moment for years.

How many had told their families they wanted to act, only to be told to find something more practical.

How many were quietly hoping that today might be the beginning of something wonderful.

She couldn't know.

But she hoped they would all find their opportunities.

Her phone vibrated again.

This time, it was a message from the production assistant.

PRODUCTION TEAM: Thank you for attending today's audition. Selected applicants will be contacted directly.

Cassandra read it.

Then she leaned back in her chair.

The audition was over.

Now came the waiting.

And if there was one thing Cassandra had learned from university life, it was that waiting for important news could make five minutes feel like an entire semester.

SCENE SEVEN: THE CALL

That evening, Cassandra was back at the hostel.

She had changed into comfortable clothes and was sitting with her phone, trying to concentrate on an assignment.

Trying being the important word.

She had reread the same paragraph six times.

Her mind kept returning to the audition.

Had she paused long enough during the monologue?

Had the panel liked the café scene?

Had she spoken too quickly?

Had she looked confident?

Had she looked too confident?

Was there such a thing as looking too confident?

She put her phone down.

Then picked it up.

Then put it down again.

"Cassandra," she told herself, "you need to calm down."

Her phone rang.

An unfamiliar number.

She stared at it.

Her heart began beating faster.

She answered.

"Hello?"

"Good evening. Am I speaking with Cassandra?"

"Yes, please."

"Good evening. My name is Tunde Balogun. I'm calling from Amara Okafor Productions."

Cassandra sat upright.

"Good evening, sir."

"I'm calling regarding your audition today."

She gripped the edge of her bed.

"Yes, sir."

"We've reviewed the performances, and the team would like to invite you for a callback tomorrow."

Cassandra blinked.

"A callback, sir?"

"Yes. We'd like you to read for one of the principal roles. The director was impressed with your performance, and Ms. Okafor would like to see more of your range."

For a moment, Cassandra couldn't speak.

Then she managed, "Thank you, sir. Thank you very much."

"We'll send you the details shortly. Please confirm your availability."

"Yes, sir. I'll be available."

"Excellent. Have a good evening."

The call ended.

Cassandra stared at her phone.

She had received a callback.

A real callback.

She wasn't being offered the role yet, but she had made it to the next stage.

She had another chance.

Another opportunity to show what she could do.

Then she screamed.

Not a polite scream.

Not a small, dignified sound.

A full, unfiltered scream that made someone in the neighbouring room shout, "WHO DIED?"

Cassandra immediately covered her mouth.

"Nobody!"

"THEN WHY ARE YOU SHOUTING?"

"I GOT A CALLBACK!"

There was a pause.

Then a voice shouted back, "CONGRATULATIONS!"

Cassandra burst into laughter.

She grabbed her phone and called Rebecca.

Rebecca answered on the first ring.

"WHAT HAPPENED?"

Cassandra was still laughing.

"I got a callback!"

Silence.

Then Rebecca screamed so loudly that Cassandra had to move the phone away from her ear.

"MY BEST FRIEND IS GOING TO BE FAMOUS!"

"Rebecca!"

"I'M SERIOUS!"

"I KNOW!"

"DO YOU KNOW WHAT THIS MEANS?"

"What?"

"IT MEANS I'M GOING TO NEED TO START DRESSING LIKE SOMEBODY WHO HAS ACCESS TO CELEBRITIES!"

Cassandra laughed until tears came to her eyes.

Rebecca continued.

"Wait. Let me call Vikksy."

"Why?"

"Because this is an emergency."

"Rebecca, it is not an emergency."

"It is a national celebration."

Before Cassandra could object, Rebecca ended the call.

A few seconds later, her phone rang again.

This time, it was a group call.

Rebecca had added Vikksy.

He answered.

"Hello?"

Rebecca immediately launched into her greeting.

"YO, NIGGA! HOW YOU DOIN'?"

Vikksy responded without missing a beat.

"YOOOO! WHAT'S GOOD, MY BROTHER?"

Cassandra covered her face.

"Both of you, please."

Rebecca continued.

"OUR GIRL GOT A CALLBACK!"

Vikksy paused.

Then his voice changed.

"She did?"

Cassandra smiled.

"Yes."

For a moment, nobody made a joke.

Then Vikksy said, "Cassandra, that's wonderful. I'm really proud of you."

Her smile softened.

"Thank you."

Rebecca broke the silence.

"Now, as the official Business Administration representative, I would like to propose a strategic celebration."

Vikksy nodded solemnly, though Cassandra could only hear him.

"Approved."

Cassandra groaned.

"What celebration?"

Rebecca answered immediately.

"Food."

Vikksy added, "That is a reasonable proposal."

"You people have no shame."

Rebecca gasped.

"Excuse me. We are celebrating your professional advancement."

"With my money?"

A pause.

Vikksy cleared his throat.

"The board is currently reviewing the budget."

Cassandra burst out laughing.

For the next several minutes, the three of them joked about Cassandra's future celebrity status, Rebecca's proposed management position, and Vikksy's demand for an official title.

But beneath the humour was something genuine.

They were happy for her.

They knew how much the opportunity meant.

They understood that a callback wasn't a guarantee, but they also knew that it represented progress.

Cassandra had taken a chance.

She had worked for it.

And now, another door had opened.

When the call ended, Cassandra sat quietly for a moment.

She looked at the callback message that had just arrived.

Tomorrow.

Another audition.

A principal role.

She smiled.

Then she opened her notebook and wrote a new heading.

CALLBACK PREPARATION.

Underneath it, she added:

1. Read the new scenes carefully.
2. Practise different emotional interpretations.
3. Listen to Vikksy's advice.
4. Let Rebecca choose the outfit, but retain final authority.
5. Do not allow Abiodun to supervise anything.
6. Celebrate after the work is done.

She paused.

Then added a seventh point.

7. Remember that this is only the beginning.

Outside, the university continued its usual evening rhythm. Students moved between buildings, voices drifted across the compound, and somebody somewhere was almost certainly arguing about an assignment.

Cassandra looked out into the evening.

She had not become a superstar overnight.

She had not landed a major film role.

She had not walked a red carpet or heard her name announced at an international awards ceremony.

Not yet.

But she had taken the first step.

And then another.

Tomorrow, she would return to the audition room.

This time, she would walk in knowing that somebody had seen something in her worth exploring.

For tonight, that was enough.

Cassandra smiled, picked up her script, and began reading.

Her dream was getting closer.

And the world was only just beginning to notice.

END OF CHAPTER TWO

CASSANDRA: BORN TO BE A STAR

CHAPTER THREE: THE CALLBACK THAT ALMOST CALLED HER BLUFF

By Thursday morning, Cassandra had discovered something deeply unfair about pursuing a dream.

The closer you got to it, the more opportunities it found to embarrass you.

For instance, she had spent the previous night rehearsing her audition scenes until she could perform them in her sleep. Unfortunately, she had also slept so little that she was beginning to suspect her brain had filed a formal complaint against her.

She sat on her bed at the hostel, staring at the printed callback notice on her phone.

CALLBACK AUDITION: FRIDAY, 10:00 A.M.

She read it again.

Then a third time.

Then she checked the sender's name, just in case the entertainment industry had accidentally invited somebody's auntie.

No mistake.

She had made it to the callback.

"Jesus," she whispered.

Her phone rang.

Rebecca.

Cassandra answered on video call.

Rebecca's face appeared on the screen. She was in her own hostel building, looking suspiciously well-rested for somebody who had a Business Administration assignment due.

"Good morning, future celebrity!"

"Please, I'm trying to concentrate."

"Concentrate on what? The fact that you're about to become famous or the fact that you still owe me that biscuit?"

"Rebecca!"

"What? Fame doesn't cancel debt. Ask any bank."

Cassandra laughed despite herself.

Rebecca leaned closer to the camera.

"Have you read the callback message properly?"

"About fifteen times."

"Good. Read it sixteen times. Maybe the seventeenth reading will reveal your salary."

"They haven't even given me the role!"

"Details. Details. You're already negotiating with the future."

Cassandra shook her head.

"You're not a serious person."

"And yet you keep me around. This is a powerful endorsement of my brand."

They laughed.

Then Rebecca's expression softened.

"I'm proud of you, Cass."

Cassandra stopped smiling quite so widely.

"Thank you."

"No, I'm serious. You've talked about acting for so long. You've done the work, you've applied, and now you're getting another chance. Whatever happens tomorrow, don't start acting like you need permission to dream."

For a moment, Cassandra had nothing clever to say.

That was how she knew Rebecca meant it.

Then Rebecca ruined the emotional moment by adding, "But if you become famous and start pretending you don't know me, I'll release our old hostel pictures."

Cassandra gasped.

"You wouldn't dare."

"I have evidence. Multiple angles."

"That's blackmail!"

"That's friendship with excellent record-keeping."

THE UNOFFICIAL MANAGEMENT DEPARTMENT

Later that afternoon, Cassandra called Vikksy.

He answered with the solemnity of a man who had apparently been waiting all day for a very important business meeting.

"Good afternoon, Miss Cassandra. Thank you for contacting Vikksy Management Services. We specialize in talent development, emotional support, and preventing clients from making foolish decisions."

"How many clients do you have?"

"One."

"And how many have paid you?"

"Let's not allow money to damage this beautiful professional relationship."

Cassandra laughed.

"Are you coming to help me rehearse?"

"That's why I picked up. Bring the callback scenes. We'll work through them."

They met later to practice.

Vikksy had studied the material Cassandra sent him. He had even written notes.

Cassandra stared at the paper in his hand.

"You actually prepared?"

He looked offended.

"What did you think I was going to do? Arrive and offer motivational quotes from the internet?"

"I thought you'd tell me to believe in myself."

"I can do both. I'm a complete service provider."

He handed her the notes.

The callback involved a scene from the romantic comedy Cassandra had auditioned for. Her character, **Maya**, was a young woman who had spent years trying to be the responsible one in her family. She was funny, ambitious, and excellent at pretending she had everything under control.

Unfortunately, Maya's carefully organized life was about to collide with the most disorganized man she had ever met.

His name was **Daniel**, and he was played by a character whose confidence was inversely proportional to his ability to plan anything.

Cassandra was being considered for the lead role of Maya.

The callback scene took place in a small café. Maya had arranged to meet Daniel to discuss a business opportunity. Daniel arrived late, carrying a box of cupcakes that he had accidentally sat on.

Vikksy read Daniel's lines.

"Maya, before you say anything, I can explain."

Cassandra, in character, folded her arms.

"Daniel, the last time you said that, you explained how a grown man could lose his own shoes while wearing them."

Vikksy looked down at the script.

"That's actually a good line."

"It's in the script."

"I know. I'm appreciating the writer."

They continued.

Vikksy stumbled over a sentence.

Cassandra stopped.

"Again."

He tried it again.

"Again."

"Cassandra, I am your acting coach, not a rechargeable fan. You cannot keep pressing the same button and expect unlimited performance."

"Then perform better."

He stared at her.

She stared back.

Then both of them burst out laughing.

After they recovered, Vikksy became serious.

"There's something I noticed during your first audition. You were good when the scene was emotional. But when you tried to be funny, you sometimes looked like you were waiting for people to laugh."

"Is that bad?"

"Not necessarily. But comedy is strange. If you tell a joke and then look at the audience to ask whether it was funny, you've already weakened it. Trust the line. Trust the moment. Let the audience catch up."

Cassandra thought about that.

"So I shouldn't try so hard to be funny?"

"Exactly. Your character isn't standing there thinking, 'I am now going to entertain the audience.' She's trying to deal with an impossible man. The funny part is that she's taking the situation seriously."

Cassandra nodded.

That made sense.

They rehearsed again.

This time, she stopped performing the jokes and started reacting to Daniel as Maya would. Her expressions became more natural. Her pauses felt less rehearsed. Even Vikksy began laughing at moments he hadn't expected.

When they finished, he lowered the script.

"That's it."

"Really?"

"Yes. I have officially exhausted my wisdom for the week."

"That didn't take long."

"Quality wisdom. Limited supply."

She smiled.

"Thank you, Vikksy."

"You're welcome. Tomorrow, go in there and do your best. Don't try to impress them with how much you want the role. Show them why you're right for it."

Cassandra held his gaze for a moment.

There was no romance hidden in the moment, no secret wish for their relationship to become something else. They had shared too much life to need that kind of confusion. Their bond had changed shape, but the care underneath it remained.

He was someone she could call when she needed advice, when something wonderful happened, or when the world became too heavy.

And he was rooting for her.

Not because he expected anything in return.

Because he genuinely wanted her to win.

"Now," he said, breaking the silence, "please become famous quickly. My unofficial management company needs better office furniture."

Cassandra threw a cushion at him.

FRIDAY: THE ROOM WHERE DREAMS WORE FORMAL SHOES

At 9:42 a.m., Cassandra stood outside the audition room at Amara Okafor Productions.

She had arrived early.

Very early.

Early enough to witness a security guard finish his breakfast, discuss football with another guard, and begin a second conversation about the first conversation.

She checked her phone.

9:43 a.m.

Seventeen minutes.

Her stomach performed a movement that was probably illegal in several countries.

Sarah arrived first, sending a quick message to wish her luck. John followed with a voice note that began with three seconds of silence and ended with him shouting, "GO AND COLLECT YOUR DESTINY!"

Abiodun sent a message:

ABIODUN: If you become famous, please remember that I once acted opposite you.

CASSANDRA: You forgot your line.

ABIODUN: Great actors create unforgettable moments.

CASSANDRA: You said "your cooking" during a breakup scene.

ABIODUN: And you still remember it. Case closed.

Cassandra laughed so hard that another applicant looked at her with concern.

"Are you okay?"

"Yes."

"You look nervous."

"I'm fine."

"You just laughed like someone who has seen the future."

Cassandra glanced at the message again.

"Something like that."

At 10:03 a.m., an assistant opened the door.

"Cassandra?"

She stood immediately.

"Yes."

"Please come in."

Her heart began behaving like it had somewhere else to be.

Inside, the room was brighter than she expected. Three people sat behind a table: Amara Okafor, the producer; Tunde Balogun, the casting director; and Mrs. Bisi Akinola, the film's director.

A camera stood near the window.

Amara smiled.

"Good morning, Cassandra. How are you feeling?"

"Good morning, ma. I'm feeling prepared."

Tunde glanced at the notes in front of him.

"Prepared?"

Cassandra paused.

"Mostly prepared, sir."

Mrs. Bisi laughed.

"Honesty. That's a useful beginning."

Amara gestured toward a chair.

"Let's talk about Maya. What do you understand about her?"

Cassandra sat.

She had prepared an answer, but suddenly the rehearsed words felt too small.

"Maya wants to be independent," she began. "But I don't think independence is the same as never needing anybody. I think she's tired of being the person who solves everything for everyone else. She wants a life of her own, but she doesn't quite know how to ask for it without feeling guilty."

The room became quiet.

Amara leaned forward.

"Interesting. What makes you say she feels guilty?"

"Because whenever someone asks her what she wants, she changes the subject. She can explain everybody else's problems, but she struggles to talk about her own. I think she's afraid that if she chooses herself, people will think she's selfish."

Mrs. Bisi exchanged a glance with Tunde.

"That's a thoughtful interpretation," the director said. "Now, let's see what you do with it."

They asked Cassandra to perform the café scene.

She took a breath.

The camera began recording.

And suddenly, the room disappeared.

She was Maya.

She was sitting across from Daniel, a man who had arrived late to an important meeting with a box of crushed cupcakes and the confidence of someone who believed punctuality was a conspiracy invented by boring people.

Cassandra delivered her lines.

She didn't rush.

She let the irritation build naturally. When Daniel offered a ridiculous excuse, she stared at him with the exhausted patience of a woman who had already forgiven him for three things he hadn't admitted to yet.

The panel laughed.

Not politely.

Genuinely.

Cassandra continued.

Then Mrs. Bisi stopped her.

"Good. Now let's change something."

Cassandra waited.

"Imagine Daniel has just told Maya that he used the money she gave him for their business meeting to buy a birthday gift for his mother. He thinks this proves he's a good person. Maya is furious, but she doesn't want to hurt him. Play that."

Cassandra blinked.

That was not in the script.

"Should I use the same lines?"

"Forget the lines," Mrs. Bisi said. "Just be Maya."

Cassandra nodded.

She imagined Maya looking at Daniel.

A man who was impossible.

A man who was careless.

A man who somehow believed that good intentions could repair every terrible decision.

She began.

"Daniel, I gave you that money because I trusted you."

She paused.

"I thought we were building something together. I thought, for once, I didn't have to be the only person in the room who understood that tomorrow exists."

Tunde stopped writing.

Cassandra continued.

"And your mother deserves a beautiful birthday. She does. But you don't get to use someone else's future to prove that you have a good heart."

The room was silent.

For a moment, Cassandra felt the weight of the words herself.

Then she let the anger soften.

"You're a good person, Daniel. I know that. But being a good person doesn't mean you can keep making bad decisions and asking everybody else to admire your intentions."

Mrs. Bisi raised a hand.

"Hold it there."

Cassandra stopped.

The director studied her.

"That was very good."

Cassandra tried not to react too quickly.

Amara smiled.

"You found something truthful in that scene. That's what we need."

Tunde closed his folder.

"We have one final question. Why should we cast you?"

Cassandra's mind went blank.

For one horrifying second, she considered saying, *Because I am available and transport was expensive.*

Instead, she took a breath.

"Because I understand Maya's contradictions. She can be strong and still be afraid. She can love people and still need boundaries. She can make mistakes and still deserve another chance. I don't want to play her as a perfect woman. I want to play her as someone people recognize."

Nobody spoke immediately.

Then Mrs. Bisi nodded.

"Thank you, Cassandra."

The audition was over.

She walked out of the room feeling as if she had left a piece of herself behind.

Outside, she checked her phone.

A message from Rebecca appeared.

REBECCA: HOW DID IT GO?

Cassandra typed.

Deleted it.

Typed again.

CASSANDRA: I THINK IT WENT WELL.

Rebecca replied almost instantly.

REBECCA: WHAT DO YOU MEAN, YOU THINK? DID YOU ACT OR DID YOU GO THERE TO INSPECT THE AIR CONDITIONER?

Cassandra laughed.

CASSANDRA: I ACTED!

REBECCA: THAT'S MY GIRL.

Then came another message.

REBECCA: I'M PRAYING FOR YOU. ALSO, IF THEY GIVE YOU THE ROLE, PLEASE REMEMBER THAT I SUPPORTED YOU BEFORE YOU HAD A PUBLICIST.

Cassandra smiled.

She sent a voice note to Vikksy.

"I think I did well. I really think I did well."

His reply came a few minutes later.

"Then celebrate that. You showed up, you prepared, and you gave them something honest. The result is their decision. The work was yours."

She listened to it twice.

Then she put her phone away and stepped outside into the Lagos sunshine.

She didn't have the role yet.

But for the first time, the dream didn't feel like something she was watching from a distance.

It felt like a door.

And someone had finally opened it.

THE CALL

The call came on Monday afternoon.

Cassandra was sitting with Sarah and John after a lecture when her phone began ringing.

Unknown number.

She stared at it.

Sarah noticed.

"Answer it."

"What if it's a bank?"

"Then tell them your account is also pursuing its dreams."

John nodded solemnly.

"Every great actor must face their greatest fear."

"Which is?"

"Unknown callers."

Cassandra answered.

"Hello?"

"Good afternoon. Am I speaking with Cassandra?"

"Yes, ma."

"This is Amara Okafor Productions. We would like to offer you the role of Maya in our upcoming romantic comedy, *Almost on Purpose*."

Cassandra stopped breathing.

Not permanently, thankfully. That would have made the paperwork difficult.

"I'm sorry," she said. "Could you please repeat that?"

The woman on the phone laughed.

"We'd like you to play Maya. We'd like you to join the cast."

Cassandra pressed her free hand against her mouth.

"Yes. Yes, ma. Thank you so much. Thank you."

They discussed the next steps: a meeting, the script, rehearsal dates, and the contract. She listened carefully, asked the questions she needed to ask, and wrote everything down.

When the call ended, she stared at the screen.

Sarah leaned forward.

"Cass?"

Cassandra looked up.

"They gave me the role."

John shot to his feet.

"WHAT?"

Heads turned across the courtyard.

Cassandra laughed and covered her face.

Sarah grabbed her in a hug.

John began celebrating as if Cassandra had personally won Nigeria the World Cup.

Within minutes, Rebecca had been called. Then Vikksy. Then Abiodun, who answered the phone with the words, "I knew it!"

"You knew nothing!" Cassandra shouted.

"I had a strong suspicion."

"You said I should remember you if I became famous!"

"Exactly. I was preparing for this moment."

Rebecca's voice cut through the call.

"Everybody be quiet. The star needs to speak."

Cassandra laughed.

Then, suddenly, she became quiet.

She looked at her friends. At the university buildings. At the students passing by, unaware that one of the biggest moments of her life had just happened on an ordinary afternoon.

"I'm going to be in a movie," she whispered.

Sarah squeezed her hand.

"Yes, you are."

Cassandra looked up at the sky.

For years, acting had been a dream she carried around carefully, afraid that if she spoke about it too loudly, someone would remind her how difficult it was.

Now it had a title.

A production company.

A contract waiting to be reviewed.

And a start date.

She had taken her first real step into the world she wanted.

She was still a student.

Still a mother.

Still Cassandra.

But now, when someone asked what she wanted to become, she had something new to say.

She was already on her way.

CHAPTER FOUR: WELCOME TO THE MOVIE INDUSTRY, PLEASE MIND THE CABLES

Cassandra signed her first acting contract on Wednesday.

Before signing it, she read every page.

Then she read the pages again.

Then she called Vikksy.

"Please explain this clause to me."

He listened as she read it aloud.

"That sounds like a usage-rights clause," he said. "But don't rely on my interpretation alone. Ask the production team to explain exactly what rights they're requesting, especially regarding promotional material and future use of your performance. If anything is unclear, get professional advice before signing."

Cassandra looked at the contract.

"You sound like a lawyer."

"Thank you. My hourly rate is one plate of jollof rice."

"You're not getting paid."

"Then I withdraw my legal services."

She laughed, but she took his advice seriously.

The production team answered her questions. She understood the agreement, reviewed the final version, and signed.

Her name appeared beneath the signature line.

CASSANDRA.

It looked ordinary on paper.

But she stared at it for a long time.

A signature was such a small thing to carry such a large feeling.

THE FIRST DAY

The first day of filming began at 6:30 a.m.

Cassandra arrived at the location at 6:12 a.m.

She had set three alarms, asked Rebecca to call her, and placed her phone far enough from the bed that she had to stand up to turn it off.

She had also gone to sleep wearing the expression of someone preparing for a national examination.

By 6:30, she had already been welcomed by the assistant director, given a call sheet, shown the wardrobe area, and introduced to seven people whose names she immediately forgot.

The assistant director, a brisk woman named **Kemi**, handed her a schedule.

"Welcome to the production, Cassandra. This is your call sheet. It tells you where you need to be, when you need to be there, and what scenes we're filming."

Cassandra studied it.

"So it's like a timetable?"

"Exactly."

"Then why does it look like it was prepared by someone who has personal problems with sleep?"

Kemi laughed.

"Because film production is a team sport, and sleep is not on the team."

Cassandra glanced at the schedule again.

There were scene numbers, location details, wardrobe notes, and estimated shooting times.

"Do we actually finish when the schedule says we will?"

Kemi gave her a sympathetic look.

"You're adorable."

Cassandra decided not to ask any more questions.

She was taken to the makeup room, where a makeup artist named **Toyin** began preparing her for the first scene.

Toyin examined her face.

"You have beautiful features. We won't need to do too much."

"Thank you."

"Are you nervous?"

"A little."

"Good. It means you understand that this matters. Just don't let the nerves start making decisions for you."

Cassandra smiled.

"I'll tell them they're not on the payroll."

Toyin laughed.

As the makeup brushes moved across her face, Cassandra looked into the mirror.

She had imagined this moment so many times.

The makeup chair.

The wardrobe rack.

The people calling her name.

The strange feeling of being somewhere she had once only pictured.

She had expected to feel transformed.

Instead, she felt like herself.

Just a little more awake.

A little more frightened.

And a great deal more grateful.

MEETING DANIEL

Her co-star arrived twenty minutes later.

His name was **Tobi Adebayo**, a rising actor with several television appearances and a reputation for being charming without taking himself too seriously.

He entered the rehearsal area carrying a bottle of water and a notebook.

"You're Cassandra, right?"

She stood.

"Yes. Good morning."

"I'm Tobi. I'll be playing Daniel."

They shook hands.

He smiled.

"I've read the script. Daniel is a very interesting man."

Cassandra tilted her head.

"Interesting is one word for him."

"What's your word?"

"An administrative emergency."

Tobi burst out laughing.

"Excellent. We haven't even started filming and you're already insulting my character."

"I'm insulting Daniel. You seem innocent so far."

"Give it time."

They began rehearsing their first scene.

Daniel was supposed to arrive at a café late, carrying a ridiculous excuse for his lateness. Maya was meant to be annoyed, but not surprised.

Tobi delivered his first line with enormous confidence.

"Maya, before you say anything, I can explain."

Cassandra looked at him.

"Daniel, I haven't said anything."

"Your face has."

Cassandra's mouth twitched.

Tobi continued.

"And your face is a very aggressive public speaker."

Cassandra laughed.

The director, Mrs. Bisi Akinola, watched from a chair nearby.

"That was good," she said. "But let's not rush the scene. Cassandra, give us the feeling that Maya has already had this argument with Daniel six times. Tobi, your character genuinely believes he's being reasonable. That's what makes him dangerous."

Tobi placed a hand over his chest.

"I've never felt so attacked by a fictional character."

Mrs. Bisi smiled.

"Then you're already doing your job."

They rehearsed again.

This time, Cassandra let her irritation arrive slowly. She didn't force the joke. She allowed the silence to carry the frustration before delivering the line.

Tobi responded with a perfectly sincere expression.

The crew laughed.

Mrs. Bisi nodded.

"That's the rhythm. Trust each other. Comedy isn't just about saying funny things. It's about two people believing completely different things in the same situation."

Cassandra absorbed the lesson.

She was beginning to understand that acting was not simply memorizing words and making expressions.

It was listening.

Reacting.

Making imaginary circumstances feel real enough that strangers could recognize themselves inside them.

And, occasionally, trying not to laugh when your co-star looked at you like a man who had never successfully completed a plan in his life.

THE CASE OF THE MISSING CUPCAKES

The first scene was scheduled to begin at 9:00 a.m.

At 9:07, the cupcakes were missing.

They were important to the scene. Daniel was supposed to arrive with a box of cupcakes that had been crushed during his journey.

The props assistant had placed them on a table.

Then somebody moved the table.

Then somebody moved the box.

Then somebody remembered seeing a box near the wardrobe area.

The box near the wardrobe area contained cables.

By 9:15, three crew members were searching for cupcakes with the seriousness usually reserved for missing government documents.

Tobi stood beside Cassandra.

"I think this is a sign."

"Of what?"

"That Daniel's life is already falling apart."

Cassandra folded her arms.

"Daniel's life fell apart when he decided punctuality was optional."

Tobi nodded.

"Fair."

The props assistant finally returned, holding an empty box.

"Found it!"

Cassandra stared.

"Where are the cupcakes?"

The assistant hesitated.

"There's been a small development."

Mrs. Bisi looked up from her notes.

"Define small."

The assistant swallowed.

"Someone thought they were refreshments."

Silence.

Tobi slowly turned toward Cassandra.

"Well, Daniel has now eaten the evidence."

Cassandra burst out laughing.

Even Mrs. Bisi had to cover her mouth.

The production team eventually replaced the cupcakes. The scene started forty minutes late.

Cassandra learned her first important lesson about filmmaking:

The movie might be fictional.

The problems were extremely real.

ACTION!

When the cameras finally rolled, the entire atmosphere changed.

The assistant director called for quiet.

The camera operator checked the frame.

The sound recordist adjusted the microphone.

Mrs. Bisi took her position behind the monitor.

"Picture ready?"

"Ready."

"Sound?"

"Speed."

"Camera?"

"Rolling."

Mrs. Bisi raised her hand.

"Action!"

Cassandra became Maya.

Tobi became Daniel.

The crew disappeared from her awareness. The cables, lights, cameras, and people watching the scene faded into the background.

There was only Maya, sitting in a café, waiting for a man who had arrived late with crushed cupcakes and a terrible explanation.

Tobi delivered his line.

Cassandra looked at the box.

Then at him.

Then back at the box.

"Daniel."

"Yes?"

"Before you speak, I want you to know that I'm giving you this opportunity because I believe in personal growth."

He smiled hopefully.

"Thank you."

"Not yours. Mine. I'm growing past the point where I explain basic human responsibility to adults."

A crew member made a choking sound behind the monitor.

Tobi lowered his head, fighting a smile.

Cassandra continued.

"Now sit down. Before I discover that you also forgot how chairs work."

"Cut!"

The room erupted in laughter.

Mrs. Bisi stood.

"Beautiful. Let's do it again."

Cassandra blinked.

"Again?"

"Yes. The first take was good. The second might be better."

Tobi leaned toward Cassandra.

"Welcome to acting. Where your best work is often followed by the words 'one more time.'"

She whispered back, "At least the cupcakes survived this take."

"They didn't survive the first one."

"Don't remind me."

They filmed the scene again.

And again.

And once more because a delivery motorcycle had decided that the quietest moment in the entire city was the perfect time to announce its existence.

By the fourth take, Cassandra was tired.

But she was also learning.

She noticed how Mrs. Bisi adjusted the timing of a pause. She watched how Tobi changed his expression slightly between takes. She saw the camera operator move the frame by a few inches to capture a reaction that might otherwise have been missed.

Every person had a job.

Every detail mattered.

The finished movie would look effortless.

Making it was anything but.

When Mrs. Bisi finally called, "That's a wrap on the scene," Cassandra exhaled.

Tobi gave her a thumbs-up.

"First scene complete."

Cassandra smiled.

"My career has officially survived its first cupcake-related emergency."

"Put it in your autobiography."

"Chapter One: The Cupcake That Almost Ended Cinema."

"International bestseller."

A CALL FROM HOME

During lunch, Cassandra found a quiet corner and called home.

Grandma answered first.

Behind her, Nelson and Kayla were arguing over a toy.

Nelson appeared on the screen.

"Mummy!"

"Hello, my baby!"

"Are you acting now?"

"I am."

"Are you famous?"

Cassandra laughed.

"Not yet."

Nelson looked disappointed.

"Then why are you wearing makeup?"

Cassandra covered her mouth.

"Because it's part of my character."

He considered this.

"So when you're famous, will you still cook?"

Grandma began laughing in the background.

Cassandra shook her head.

"Nelson, fame does not cancel cooking."

From somewhere off-screen, Kayla shouted, "Mummy, bring me a princess dress!"

"I will, my love."

"Two princess dresses!"

"Why two?"

"Because one is for me and one is for my doll."

Cassandra smiled.

"That's a very reasonable business proposal."

Kayla appeared beside her brother.

"Mummy, when will you come home?"

The question was simple.

It landed more heavily than Cassandra expected.

"After filming, sweetheart. Grandma is taking good care of you both, isn't she?"

"Yes," Kayla said. Then, after a pause, "But I want you."

Cassandra's smile softened.

"I want you too, my love. I'm working now, but I'll call you every day. And when I'm home, you'll get all the hugs you can handle."

"Even big hugs?"

"The biggest."

Nelson leaned toward the camera.

"Can I be in your movie?"

"Maybe one day."

"I can act."

Cassandra raised an eyebrow.

"Really? Show me."

Nelson immediately fell backward onto the sofa and pretended to be asleep.

Grandma gasped dramatically.

"Somebody call the doctor!"

Kayla screamed with laughter.

Cassandra laughed so hard she had to lower the phone.

"Nelson, that was not acting. That was a nap with ambition."

"I'm a very good actor," he insisted.

"You might be. But first, you must learn to wake up when Grandma calls you."

"That's not acting. That's impossible."

Grandma shook her head.

"Your son is negotiating his future already."

"At least he understands the industry," Cassandra replied.

They talked a little longer.

When the call ended, Cassandra sat quietly for a moment.

She loved acting. She loved the work, the challenge, the chance to tell stories that could make people laugh or see themselves differently.

But she also loved the little people waiting for her at home.

She didn't want success to mean becoming a stranger to them.

She wanted to build a life big enough to hold all of it.

Her dream.

Her family.

Her children.

And the person she was when nobody was watching.

She opened her notes app and typed:

REMEMBER: SUCCESS SHOULD GIVE MY FAMILY MORE OF ME, NOT LESS.

Then she saved it.

Some reminders deserved to stay close.

THE UNOFFICIAL MANAGER REPORTS FOR DUTY

That evening, Cassandra sent Vikksy a photograph from the set.

It showed her in costume beside Tobi, both of them laughing between takes.

CASSANDRA: FIRST DAY OF FILMING COMPLETE!

Vikksy replied.

VIKKSY: Congratulations. How many people have asked you for an autograph?

CASSANDRA: Nobody.

VIKKSY: Excellent. Your humility remains intact.

CASSANDRA: I hate you.

VIKKSY: That's not what the unofficial management contract says.

She called him.

He answered almost immediately.

"Madam Actress."

"Please stop."

"I am simply respecting your professional title."

"I spent forty minutes waiting for cupcakes today."

There was a pause.

"Your career has already begun teaching you patience."

"Someone ate the props!"

Vikksy laughed.

"Cinema is a serious art form."

"It is not serious. It is a group of adults searching for cake."

"That sounds like a documentary about the entertainment industry."

Cassandra laughed too.

Then she told him about the scene, the director's advice, and how different it felt to perform in front of a camera.

Vikksy listened.

He didn't interrupt with advice every five seconds. He let her tell the story in her own way.

When she finished, he said, "I'm happy for you, Cass. Not just because you got the role. I'm happy because you're doing the thing you've talked about for so long."

She looked down at her hands.

"Thank you for helping me prepare."

"You did the work."

"You helped."

"Then we'll share the credit. You get the acting award. I get a framed photograph of myself standing beside the award."

"That is not how awards work."

"That's why you're the actress and I'm management."

She shook her head, smiling.

Their lives would continue to change. They would grow, pursue different plans, make new memories, and build futures that belonged to them individually.

But the affection between them didn't need romance to remain real.

Some people stayed important because they had helped you through a chapter of your life.

Others stayed important because, even after the chapter changed, they still wanted to see you thrive.

Vikksy was both.

"Get some rest," he told her. "You have another filming day tomorrow."

"Yes, sir."

"And remember, when you're famous, don't start giving interviews in an accent you acquired three minutes ago."

Cassandra burst out laughing.

"I will block you."

"You can't block management."

"Watch me."

She ended the call.

Then she looked again at the photograph from the set.

She was tired. Her feet hurt. Her head was full of dialogue, camera positions, and instructions.

Tomorrow would bring more scenes, more retakes, and probably another crisis involving food.

But tonight, Cassandra was happy.

She had walked into a film set as a young woman hoping for a chance.

She was leaving it as a young actress who had earned her place there.

Her name was on the call sheet.

Her character had a story to tell.

And somewhere beyond the lights, cameras, and the occasional missing cupcake, a much bigger adventure was waiting.

For now, she had work to do.

And Cassandra intended to do it well.

CASSANDRA: BORN TO BE A STAR

CHAPTER FIVE: FAME HAS A CALL TIME, AND IT IS RUDELY EARLY

By the second week of filming *Almost on Purpose*, Cassandra had learned three important things about the movie industry.

First, the phrase "We'll finish in an hour" was not a promise. It was a prayer.

Second, everyone on a film set had a job title, and at least four people had jobs she did not fully understand.

Third, if you were going to become a famous actress, you needed comfortable shoes.

She had arrived at the studio wearing beautiful shoes.

By lunchtime, she had developed a personal disagreement with them.

By the afternoon, the shoes had won.

"Never again," she declared, sitting in the wardrobe area with her feet stretched out.

Tobi, who was reviewing his script nearby, glanced at her.

"Never again what?"

"Fashion."

"You're giving up fashion?"

"I'm negotiating a peace treaty with comfort."

He nodded gravely.

"Tell fashion I said congratulations. It has finally defeated another victim."

Cassandra threw a tissue at him.

He caught it.

"Excellent reflexes," she said.

"I'm an actor. We train for everything."

"You caught a tissue."

"And you witnessed it. Don't limit my range."

She laughed.

Their friendship was developing naturally. Tobi was playful, professional when it mattered, and surprisingly observant. He remembered small details about scenes, asked thoughtful questions, and never treated Cassandra like a newcomer who needed to be reminded of her place.

He also had a talent for making ridiculous statements with the confidence of a university professor defending a thesis.

Cassandra respected that talent.

She had encountered worse academic performances.

THE SCENE THAT REFUSED TO COOPERATE

That morning, Cassandra was scheduled to film a difficult scene.

Maya had discovered that Daniel had secretly applied for a business opportunity on her behalf without telling her. His intentions were good, naturally. Daniel's intentions were always good.

His judgment, however, had apparently been raised by wolves.

In the scene, Maya was hurt. She had trusted Daniel, and he had made a decision that could affect her future without asking her.

Cassandra understood the scene.

She understood Maya's frustration, her disappointment, and the uncomfortable realization that loving someone did not automatically mean trusting their decisions.

But every time the cameras rolled, something went wrong.

On the first take, Cassandra delivered the scene beautifully, but a sound technician accidentally stepped into the edge of the frame.

On the second, Tobi forgot a line.

On the third, a phone rang somewhere in the building.

On the fourth, Cassandra stumbled over a sentence she had memorized perfectly the night before.

"Cut," Mrs. Bisi called.

Cassandra closed her eyes.

"I'm sorry, ma."

Mrs. Bisi walked toward her.

"Don't apologize for every mistake. We'll correct what needs correcting. That's why we're here."

"I know. I'm just frustrated."

"Good. Now use the frustration to understand Maya. Don't use it to punish yourself."

Cassandra nodded.

They tried again.

This time, the scene went well until the final line.

Cassandra delivered it, held the silence, and waited.

"Cut!"

Mrs. Bisi smiled.

"That's it. We have it."

Cassandra exhaled so deeply that Tobi looked concerned.

"Should we call medical personnel?"

"No."

"Because that sounded like your soul just returned from a long journey."

"My soul has been working overtime."

"Tell it to submit an invoice."

She laughed.

Mrs. Bisi approached them.

"That was a strong take. Cassandra, your best moment was when you stopped trying to make the emotion happen and simply allowed yourself to respond. Remember that."

Cassandra took the advice seriously.

She was beginning to see the difference between acting as she imagined it and acting as it actually was.

It wasn't about producing the perfect expression every time.

It was about staying present long enough for the truth of the scene to emerge.

And sometimes, apparently, it was about surviving four failed takes and a rogue phone ringtone.

A TECHNICAL EMERGENCY

That afternoon, the production office experienced a small crisis.

The laptop being used to organize the day's footage had frozen.

The production assistant had been trying to open a large video file when the system stopped responding. Now the laptop displayed a spinning loading symbol that seemed to have mistaken waiting for a full-time career.

The assistant clicked the mouse repeatedly.

Nothing happened.

She pressed several keys.

Still nothing.

Then she whispered the words that had probably been spoken by frustrated computer users since the invention of electricity.

"Please, please, please."

The laptop continued ignoring her.

Cassandra happened to be passing the office when she noticed the commotion.

"What's wrong?"

"The computer has stopped responding. We need to review some footage, and I can't get anything to work."

Cassandra leaned over to look.

"Have you tried restarting it?"

"I can't even close the program."

Before the assistant could attempt another form of technological persuasion, Cassandra remembered someone.

She pulled out her phone and called Vikksy.

He answered on the second ring.

"Technical Support Department. Your problem is our problem, unless the problem is a printer. Printers are a separate branch of suffering."

"Vikksy, I'm serious."

His tone changed immediately.

"What's happening?"

She explained the situation.

"Windows laptop?"

"Yes."

"Is anything responding, or is the whole thing frozen?"

"The whole thing, I think."

"Can you see whether the keyboard responds to anything? Don't keep clicking everything. That's how people turn one problem into six."

Cassandra repeated his instructions to the assistant.

They checked the keyboard, waited a moment, and confirmed that the system was completely unresponsive.

Vikksy walked her through a safe way to restart the machine, then asked them to wait for it to boot before opening the footage again.

The laptop restarted.

The assistant stared at the screen.

"It's working!"

Cassandra smiled.

"You're welcome."

The assistant looked at her.

"You know computers?"

"A little."

From the phone, Vikksy said, "Please don't exaggerate her skills. She knows a little. I know slightly more than a little. Together, we can frighten a laptop into cooperation."

Cassandra rolled her eyes.

"You're on speakerphone."

"I assumed. You only put me on speaker when you want witnesses to my brilliance."

"You have never been humble in your life."

"Humility is important. I simply don't want to monopolize it."

The assistant laughed.

Cassandra thanked him and ended the call.

The production assistant looked at her with renewed interest.

"That was your boyfriend?"

Cassandra shook her head.

"No. Vikksy is my friend. He's been one of my closest supporters for a long time."

"He's funny."

"Unfortunately, he's aware of it."

The assistant grinned.

"Can he help me with my laptop at some point?"

Cassandra sighed theatrically.

"Congratulations. You have discovered the unofficial technical department. Please note that the department's services are not free of jokes."

THE MAN WHO FIXED EVERYTHING EXCEPT HIS OWN ANNOYINGNESS

Later that evening, Cassandra called Vikksy again.

This time, there was no computer emergency.

She simply wanted to tell him about filming.

He listened as she described the difficult scene, the laptop incident, and the way the crew had begun treating her like part of the team.

When she finished, he said, "So, in summary, you're becoming an actress, learning emotional discipline, and providing emergency IT support to a film production."

"When you put it like that, it sounds ridiculous."

"That's because it is. Most careers are several unrelated problems wearing one name tag."

Cassandra laughed.

"You're impossible."

"Yet technically useful."

"Very technically useful."

"I shall put that on my résumé."

She smiled.

Then she told him something she hadn't quite admitted to herself.

"I think I'm starting to feel like I belong there."

Vikksy didn't make a joke.

He didn't interrupt.

He let her finish explaining how strange it felt to walk onto the set each morning and see her name on the schedule. How she still worried that somebody would realize she was new and decide she didn't deserve to be there.

When she finally stopped talking, he said, "Cass, you don't have to be the most experienced person in the room to deserve your place in it. You're there because they chose you, and you're learning because you take the work seriously. Let yourself grow into the opportunity."

She was quiet.

"Thank you."

"You're welcome."

A pause followed.

Then he added, "Also, if they need another laptop fixed, tell them my consultation fee has increased."

Cassandra laughed.

"There he is."

"I was being emotionally supportive. My system cannot sustain that level of sincerity indefinitely."

"You're so annoying."

"But you called me."

"Unfortunately."

"Friendship is beautiful."

"Goodnight, Vikksy."

"Goodnight, future award winner."

She ended the call smiling.

Some friendships were loud. Some were quiet. Some involved long conversations, thoughtful advice, and someone who could make you laugh five minutes after you had been convinced that the world was too heavy.

Cassandra was grateful for hers.

She didn't need Vikksy to become anything other than what he was.

He was her friend, her adviser, her occasional technical department, and a reliable source of jokes she had not requested.

And he wanted to see her succeed.

That was enough.

THE FIRST SCREENING

Two weeks later, the production team organized a private screening of selected scenes for the cast and crew.

The film wasn't finished, but Mrs. Bisi wanted everyone to review some early footage and discuss what was working.

Cassandra arrived at the screening room with Sarah, who had come straight from campus, and a level of nervousness that made her reconsider the wisdom of eating lunch.

Tobi sat beside her.

"Relax," he whispered.

"I'm relaxed."

"Your hands are gripping that chair like it owes you money."

She released it.

"Better?"

"Marginally."

The lights dimmed.

The first scene appeared on the screen.

Cassandra saw herself.

Not in a mirror. Not in a rehearsal. Not in the small, controlled world of her imagination.

On a screen.

Her face was larger than life, framed by the camera, surrounded by the café set, and accompanied by the voices of people who had watched her perform.

She looked different.

Not because the camera had transformed her into someone else, but because she was seeing herself from the outside.

The scene played.

The audience laughed at one of her lines.

Cassandra blinked.

They laughed again at a moment she hadn't thought was particularly funny.

Tobi leaned toward her.

"Congratulations. The audience has discovered your face."

"Please be quiet."

"Your face is now a public resource."

She nudged him.

The screening continued.

There were moments she loved. There were moments she wanted to improve. A pause she thought was too long. A reaction she hadn't realized the camera had captured. A line that sounded much more natural on screen than it had during rehearsal.

When the final clip ended, Mrs. Bisi stood.

"Everyone did good work. We still have plenty to do, but we're building something promising."

She looked toward Cassandra.

"Maya is becoming a very interesting character. Cassandra, I want you to keep trusting your instincts while remaining open to direction. You have a natural connection with the audience. Protect that. Don't start imitating what you think an actress should look like."

Cassandra nodded.

"Thank you, ma."

After the screening, Sarah hugged her.

"You were so good!"

Cassandra smiled.

"You don't have to say that because we're friends."

"I'm saying it because it's true. I can insult you later if you need balance."

"Thank you for your generosity."

Sarah laughed.

On the way out, Cassandra checked her phone.

A message from Vikksy waited on the screen.

VIKKSY: How was the screening?

CASSANDRA: Good. People laughed at my scenes.

VIKKSY: Naturally. I've been telling you that you're entertaining for years.

CASSANDRA: You mostly laugh at me.

VIKKSY: Comedy has many delivery methods.

She shook her head, smiling.

Then another message arrived.

VIKKSY: Proud of you, Cass. Keep going.

She read that one twice.

The world had not changed overnight.

She wasn't famous yet. Her name wasn't trending. She hadn't received a major award or appeared on the cover of a magazine.

But the work was improving.

Her confidence was growing.

And the dream she had carried for so long was becoming a real, ordinary, demanding part of her life.

That was worth celebrating.

CHAPTER SIX: WHEN THE INTERNET DISCOVERS YOUR FACE

The first clip from *Almost on Purpose* went online on a Tuesday evening.

It was a short promotional video released by Amara Okafor Productions. The clip showed Maya sitting across from Daniel in the café, listening to one of his increasingly ridiculous explanations.

The scene ended with Cassandra delivering a line that had made the crew laugh during filming.

The caption read:

SOME PEOPLE BRING FLOWERS. DANIEL BRINGS PROBLEMS.

Within an hour, the clip had been shared hundreds of times.

By the following morning, people were quoting Maya's line in the comments.

Cassandra didn't know any of this.

She was at PAU, trying to finish an assignment while her phone sat face down beside her notebook.

Rebecca discovered the clip first.

At 8:17 a.m., Cassandra received a voice note.

It began with Rebecca screaming.

Not speaking loudly.

Screaming.

Cassandra nearly dropped her phone.

"WHAT IS WRONG WITH YOU?"

Rebecca sent another voice note.

"YOUR FACE IS ON THE INTERNET!"

Cassandra frowned.

"My face has been on the internet before."

"NOT LIKE THIS!"

"What does that mean?"

"It means people are laughing at your acting, not at your old hostel pictures!"

Cassandra sat upright.

"What?"

"CHECK YOUR PHONE!"

Cassandra opened the production company's page.

There it was.

Her face.

Her voice.

Her performance.

Thousands of views.

Comments from people she had never met.

She read them slowly.

Who is this actress? She's naturally funny.

The girl playing Maya is so good.

Her expressions are everything.

I need the full movie immediately.

One comment simply read:

Daniel needs prayer.

Cassandra laughed.

Another said:

I know a Daniel like this. We are no longer friends.

She laughed harder.

Rebecca called.

"Do you see it?"

"I see it!"

"People are talking about you!"

"I can read, Rebecca!"

"Then read faster!"

Cassandra stared at the numbers beneath the clip.

They were increasing.

Every time she refreshed the page, the view count had climbed.

It wasn't a global phenomenon. It wasn't even a major celebrity moment.

But it was the first time strangers were responding to her work without knowing her personally.

They didn't know her coursemates.

They didn't know about her hostel.

They didn't know how many times she'd rehearsed the scene or how much effort had gone into a few seconds of footage.

They were simply watching Maya.

And they liked her.

Cassandra felt something warm bloom in her chest.

Then her phone rang again.

Vikksy.

She answered.

"Have you seen it?"

He spoke in a solemn tone.

"Cassandra, I regret to inform you that your face has escaped containment."

She burst out laughing.

"What does that even mean?"

"Your face was previously a private matter. Now it is circulating among strangers without adequate supervision."

"You're not serious."

"I'm deeply concerned. Have you secured the necessary permits?"

"Vikksy!"

He laughed.

Then he softened his voice.

"I've seen it, Cass. You were really good. The timing was excellent, and your expressions were natural. You didn't force the joke. You let the situation do the work."

Cassandra smiled.

"You actually analyzed it?"

"Obviously. I am an unofficial manager, technical consultant, and part-time professional nuisance. I have responsibilities."

"Mostly nuisance."

"Every organization needs a strong department."

She laughed.

He continued.

"Enjoy this. You've earned the moment. Just remember that the numbers will go up and down. Don't let a good day make you careless, and don't let a bad day convince you that you've suddenly forgotten how to act."

Cassandra looked at the screen.

The view count had increased again.

"I won't."

"Good. Now go to class before you become too famous to understand your own timetable."

"You're the worst."

"I've been called worse by better people."

She ended the call, still smiling.

THE BUSINESS ADMINISTRATION DEPARTMENT OF UNAUTHORIZED CELEBRATION

At lunchtime, Rebecca arrived at Cassandra's hostel building carrying snacks and the expression of someone who had prepared a major presentation.

She entered the room, dropped the snacks on the bed, and pointed at Cassandra.

"Stand up."

"Why?"

"Because I need to inspect the celebrity."

Cassandra stared at her.

"Inspect me?"

"Yes. Turn around."

"No."

"Fine. I'll inspect you from this angle."

Rebecca studied her face.

"Hmm."

"What?"

"You look exactly the same."

"Thank you?"

"I was expecting some visible change. Maybe your cheekbones would become internationally recognized."

Cassandra threw a pillow at her.

Rebecca caught it.

"Excellent. The reflexes of a rising star."

They sat together and opened the clip again.

Rebecca watched it twice.

Then she said, "You know what I like most?"

"What?"

"You look comfortable. You're not trying too hard. It feels like you're actually living in the scene."

Cassandra smiled.

"Mrs. Bisi said something similar."

"Then listen to Mrs. Bisi. She's directing a film. I'm studying Business Administration. If I start giving you detailed acting advice, we will both suffer."

"At least you're self-aware."

"I am a businesswoman. We identify our competitive advantages."

Cassandra laughed.

Rebecca reached for a snack.

"Now, let's discuss the financial implications of your sudden popularity."

"There are no financial implications. It's a free promotional clip."

"That is a terrible attitude."

"Rebecca."

"I'm serious. You have a growing public profile. You need to be sensible about opportunities. Don't agree to every offer because someone says you're talented. Read agreements. Understand what people expect from you. And don't let strangers pressure you into sharing things you want to keep private."

Cassandra nodded.

The advice was sensible.

Rebecca could joke about becoming her manager all she wanted, but she understood business, and she cared about Cassandra's future.

"Thank you," Cassandra said.

Rebecca smiled.

"You're welcome. My consultation fee is one snack."

"You've already eaten three."

"Then my fee has appreciated in value."

Cassandra shook her head.

"You are impossible."

"And yet, when your name was on the internet, you called me first."

"I did not."

"You called me second."

"Vikksy called me first."

Rebecca paused.

Then she nodded.

"That man is becoming a serious threat to my position."

Cassandra laughed.

Rebecca grabbed another snack.

"Not romantically, before your imagination starts writing a television series. I'm talking about friendship rankings. We need an official chart."

"Please don't."

"Too late. I've already opened a spreadsheet."

Cassandra stared at her.

"You have not."

Rebecca smiled.

"Would you like to see the draft?"

"No."

"Excellent. I'll send it to you."

Cassandra threw another pillow.

THE GROUP CHAT HAS LOST ITS MIND

That evening, Cassandra's friends created a group call.

Sarah was present. John was present. Abiodun was present. Rebecca joined from her hostel building.

Vikksy joined a minute later.

Rebecca greeted him immediately.

"YO, NIGGA! HOW YOU DOIN'?"

Vikksy answered in his usual exaggerated style.

"YOOOO! WHAT'S GOOD, MY BROTHER?"

John frowned at the screen.

"Why do you two speak like you have just arrived from a country neither of you has visited?"

Rebecca pointed at him.

"Don't interrupt the culture."

Vikksy nodded.

"Exactly. This is an international friendship. We have no visa, but our accents travel freely."

Sarah burst out laughing.

Cassandra covered her face.

"Please behave."

"Impossible," Rebecca said. "Your fame has activated our celebration protocols."

Abiodun cleared his throat.

"I would like to announce that I have known Cassandra since before she became popular."

Cassandra stared at him.

"You have known me for two years."

"Two years of historical significance."

"You forgot your line during our first class exercise."

"That was my artistic origin story."

Vikksy leaned toward the camera.

"Abiodun, your greatest contribution to cinema remains the phrase 'your cooking.'"

Everyone laughed.

Abiodun placed a hand on his chest.

"History will vindicate me."

"History has already filed a complaint," Vikksy replied.

Rebecca nearly fell off her chair laughing.

The conversation moved from the promotional clip to Cassandra's filming schedule, the next scenes, and the growing number of comments from viewers.

John suggested that Cassandra prepare an autograph.

Sarah suggested that she focus on her coursework before the university remembered that she was still a student.

Rebecca suggested that Cassandra appoint her as Director of Public Relations.

Vikksy suggested that Rebecca first complete a short course in not shouting at people during video calls.

Rebecca replied that his application for the position of Friendship Assistant had been rejected.

"On what grounds?" he asked.

"Excessive talking."

"That is a discriminatory policy against intelligent people."

"Then why are you affected?"

The group erupted.

Cassandra watched them, smiling.

They were ridiculous.

They were loud.

They had absolutely no intention of allowing her to enjoy a single peaceful moment of early fame.

And she loved them for it.

Not because they never annoyed her.

Because they could celebrate her without competing with her.

They could tease her without making her feel small.

They could laugh at her jokes, laugh with her, and still take her dreams seriously.

That kind of friendship was a gift.

When the call finally ended, Cassandra sat quietly for a moment.

She thought about the people who had helped her reach this point.

Her family.

Her friends.

Her lecturers.

Mrs. Bisi.

The production team.

Vikksy, who had listened to her rehearse, challenged her interpretations, helped her think through problems, and remained one of her loudest supporters.

She hadn't built her future alone.

But she was the one doing the work.

And that mattered too.

A MESSAGE FROM AMARA

The following afternoon, Cassandra received an email from Amara Okafor Productions.

The subject line read:

NEXT STEPS: CASSANDRA / PUBLICITY AND FUTURE PROJECTS

She opened it carefully.

The production team thanked her for her work on *Almost on Purpose* and explained that the promotional response to the early clip had been encouraging.

They were pleased with her performance and wanted to discuss future opportunities after the film's release.

There was also an invitation to attend a small industry networking event the following month.

Cassandra read the message twice.

Future opportunities.

Networking event.

Industry contacts.

It sounded like the kind of language people used when describing a world she had only recently entered.

She called Rebecca.

Then Sarah.

Then Vikksy.

He listened to her read the email.

"That's encouraging," he said. "But take it one step at a time. Finish this film well. Attend the event, meet people, and learn how the industry works. Don't start planning your acceptance speech for an award you haven't been nominated for."

Cassandra laughed.

"I wasn't!"

"You were probably choosing your outfit."

"I was thinking about it."

"Exactly. The award industry has suffered a major loss. Your outfit has already won."

She shook her head.

Then she became thoughtful.

"Do you think I can actually become a big actress?"

Vikksy didn't answer immediately.

When he spoke, his voice was steady.

"I think you have talent, you're willing to learn, and you're doing the work. Those are real reasons to keep going. I can't promise you how big you'll become. Nobody can. But I don't think you should make your dream smaller just because the future isn't guaranteed."

Cassandra looked at the email again.

"Thank you."

"And remember, you don't have to become famous overnight. You need to become better, keep making good decisions, and protect the parts of your life that matter."

She nodded.

For once, she didn't tease him about being serious.

He had given her something more useful than a prediction.

He had reminded her that her future wasn't a verdict waiting to be delivered.

It was something she could keep building.

THE GIRL WHO WAS BEGINNING TO BE SEEN

That night, Cassandra stood before the mirror in her room.

She had finished her assignment. Her costume for the next filming day was ready. Her phone was charging.

On the screen, the promotional clip continued collecting views.

People were sharing it.

People were laughing.

Some were asking when the full movie would be released.

She smiled.

Then she turned away from the phone.

There were still scenes to film. Lines to learn. Lessons to absorb. Exams to prepare for. Children to call. Family members to visit. Friendships to nurture.

There was a whole life beyond the screen.

She wanted the spotlight.

She wanted the roles, the red carpets, the beautiful clothes, the interviews, and the chance to tell stories that would make people feel something.

She wanted to become the actress she had always imagined.

But she also wanted to remain someone her children could run to without needing an appointment with her assistant.

Someone her friends could tease.

Someone who could sit with her mother and laugh about ordinary things.

Someone who could call Vikksy when her phone refused to cooperate and expect a solution followed by an unsolicited lecture about proper device maintenance.

She wanted a big life.

Not an empty one.

Cassandra returned to her desk and opened her notebook.

At the top of a fresh page, she wrote:

MY DREAM IS GETTING BIGGER. I MUST GROW WITH IT.

Then she underlined the sentence.

Twice.

Outside, Lagos continued its usual business of noise, movement, ambition, and people trying to get somewhere before the traffic decided otherwise.

Somewhere in the city, a young actress was preparing for tomorrow.

She was not a superstar yet.

But people were beginning to notice her.

And the more they noticed, the more Cassandra understood something important.

Being seen was exciting.

Being remembered was powerful.

But becoming someone worth remembering would take a little more than a viral clip.

It would take courage.

Work.

Humility.

A good team.

And, if she was particularly unlucky, another conversation with Vikksy about why she should stop letting her phone battery reach two percent.

Her journey had only just begun.

CASSANDRA: BORN TO BE A STAR

CHAPTER SEVEN: NETWORKING, NICE OUTFITS, AND PEOPLE WHO SAY "LET'S CONNECT"

Cassandra had never attended an industry networking event before.

She had attended birthday parties, university gatherings, family celebrations, and one particularly chaotic hostel event where somebody had attempted to make fried rice for forty people using a pot designed for approximately six.

She had survived all of them.

But the invitation from Amara Okafor Productions felt different.

It was a small entertainment industry gathering for actors, directors, producers, screenwriters, and other professionals. The event would bring together people whose names Cassandra had previously encountered on movie posters, television credits, and social media.

She was excited.

She was also terrified.

Naturally, Rebecca considered this an excellent opportunity to become unbearable.

"Send me a picture of your outfit," Rebecca demanded during their video call.

Cassandra held up a dress.

Rebecca examined it with the seriousness of a fashion judge deciding the fate of a national wardrobe.

"Hmm."

Cassandra narrowed her eyes.

"What does 'hmm' mean?"

"It means I'm thinking."

"Think faster."

"I'm trying to be diplomatic."

"Rebecca!"

"Fine. The dress is beautiful. You look elegant. You look intelligent. You look like someone who knows the difference between a producer and a person who simply owns a camera."

Cassandra laughed.

"Thank you."

"You're welcome. Now, what shoes are you wearing?"

"Comfortable ones."

Rebecca stared at her.

"Who are you, and what have you done with Cassandra?"

"I learned from experience."

"Good. We are evolving."

Cassandra shook her head.

Rebecca had also prepared a list of networking advice.

Some of it was sensible.

Some of it sounded suspiciously like advice from a motivational speaker who charged people money to explain the importance of eye contact.

"Remember," Rebecca said, "introduce yourself confidently. Ask people about their work. Listen. Don't spend the entire evening talking about yourself."

"That sounds reasonable."

"And don't follow a famous person around the room like a lost puppy."

"I wasn't planning to!"

"I'm just saying. If you see someone important, greet them. Have a normal conversation. Then let them move around freely."

Cassandra nodded.

"Anything else?"

"Yes. If somebody says, 'We should work together sometime,' don't immediately start planning your wedding to their career."

Cassandra burst out laughing.

"Rebecca!"

"What? People say things. Sometimes they mean them. Sometimes they're being polite. Learn the difference."

Cassandra smiled.

"You're actually giving good advice."

Rebecca placed a hand on her chest.

"Please don't sound so surprised. I study Business Administration. I have a degree in common sense pending."

"You're in 200 level."

"Exactly. The degree is still buffering."

They laughed.

Before ending the call, Rebecca added, "I'm proud of you, Cass. Go and enjoy yourself. You don't have to impress everybody in the room. Just be yourself, learn something, and make a few good connections."

Cassandra smiled.

"Thank you, bestie."

"You're welcome. And if you become famous enough to have a personal assistant, I expect priority access to your calendar."

"Goodbye, Rebecca."

"Love you too!"

THE MANAGER'S FINAL BRIEFING

Vikksy called that evening.

"Madam, your pre-event briefing is ready."

Cassandra sat on her bed.

"How much is the consultation fee?"

"Free for the first five minutes. After that, I charge per unnecessary interruption."

"So this call is about to bankrupt me."

"Then we should discuss your budget."

She laughed.

He continued.

"Seriously, Cass. You're going to meet people who have been in the industry for years. Some will be friendly. Some will be busy. Some will talk like every sentence needs to be engraved on a marble wall."

Cassandra chuckled.

"How do I deal with them?"

"Listen. Ask questions. Be respectful. If you don't know something, don't pretend you do. And if somebody offers an opportunity, find out what it actually involves before getting excited."

"Rebecca said something similar."

"Excellent. My competition is becoming competent."

"She's my bestie. You're my bestie."

Vikksy paused.

"That's a very generous arrangement. I shall inform the Friendship Regulatory Commission."

Cassandra laughed.

Then he added, more thoughtfully, "And remember that you belong in the room. You don't need to act like you're more experienced than you are. You're there to learn, meet people, and let them get to know you."

She nodded.

"I'll remember."

"Good. Also, charge your phone before you leave."

Cassandra looked at the screen.

"Why?"

"Because you once called me to complain that your phone died while you were using it."

"That was one time!"

"It was at eleven percent."

"Exactly. Eleven is not zero."

"Your relationship with mathematics is concerning."

She laughed so hard she had to put the phone down.

WELCOME TO THE ROOM

The event took place in an elegant venue in Lagos.

Cassandra arrived early enough to settle herself before the room filled.

The lighting was warm. Soft music played in the background. Small groups of guests stood around tables, exchanging greetings and discussing productions, scripts, auditions, and projects that seemed to involve a surprising number of meetings.

Cassandra collected her name tag.

CASSANDRA *Actor | Film and Multimedia Studies, PAU*

She stared at it for a moment.

Seeing the word *Actor* beside her name still felt slightly unreal.

A young woman standing nearby smiled at her.

"First time here?"

Cassandra turned.

"Is it that obvious?"

"Only because you're looking at your name tag like it just told you you're the new governor."

Cassandra laughed.

"That's fair."

"I'm Zainab," the woman said. "I'm a screenwriter. I've worked on a couple of short films, and I'm currently developing a television project."

"Cassandra. I'm acting in a romantic comedy called *Almost on Purpose*."

Zainab's face brightened.

"I saw the promotional clip!"

Cassandra blinked.

"You did?"

"Yes! The café scene. The way you looked at that man when he started explaining himself was hilarious."

Cassandra laughed.

"Daniel is a full-time responsibility."

"Daniel is the kind of man who would lose his own house and blame the estate agent."

Cassandra laughed again.

Zainab grinned.

They began talking about the film, then about acting, writing, and the challenge of creating characters who felt like real people.

Cassandra discovered that Zainab was observant, funny, and refreshingly honest about the difficulty of getting projects made.

"People think the hardest part of writing is coming up with an idea," Zainab said. "Sometimes the hardest part is convincing everybody that the idea deserves to exist."

Cassandra nodded.

"That sounds familiar."

"You're an actress. You have to convince people that you can become somebody who doesn't exist."

"And sometimes convince them that the person who exists already is worth watching."

Zainab smiled.

"Exactly."

They exchanged contacts.

It was Cassandra's first proper networking conversation, and it hadn't required her to pretend to be someone else.

That felt like a promising beginning.

THE WOMAN WHO HAD BEEN THERE BEFORE

Later, Amara Okafor approached Cassandra.

"Cassandra! I'm glad you could make it."

"Thank you for inviting me, ma."

"How is filming going?"

"Well, ma. I'm learning a lot."

"Good. That's what your first production should do. Give you work to be proud of and lessons you'll remember."

Amara introduced her to several people, including a director, a cinematographer, and a casting professional.

Cassandra listened carefully, asking questions whenever the conversation allowed.

Then Amara led her toward a woman speaking with two producers near the window.

The woman wore a simple, elegant outfit. Her presence was calm, but people naturally turned toward her when she spoke.

"This is **Irene Danjuma**," Amara said. "She's one of the most respected actresses in the industry."

Cassandra recognized the name immediately.

Irene had appeared in award-winning dramas, major television productions, and several films that Cassandra had studied during her Film and Multimedia courses.

Cassandra greeted her politely.

"Good evening, ma. It's an honour to meet you."

Irene smiled.

"You're Cassandra, aren't you? The young actress in *Almost on Purpose*."

Cassandra's eyes widened.

"Yes, ma."

"I watched your clip. You're funny."

"Thank you, ma."

"And your expressions are very clear on camera. That's useful. But don't become so pleased with yourself that you stop learning."

Cassandra laughed nervously.

"I'll try not to."

Irene smiled.

"I'm teasing you. Mostly."

Amara laughed.

They spoke for several minutes about Cassandra's first film, her studies at PAU, and her interest in becoming a versatile actress.

Irene listened with genuine attention.

"Film school gives you useful tools," she said. "But the industry will teach you things no classroom can fully prepare you for. You must learn how to work with different directors, understand scripts, protect your professionalism, and handle rejection without allowing it to define you."

Cassandra nodded.

"How did you handle rejection when you were starting out?"

Irene considered the question.

"Some days, better than others. I used to believe that if someone rejected me, it meant I wasn't good enough. Eventually, I learned that casting decisions are more complicated than that. Sometimes you're excellent but wrong for the role. Sometimes the production changes direction. Sometimes someone else simply fits the part better."

She paused.

"The important thing is to learn what you can, improve what you control, and keep moving."

Cassandra absorbed every word.

"Thank you, ma."

Irene smiled.

"Don't thank me yet. You'll probably remember this conversation the next time you lose an audition."

Cassandra laughed.

"That's encouraging."

"I'm an actress. Encouragement is part of the job. So is telling people the truth."

Before they parted, Irene gave Cassandra her professional contact details.

"If you're serious about this career, keep studying. Watch good performances. Read scripts. Learn about the business side. And don't limit yourself to the roles you think you're supposed to play."

Cassandra nodded.

"I will."

As Irene moved away, Cassandra stood quietly for a moment.

She had just spoken with a woman whose career represented something she wanted for herself.

Not merely fame.

Longevity.

Respect.

The ability to keep doing meaningful work long after the excitement of becoming famous had passed.

It was a different kind of ambition, and Cassandra found herself wanting it just as much.

THE NETWORKING EMERGENCY

The event was going well until Cassandra encountered a man who seemed to believe that every conversation was an audition for his own biography.

His name was Mr. Kingsley, and he was a self-described entertainment consultant.

He introduced himself by listing several productions he had allegedly advised, followed by a lengthy explanation of how he had once told a producer something the producer apparently needed to hear.

Cassandra listened politely.

Eventually, he asked, "So, young lady, what do you bring to the industry?"

Cassandra thought carefully.

"I'm still learning, sir. I bring preparation, a willingness to improve, and a genuine interest in telling stories that people can connect with."

He nodded.

"Good. Very good. But you need to understand something. Talent is nothing without connections."

Cassandra remained polite.

"Connections can certainly help."

"Exactly. You need people who can open doors for you."

He leaned closer.

"I know many important people."

Cassandra smiled.

"That's good, sir."

"I could help you."

She waited.

He began describing an unspecified opportunity, but the details remained strangely vague.

He spoke about exposure, influence, and the importance of being around the right people.

Cassandra remembered Rebecca's advice.

She also remembered Vikksy's warning not to confuse an exciting promise with a real opportunity.

So she asked a simple question.

"Thank you, sir. Could you tell me what the project involves, what role you would play, and what the expected terms would be?"

Mr. Kingsley paused.

For the first time in the conversation, he seemed to have run out of material.

"Well, we would discuss that later."

"Certainly. I'd be happy to review the details when they're available."

She smiled, thanked him for his time, and politely excused herself.

Across the room, Zainab had witnessed the exchange.

When Cassandra joined her, Zainab grinned.

"You handled that well."

Cassandra exhaled.

"I wasn't sure what to say."

"You said exactly what you needed to say. You were respectful without agreeing to something you didn't understand."

Cassandra laughed.

"I was afraid I'd offended him."

"If asking for details offends someone, imagine what happens when you ask them to sign a contract."

Cassandra nearly choked on her drink.

Zainab smiled.

"Welcome to the industry."

THE CALL THAT ENDED THE EVENING

On the journey home, Cassandra called Vikksy.

He answered immediately.

"Report from the front lines."

"Networking is exhausting."

"Did you meet important people?"

"Yes."

"Did you make useful connections?"

"Yes."

"Did anyone try to sell you a dream without providing a receipt?"

Cassandra stopped walking.

"How did you know?"

Vikksy laughed.

"Because humans have been doing that since dreams became expensive."

She told him about Mr. Kingsley.

Vikksy listened, then said, "You handled it well. There's nothing wrong with asking questions. A legitimate opportunity should survive basic clarification."

"Rebecca said the same thing."

"Your bestie and I are becoming alarmingly aligned. This may require a meeting."

Cassandra smiled.

"She'll probably make a spreadsheet."

"Then I shall arrive with a presentation."

"Please don't."

"Too late. Slide one is titled 'The Economic Consequences of Rebecca's Confidence.'"

Cassandra burst out laughing.

They talked about Irene Danjuma, the screenwriter she had met, and the possibility of attending more industry events.

Vikksy was genuinely pleased.

He didn't make her success about himself. He didn't remind her how much he had helped. He simply celebrated the new doors opening in front of her.

Before ending the call, he said, "You know what I like about today?"

"What?"

"You went into a room full of people you admired, and you didn't spend the whole evening trying to become somebody else. You listened, asked questions, and let them meet Cassandra."

She was quiet for a moment.

"That's what Irene told me too. In a different way."

"Then two intelligent people have independently reached the same conclusion. I shall add this to my evidence."

"Evidence of what?"

"That you should listen to me more often."

Cassandra groaned.

"There it is. You were doing so well."

"My sincerity has a limited battery."

"Goodnight, Vikksy."

"Goodnight, future legend."

She ended the call smiling.

The networking event had given her more than contacts.

It had shown her the kind of professional she wanted to become: talented, prepared, thoughtful, and confident enough to ask questions without pretending to know everything.

She was beginning to understand that success wasn't simply about being noticed.

It was also about what you did after people noticed you.

And Cassandra intended to be ready.

CHAPTER EIGHT: THE AUDITION THAT COULD CHANGE EVERYTHING

Three days after the networking event, Cassandra received a message from Irene Danjuma.

She stared at the notification for several seconds.

Then she opened it.

Irene had enjoyed meeting her and had spoken with a casting director who was looking for young actresses for an upcoming feature film.

The project was a family adventure drama called **THE MAP OF TOMORROW**.

It followed a determined young woman who discovers an old travel journal belonging to her late grandfather. As she follows the journal's clues across different Nigerian communities, she begins to understand her family's history, repair broken relationships, and discover what she wants from her own future.

The role being cast was **Amara**, a young woman who appeared confident and independent but secretly feared disappointing the people she loved.

It was a substantial role.

The production had a larger budget than *Almost on Purpose*, an experienced director, and a cast that included several established actors.

The casting director was inviting Cassandra to audition.

Not offering her the role.

Inviting her to audition.

Cassandra read the message again.

Then she sat down.

She had spent the past few weeks learning how to perform on camera, work with a crew, and trust her instincts.

Now she had an opportunity to audition for a film that could introduce her to an entirely different audience.

She called Irene.

"Good afternoon, ma. Thank you so much for thinking of me."

"You're welcome, Cassandra. I thought you might be suitable for the character."

"I'll prepare seriously."

"Good. And remember, I recommended you for consideration. What happens next depends on your audition. Don't feel that you owe me a particular result."

Cassandra appreciated that.

"Yes, ma."

"Now go and do your work. That's what opportunities are for."

After the call, Cassandra sat quietly.

Then she screamed into a pillow.

It was a perfectly reasonable response to a perfectly unreasonable amount of excitement.

THE FAMILY COUNCIL

That evening, Cassandra called Rebecca.

Rebecca answered while eating.

"Why are you calling me with the voice of someone who has just discovered oil beneath her hostel?"

Cassandra explained everything.

Rebecca stopped chewing.

"Wait. Irene Danjuma recommended you?"

"She passed my name to the casting director."

"And they're inviting you to audition for a bigger film?"

"Yes."

Rebecca placed her food down.

"Cassandra."

"What?"

"Do you understand what this means?"

"It means I have another audition."

Rebecca stared at her.

"You're technically correct, which is the most annoying kind of correct."

Cassandra laughed.

Rebecca began pacing around her room.

"Okay. We need a plan."

"We?"

"Yes, we. You are the actress. I am the friend who will prevent you from losing your mind."

"I thought you were Director of Public Relations."

"I have expanded my portfolio."

"Without a meeting?"

"I am a fast-growing company."

Cassandra shook her head.

Rebecca became serious.

"Send me the character description and the audition requirements. I'll help you organize your preparation schedule. We can make sure you don't leave everything until the night before."

Cassandra smiled.

"Thank you."

"You're welcome. Also, don't start comparing yourself with the established actresses in the cast. You're auditioning for a role, not competing to become the entire film industry by Friday."

Cassandra laughed.

"I wasn't going to do that."

"You were absolutely going to do that."

Rebecca knew her too well.

VIKKSY'S RESEARCH DEPARTMENT

Cassandra sent Vikksy the project information.

His response arrived a few minutes later.

VIKKSY: Congratulations. Your career has entered the stage where your fictional problems are becoming more expensive.

CASSANDRA: Please be serious.

VIKKSY: I am. I'm celebrating and being irritating simultaneously. It's called efficiency.

She smiled.

Then she explained the role.

Vikksy asked her to send the audition instructions and the character description. He read through them and helped her identify the central conflict in Amara's story.

"What does she want?" he asked during their call.

"She wants to discover her grandfather's story and understand her family better."

"That's the external goal. What does she need?"

Cassandra thought for a moment.

"To stop believing that she has to make everybody happy?"

"Maybe. What makes her afraid of failing?"

"She thinks that if she disappoints her family, she'll lose their respect."

"Good. Now you've got something to work with."

Cassandra wrote it down.

Vikksy continued.

"Don't play her as a sad person from the beginning. Let her be funny, curious, stubborn, and occasionally unreasonable. If she's a real person, she can't be only one emotion."

Cassandra looked at him through the screen.

"That's actually good advice."

He appeared offended.

"Actually?"

"You're usually telling me to charge my phone."

"Because you refuse to learn."

She laughed.

They continued discussing the character.

Vikksy helped her break down the audition scene into smaller emotional shifts. He suggested that she mark the places where Amara's confidence slipped, where she hid her disappointment behind humor, and where she finally admitted something she had been avoiding.

He didn't tell Cassandra how to act every line.

He asked questions that helped her discover her own interpretation.

That was the difference between simply giving advice and helping someone think.

By the end of the call, Cassandra had a clearer understanding of the character.

"Thank you," she said.

"You're welcome."

She smiled.

"You're going to become unbearable when I win an award."

"Become? Cassandra, I have been preparing for that moment for years."

She burst out laughing.

"Goodnight, Vikksy."

"Goodnight. And please, no rehearsing until three in the morning. Your brain is not an internet café."

THE WOMAN IN THE MIRROR

For the next several days, Cassandra prepared for the audition.

She studied the script.

She researched the kind of character Amara was.

She practiced her delivery, then practiced saying the lines differently.

She recorded herself on her phone and watched the playback.

Sometimes she liked what she saw.

Sometimes she wanted to hide the phone under her mattress and pretend technology had never been invented.

On one recording, she noticed that she looked away too quickly during an emotional moment.

On another, she realized she was making the same expression at three different points in the scene.

She began experimenting.

What if Amara tried to hide her disappointment with a joke?

What if she looked at the person she was speaking to before answering?

What if she allowed a silence to remain uncomfortable instead of filling it immediately?

Each attempt taught her something.

One afternoon, she called Vikksy to complain.

"I've recorded this scene twelve times."

"Excellent."

"Excellent?"

"You've recorded it twelve times and learned something each time. That's called practice."

"I hate how reasonable you sound."

"I can be unreasonable if it helps."

"Please don't."

"Then appreciate my growth."

She laughed.

Then she admitted that she was becoming nervous.

"What if I don't get it?"

Vikksy didn't dismiss the concern.

"Then you'll have auditioned for a bigger project, gained experience, and learned what you need to improve. It would be disappointing, obviously. You're allowed to want the role. Just don't make the result a judgment on your entire future."

Cassandra nodded.

"I really want this."

"I know."

"I want to show them that I'm capable of doing more than comedy."

"Then show them. You don't have to stop being funny to prove you can be serious. Range means being able to move between different kinds of truth."

She wrote that down too.

Vikksy noticed.

"Are you taking notes?"

"Yes."

"Please put my name beside that sentence."

"Why?"

"For future royalties."

She laughed.

"You're impossible."

"And yet my wisdom remains in demand."

AUDITION DAY

The audition took place at a casting studio in Lagos.

Cassandra arrived early, wearing a simple, elegant outfit and carrying her script.

The waiting room contained several other actresses.

Some were reviewing their scenes. Others were speaking quietly with their agents. One woman was practicing lines while pacing back and forth.

Cassandra sat down and took a breath.

She reminded herself that the other actresses were not her enemies.

They were people pursuing the same opportunity.

Some would perform brilliantly.

Some might be more experienced.

Some might suit the role better.

She could respect all of that without making herself smaller.

A casting assistant called her name.

"Cassandra?"

She stood.

"Yes."

"Please come in."

Inside the room sat the casting director, **Nneka Eze**, and the film's director, **David Afolayan**.

Irene Danjuma was also present, observing the session.

Cassandra greeted everyone.

Nneka smiled.

"Welcome, Cassandra. We understand this is your first major audition since *Almost on Purpose*."

"Yes, ma."

"We've seen the clip. You have a natural sense of timing. Today, we'd like to see how you approach a different kind of character."

Cassandra nodded.

David looked at the script.

"Tell us what you understand about Amara."

Cassandra answered carefully.

"I think she's someone who wants to appear independent because she believes needing help makes her weak. She's curious and determined, but she doesn't always know how to admit when she's afraid. The journey forces her to recognize that accepting help doesn't make her less capable."

David nodded.

"Good. Let's see the scene."

Cassandra moved into position.

The camera began recording.

She became Amara.

In the scene, Amara was arguing with her older brother about the journal. He wanted to abandon the journey because he believed their family had already suffered enough.

Amara wanted to continue.

At first, she was confident.

She spoke quickly, defending the journey and dismissing his concerns.

Then he told her that their mother was worried.

Cassandra paused.

The character's confidence faltered.

For a moment, Amara had nothing to say.

Then she smiled, attempting to hide the hurt.

"Of course she's worried. Mum worries when I leave the house to buy bread. Last week, she called me twice because I was taking too long at the shop."

The line earned a small laugh from the room.

Cassandra continued.

"But this matters. Granddad spent years writing all of this down. He wanted somebody to read it. Somebody to understand what he was trying to tell us."

Her voice softened.

"And every time we decide that something is too difficult, we pretend we're being sensible. Sometimes we are. Sometimes we're just afraid of finding out what happens if we try."

She stopped.

The silence remained.

She didn't rush to fill it.

Then she looked at the imaginary person standing before her.

"I'm afraid too. I just don't want fear to be the only thing making decisions for me."

"Cut," David said.

Cassandra returned to herself.

The room was quiet.

Nneka glanced at David.

He nodded.

"Thank you, Cassandra. We'd like to try something else."

They asked her to perform the same scene with a different emotional approach.

This time, they wanted Amara to conceal her vulnerability more aggressively.

Cassandra tried again.

Then they asked her to improvise a short scene in which Amara discovered that the journal contained a message addressed specifically to her.

She had no prepared lines.

She had to react.

Cassandra took a breath.

She imagined the message.

She imagined a grandfather she had never met, leaving behind words that seemed to understand her better than she understood herself.

Her eyes moved across the imaginary page.

She smiled faintly.

Then her expression changed.

The message had mentioned a memory she shared with him, something she had almost forgotten.

Cassandra's voice became quiet.

"You remembered."

She paused.

"I thought nobody remembered that."

She looked down.

For a moment, she seemed to be listening to someone who was no longer there.

Then she smiled through the emotion.

"Well, Granddad, you could have told me this while you were alive. You know I don't enjoy doing emotional homework."

The room laughed softly.

Cassandra allowed the humor to remain, then returned to the tenderness of the moment.

She finished the scene.

David leaned back in his chair.

"Thank you."

Nneka smiled.

"We appreciate your work today. We'll be in touch."

Cassandra thanked them and left the room.

She had done everything she could.

Now came the part no amount of rehearsal could control.

Waiting.

THE RESULT

Cassandra returned to the waiting room and sat down.

She didn't immediately reach for her phone.

She simply breathed.

After a few minutes, she checked her messages.

Rebecca had sent a photograph of a plate of food.

REBECCA: I am eating in your honour.

CASSANDRA: You eat in honour of yourself every day.

REBECCA: And today, I am expanding the scope of the celebration.

Vikksy had sent a message too.

VIKKSY: How did it go?

Cassandra typed:

CASSANDRA: I think I did well.

She paused, then added:

CASSANDRA: I really tried.

His reply arrived quickly.

VIKKSY: That's what I wanted to hear. Go and eat something. You have spent the last few days feeding your brain and forgetting that the rest of your body is a stakeholder.

Cassandra laughed.

She had just finished replying when another message appeared.

It was from Nneka Eze.

Thank you for attending today's audition. The director would like to invite you to a second-round screen test with a small number of shortlisted candidates. Our office will contact you with the details.

Cassandra stared at the message.

A second round.

She hadn't been rejected.

She hadn't been offered the role either.

She had been shortlisted.

Her heart began beating faster.

She called Rebecca.

Rebecca answered immediately.

"Tell me everything."

Cassandra read the message aloud.

Rebecca screamed.

Cassandra held the phone away from her ear.

"Rebecca! I need my hearing for my career!"

"YOU'VE BEEN SHORTLISTED!"

"I KNOW!"

"THEN WHY ARE YOU SPEAKING SO QUIETLY?"

"BECAUSE WE ARE ON A PHONE CALL!"

Rebecca began laughing.

Within minutes, Cassandra had also called Vikksy.

He listened, then said, "That's progress. Now, don't spend the next three days mentally accepting the role and choosing your wardrobe for the premiere."

Cassandra paused.

"I wasn't."

"Your silence is suspicious."

She laughed.

"I'll prepare for the screen test."

"Good. Celebrate tonight. Prepare tomorrow. That's the sequence."

Cassandra smiled.

"Thank you."

"You're welcome."

He paused.

"And Cass?"

"Yes?"

"I'm proud of you. Whatever happens next, you've already shown that you can compete for opportunities at a higher level. Keep building on that."

She felt the words settle somewhere deep inside her.

"Thank you, Vikksy."

This time, he didn't ruin the moment with a joke.

Not immediately, anyway.

After a few seconds, he added, "I shall now return to my regular programming."

Cassandra laughed.

"There you are."

THE NEXT DOOR

That evening, Cassandra sat with her script open beside her.

She had a second-round screen test ahead of her, another chance to show what she could do.

The role was not hers yet.

She understood that.

But she had made it further than she had expected, and she was learning how to stand in uncertainty without allowing it to swallow her confidence.

She thought about Irene Danjuma, who had recommended her without promising her success.

She thought about Mrs. Bisi, who had taught her to trust the truth of a scene.

She thought about Rebecca, who could turn almost any serious occasion into a celebration involving spreadsheets and snacks.

She thought about Vikksy, who had helped her prepare without trying to take ownership of her achievement.

And she thought about her children.

Nelson and Kayla were still too young to understand why an audition mattered or why their mother sometimes had to spend long hours away from home.

But she hoped that one day they would understand that she had tried to build something meaningful, not just for herself, but for the people she loved.

Cassandra turned to a fresh page in her notebook.

She wrote:

I DO NOT NEED TO KNOW HOW THE WHOLE STORY ENDS. I JUST NEED TO BE READY FOR THE NEXT SCENE.

She smiled at the sentence.

Then she returned to her script.

Tomorrow, she would prepare again.

Because somewhere beyond the next audition, the next film, and the next opportunity, there was a version of her life she had not yet imagined.

And she intended to meet that version of herself with courage, humor, and both feet firmly on the ground.

Even if the shoes were uncomfortable.

CASSANDRA: BORN TO BE A STAR

CHAPTER NINE: EVERY STAR HAS TO SURVIVE A SCREEN TEST

The morning of Cassandra's second-round screen test began with three alarms, two missed calls from Rebecca, and one deeply insulting message from Vikksy.

VIKKSY: Good morning, future international sensation. Please confirm that you are awake, alive, and not negotiating with your pillow.

Cassandra stared at the message.

CASSANDRA: I'm awake.

VIKKSY: Excellent. Your career has survived another night.

CASSANDRA: Do you have anything useful to say?

VIKKSY: Yes. Eat breakfast.

She rolled her eyes.

CASSANDRA: I knew I shouldn't have asked.

VIKKSY: You asked for useful information. I delivered. Your disappointment is not covered by the warranty.

Cassandra laughed despite herself.

She got out of bed, washed up, ate breakfast, and reviewed her notes.

Today's screen test was different from her previous auditions. Instead of performing alone before a small panel, she would act opposite another shortlisted performer while the production team recorded the scene.

They wanted to see how the actors worked together.

Could Cassandra listen naturally?

Could she react when another actor changed the timing?

Could she remain believable when a scene didn't unfold exactly as she expected?

The test was designed to reveal something that a polished monologue could not.

Cassandra understood the assignment.

She also understood that her stomach had apparently misunderstood it as a declaration of war.

OPERATION: DON'T EMBARRASS YOURSELF

At 8:10 a.m., Rebecca called.

"Are you ready?"

"I'm preparing."

"That's not what I asked."

"I'm as ready as I can be."

Rebecca nodded thoughtfully.

"Good. Remember, you're not going there to prove that you're better than everybody else. You're going there to show them what you can do."

Cassandra smiled.

"Vikksy said something similar."

Rebecca looked offended.

"Why is that man always trespassing on my territory?"

"Your territory?"

"Emotional support and unsolicited wisdom. We need clearer boundaries."

Cassandra laughed.

Rebecca continued.

"Seriously, Cass. You've worked hard. Don't spend the entire audition worrying about the result. Concentrate on the scene."

"I will."

"And when you come back, tell me everything."

"Obviously."

"Even the boring parts."

"Rebecca, you want a full report?"

"I want a comprehensive account. Include names, dialogue, facial expressions, and any suspicious behaviour."

Cassandra shook her head.

"You're studying Business Administration, not intelligence gathering."

Rebecca smiled.

"Business is information. Information is power. Power is influence. Influence is how I eventually become the friend of a famous actress."

"You're already my friend."

Rebecca paused.

Then she grinned.

"That was beautiful. Please repeat it while I record."

Cassandra ended the call.

She was smiling when she picked up her bag.

That was the thing about Rebecca. She could make Cassandra laugh without making her dream seem small. Beneath the jokes was a friend who believed in her, sometimes so enthusiastically that Cassandra suspected Rebecca was already planning the celebration for an award that had not yet been invented.

THE OTHER ACTOR

The screen test took place at a larger studio than Cassandra had visited before.

A production assistant welcomed her and led her into a waiting area.

Three other actors were already there.

One of them was a young man in a blue shirt, quietly reading the script. Another was speaking with his agent. The third was checking something on a tablet.

Cassandra greeted them and sat down.

A few minutes later, the young man in the blue shirt looked up.

"You're Cassandra, right?"

"Yes."

"I'm Femi. I'll be reading Daniel's role for the screen test."

She smiled.

"Nice to meet you."

"Same here. I watched your clip from *Almost on Purpose*."

Cassandra laughed.

"That clip is following me everywhere."

"That's usually a good sign."

"Unless I said something embarrassing."

"Then it's a very permanent sign."

They laughed.

Femi had appeared in several television productions and a supporting role in a recent romantic comedy. He was experienced enough to feel comfortable in the room, but not so established that he treated the audition like a casual appointment.

They discussed the script while waiting.

Femi pointed to a line in the scene.

"This part is interesting. Amara says she doesn't care what her brother thinks, but then she immediately asks whether he thinks she's making a mistake."

Cassandra nodded.

"She's trying to convince herself more than she's trying to convince him."

"Exactly."

They discussed the scene's emotional shifts and how their characters might react to each other.

Cassandra liked that Femi didn't treat rehearsal as a competition. He wanted the scene to work.

That mattered.

A good scene required more than one person trying to look impressive. It required both actors to give each other something worth responding to.

The casting assistant opened the door.

"Cassandra? Femi? We're ready for you."

They stood.

Femi smiled.

"Let's go make some imaginary family problems."

Cassandra laughed.

"Please. My real family is already doing enough."

THE SCREEN TEST

Inside the studio, director David Afolayan stood beside the camera.

Casting director Nneka Eze sat near the monitor, reviewing the scene.

Irene Danjuma was present again.

She smiled when Cassandra entered.

"Good morning."

"Good morning, ma."

David explained the setup.

The scene took place in the family home. Amara had discovered that her brother had secretly contacted someone who wanted to purchase their grandfather's journal.

Her brother believed selling it would solve their family's financial problems.

Amara believed the journal was worth more than money.

But underneath the disagreement lay a deeper conflict. Amara feared that her family was losing its connection to the past, while her brother feared that she was sacrificing their present for a memory.

David finished explaining.

"I want the argument to feel like two people who love each other but have reached the limits of their patience. Neither character should be entirely right or entirely wrong."

Cassandra nodded.

"Understood."

"Good. Let's begin."

The camera rolled.

Femi, as Amara's brother, held the journal.

"I spoke to the buyer."

Cassandra looked at him.

"You did what?"

"He made a reasonable offer."

"That wasn't the question."

"I know what the question was."

"Then I'm impressed. We have achieved the first miracle of the morning."

Femi's expression tightened.

"Amara, we're struggling. You know that. Mum is worried about the bills. We can't keep pretending that everything will work itself out."

Cassandra stepped closer.

"I'm not pretending anything."

"Then why are you acting as if this book is going to save us?"

She looked at the journal.

For a moment, her anger softened.

"Because it mattered to him."

"He isn't here anymore."

The words struck harder than Amara expected.

Cassandra fell silent.

Femi continued.

"And I'm sorry, but we can't keep making decisions based on what Granddad might have wanted. We have to live with what we have now."

Cassandra looked at him.

"And what if what we have now is all we've got because nobody bothered to understand what came before it?"

Femi shook his head.

"Not everything is a mystery waiting for you to solve."

"Not everything is a problem waiting for you to sell."

The words came out sharper than she intended.

For a moment, neither character spoke.

Then Cassandra looked down at the journal.

Her voice softened.

"I know you're trying to help. I know you're tired. I'm tired too."

She took a breath.

"But I don't want us to reach a point where we can't remember anything about him except how much his things were worth."

Femi looked away.

Cassandra continued.

"You can disagree with me. You can tell me I'm being unreasonable. You can even tell me that I'm making a mistake."

She paused.

"But please don't make the decision before we've had the chance to understand what we're giving up."

The scene ended in silence.

"Cut," David said.

Cassandra returned to herself.

David looked at the monitor.

"Good. Let's adjust the next take."

He gave Femi a different instruction. This time, the brother would be less defensive and more visibly exhausted.

He asked Cassandra to let Amara's anger emerge from fear rather than certainty.

They tried again.

The second take was different.

Femi played the brother as someone who had been carrying the family's worries for months. Cassandra responded with more tenderness, allowing Amara to recognize her brother's exhaustion even while disagreeing with him.

The argument became less about winning and more about two people trying to protect their family in different ways.

When the scene ended, the room remained quiet.

David nodded.

"That's closer to what I'm looking for."

Nneka made a note.

Irene smiled at Cassandra.

"Good work."

Cassandra thanked them.

But David wasn't finished.

"One more thing. I'd like you to improvise a short scene. Amara discovers a letter from her grandfather addressed to her. You haven't read it before. Femi, you'll be her brother. You enter the room while she's reading."

Cassandra nodded.

They took their positions.

The camera rolled.

Cassandra imagined unfolding the letter.

She read the first few lines silently.

Then her expression changed.

Femi entered.

"What is it?"

She didn't answer.

"Amara?"

Cassandra looked up.

"He wrote to me."

Femi stepped closer.

"What does it say?"

She looked down at the letter.

"He says he always knew I'd be the one to ask questions."

A faint smile appeared on her face.

"He says I remind him of himself."

Femi smiled.

"That sounds like a compliment."

Cassandra shook her head.

"It sounds like a warning."

Femi laughed softly.

Then Cassandra's smile faded.

"He says he was afraid when he was young. Afraid of leaving home. Afraid of disappointing his parents. Afraid of choosing the wrong life."

She swallowed.

"And he says he wishes somebody had told him that being afraid doesn't mean you're making the wrong decision."

The room was still.

Cassandra looked at the letter again.

"I wish I'd known him."

Femi sat beside her.

"Maybe you do."

She looked at him.

He nodded toward the letter.

"Maybe this is how you get to know him."

Cassandra smiled through her emotion.

For a few seconds, she remained in the moment.

Then David called, "Cut."

He looked at Nneka.

Nneka nodded.

"Thank you, both of you. That was excellent."

Cassandra stepped away from the camera, feeling a little unsteady.

She had done it.

She had found something truthful in an unfamiliar scene without needing a prepared speech or a carefully rehearsed expression.

Irene approached her.

"That last scene was very good."

"Thank you, ma."

"Do you know what I liked most?"

Cassandra shook her head.

"You didn't rush the emotion. You allowed yourself to discover it. That's important. Keep working on that."

Cassandra nodded.

"I will."

Irene smiled.

"And keep your sense of humour. Serious acting doesn't require you to become a permanently miserable person."

Cassandra laughed.

"I'll remember that."

"Good. Some people enter this industry and begin behaving as if happiness is a sign of insufficient artistic depth."

Cassandra burst out laughing.

"That's a very specific description, ma."

"I've been around for a while."

THE WAITING GAME

Cassandra returned to the hostel that afternoon.

She had performed well, but she knew that other actors had also performed well. The role was important, and the production team had several strong candidates to consider.

She decided not to spend the entire evening refreshing her email.

Instead, she called her children.

Grandma answered.

Nelson appeared first.

"Mummy!"

"Hello, my love!"

"Are you finished acting?"

"For today, yes."

"Did you win?"

Cassandra smiled.

"Win what?"

"The acting."

She laughed.

"That's not exactly how it works, sweetheart."

Nelson looked confused.

"Then how do you know if you win?"

Cassandra thought about it.

"You do your best, you learn, and sometimes people choose you for a role. Sometimes they choose somebody else. Either way, you keep learning."

Nelson considered this.

"So if they don't choose you, you try again?"

"Exactly."

He nodded with great seriousness.

"Okay. But I think they should choose you."

Cassandra felt her heart melt.

"Thank you, baby."

Kayla appeared beside him.

"Mummy, are you a princess now?"

"Not yet."

"Why?"

Cassandra laughed.

"Because I'm auditioning to be an actress, not a princess."

Kayla frowned.

"Can't you be both?"

Cassandra looked at the screen.

Her daughter had just presented a career strategy more appealing than several business proposals she had encountered.

"That," Cassandra said, "is an excellent question."

Grandma laughed in the background.

They talked a little longer before Cassandra ended the call.

She sat quietly, smiling.

Whatever happened with the audition, she had learned something important.

Her children didn't need her to be the most famous woman in the world.

They needed her to be their mother.

And she could pursue a great dream without forgetting that simple truth.

THE CALL

The decision came two days later.

Cassandra was at PAU, leaving a lecture with Sarah and John, when her phone rang.

The caller was Nneka Eze.

Cassandra stepped away from her friends.

"Good afternoon, ma."

"Good afternoon, Cassandra. I hope you're well."

"Yes, ma. Thank you."

"We've completed the screen tests. The director and production team were very impressed with your work."

Cassandra held her breath.

"We would like to offer you the role of Amara in *The Map of Tomorrow*."

For a moment, she heard nothing else.

The campus noise seemed to fade.

She pressed a hand against her chest.

"Thank you, ma. Thank you so much."

Nneka explained the next steps, including the production schedule, script discussions, contract review, and a meeting with the director.

Cassandra listened carefully, asked a few questions, and thanked her again before ending the call.

Then she stood completely still.

Sarah approached.

"Cass? What happened?"

Cassandra turned toward her.

"They offered me the role."

Sarah screamed.

John nearly dropped his bag.

"WHICH ROLE?"

"The film! *The Map of Tomorrow*! I'm playing Amara!"

Sarah grabbed her in a hug.

John began celebrating.

A few students turned to look.

Cassandra laughed, crying a little now that the shock had finally caught up with her.

She had been selected for a larger production.

A role that demanded a different kind of performance.

A chance to work with an experienced director and a cast that included actors she admired.

She was moving forward.

Not because somebody had handed her a dream without asking anything of her.

Because she had prepared, listened, learned, and shown them what she could do.

She called Rebecca.

Rebecca answered with her usual greeting.

"Tell me good news."

Cassandra laughed.

"How do you know it's good news?"

"Because if it were bad news, you would have sent me a message saying, 'Are you busy?'"

Cassandra told her.

Rebecca screamed so loudly that Cassandra pulled the phone away from her ear.

"I KNEW IT!"

"No, you didn't!"

"I HAD FAITH!"

"Those are different things!"

"Let me enjoy my prophetic moment!"

Cassandra laughed.

Then she called Vikksy.

He listened quietly while she explained.

When she finished, he exhaled.

"Cass, that's huge. Congratulations."

"Thank you."

"You went into that audition prepared, you trusted yourself, and you earned their confidence. I'm genuinely happy for you."

She smiled.

"I couldn't have prepared as well without your help."

"I helped you prepare. You did the audition. Both things can be true."

She was quiet for a moment.

Then he added, "Now, please don't forget your university assignments because your fictional grandfather has left you a letter."

Cassandra burst out laughing.

"I hate you."

"No, you don't. You're just experiencing the emotional complexity of friendship."

"Goodbye, Vikksy."

"Congratulations again, Cass."

She ended the call.

And this time, she allowed herself to celebrate without immediately worrying about what could go wrong next.

She had earned the moment.

She was allowed to enjoy it.

CHAPTER TEN: TWO MOVIES, ONE MOTHER, AND A VERY FULL CALENDAR

The next few weeks changed Cassandra's life in ways she had not anticipated.

She was still filming *Almost on Purpose*.

She was preparing for *The Map of Tomorrow*.

She was still a 200-level Film and Multimedia Studies student at Pan-Atlantic University.

And she was still the mother of Nelson and Kayla, two children who considered her career exciting but remained deeply suspicious of any activity that prevented her from attending to their immediate requests.

One afternoon, Nelson called while Cassandra was reviewing her new script.

"Mummy?"

"Yes, baby?"

"Are you working?"

"Yes, sweetheart."

"Can you stop?"

Cassandra smiled.

"Not right now. I need to finish reading something."

"Why?"

"Because I have to prepare for my next film."

Nelson considered this.

"Can the film wait?"

Cassandra laughed.

"Unfortunately, the film has a schedule."

"So do I."

She raised an eyebrow.

"What schedule?"

"My eating schedule."

Cassandra burst out laughing.

"Nelson, you ate less than an hour ago!"

"I'm planning ahead."

Kayla's voice came from somewhere in the background.

"Mummy! I want to show you my drawing!"

"Bring it, sweetheart."

Kayla appeared holding a picture of a woman wearing a crown, standing beside two smaller figures.

Cassandra examined it carefully.

"Who's this?"

"That's you."

Cassandra smiled.

"And who are these two?"

"Me and Nelson."

"Why am I wearing a crown?"

Kayla looked at her as if the answer should have been obvious.

"Because you're a queen."

Cassandra's eyes softened.

"That's beautiful, my love."

Kayla nodded.

"I want a crown too."

Nelson appeared beside her.

"I want one as well."

Grandma laughed.

"Now everybody wants to be royalty."

Cassandra smiled at the screen.

"There's enough crown for everybody."

Then she added, "But the king and queen still have to brush their teeth."

Nelson looked offended.

"That's not in the royal rules."

"It is now."

Kayla giggled.

Cassandra promised to call again after rehearsals.

When the call ended, she looked at the drawing for another moment.

She had spent so much time imagining the day she would become a famous actress that she had occasionally forgotten to imagine how she would feel along the way.

This was part of it.

The long days.

The difficult choices.

The moments when work demanded her attention and her children wanted her beside them.

She didn't want to choose between being a good mother and becoming a successful actress.

She wanted to learn how to honour both responsibilities.

That would take planning, support, and the willingness to admit when she needed help.

Fortunately, she knew people.

Unfortunately, those people were very annoying.

THE GREAT CALENDAR SUMMIT

Cassandra called Rebecca and Vikksy that evening.

Rebecca answered first.

"Why have you summoned this meeting?"

"Because I need help organizing my schedule."

Vikksy joined the call.

"Excellent. A meeting about scheduling. Nothing says entertainment quite like a spreadsheet."

Rebecca pointed at the screen.

"Don't mock spreadsheets. Civilization depends on them."

"That explains several things about civilization."

Cassandra laughed.

"Please. Both of you. I need to organize my university work, filming schedule, preparation for the new film, and time with the children."

Rebecca's expression changed.

"Okay. Let's take it seriously."

Vikksy nodded.

"Agreed."

For the next forty minutes, they worked through the problem.

Rebecca helped Cassandra list her deadlines and identify which tasks needed to be completed first. They discussed her class schedule, assignments, filming days, and the amount of time she needed to prepare for the new role.

Vikksy suggested creating a shared calendar with separate categories for university, production, family, and personal time.

He also helped her set reminders and organize the script files on her phone.

"Back everything up," he advised. "If your phone develops a sudden interest in retirement, you don't want your scripts disappearing with it."

Cassandra nodded.

"Good point."

Rebecca added a list of weekly priorities.

"Don't schedule every minute," she said. "Leave room for unexpected things. If you plan every hour perfectly, one delayed meeting will destroy the entire week."

Vikksy looked impressed.

"That was intelligent."

Rebecca smiled.

"I have my moments."

"Don't worry. I'll notify the authorities."

Cassandra laughed.

They continued until she had a workable schedule.

It wasn't perfect.

Some days would be difficult. Some filming sessions would run late. Some university deadlines would require extra effort.

But she now had a clearer picture of what needed to happen and when.

When they finished, Cassandra looked at both of them.

"Thank you. Seriously."

Rebecca smiled.

"That's what friends are for."

Vikksy nodded.

"Exactly. We provide emotional support, organizational assistance, and occasional insults."

"Mostly insults," Cassandra said.

"Those are premium features."

Rebecca laughed.

Then she became thoughtful.

"Cass, I know you're excited about these opportunities. And you should be. But don't feel like you have to prove that you can do everything alone."

Cassandra listened.

"Ask for help when you need it. Rest when you need to. And if the schedule becomes too much, say so before you reach the point where your body files a resignation letter."

Vikksy nodded.

"She's right. You can't do your best work if you're permanently exhausted."

Cassandra smiled.

"I'll try to remember."

Rebecca pointed at her.

"Don't just remember. Put it in the calendar."

Cassandra groaned.

"Rebecca!"

"Rest is now a scheduled activity."

Vikksy nodded solemnly.

"Finally, a spreadsheet with moral value."

MEETING THE DIRECTOR

The following Monday, Cassandra attended her first production meeting for *The Map of Tomorrow*.

The film's director, David Afolayan, had assembled the principal cast to discuss the story, characters, and production plan.

Irene Danjuma would play Amara's mother.

Femi had been cast as her older brother.

Another experienced actor, **Bode Williams**, would play their uncle, a warm but stubborn man who knew more about the family's history than he was initially willing to reveal.

Cassandra sat around the table with the other actors, listening as David explained the film's central theme.

"This is a story about what we inherit," he said. "Not just money or property. We inherit memories, expectations, fears, habits, and sometimes questions that nobody before us had the courage to answer."

He looked around the room.

"But I don't want this film to feel heavy all the time. These characters love one another. They tease one another. They make mistakes, eat together, argue about ordinary things, and find reasons to laugh even when life is difficult."

Cassandra smiled.

She liked that.

David continued.

"The adventure matters, but the family is the heart of the story. If we get the relationships right, the journey will mean something."

The cast discussed their characters.

Cassandra learned more about Amara's childhood, her relationship with her brother, and the memories that had shaped her.

She asked questions about how Amara's confidence changed throughout the story.

David answered thoughtfully.

"At the beginning, she believes courage means doing everything herself. By the end, she understands that courage can also mean trusting other people."

Cassandra wrote that down.

It was a lesson she was beginning to understand in her own life.

She had once believed that becoming successful meant proving she could handle everything.

Now she was learning that growth sometimes meant allowing people to help without feeling that she had become less capable.

The meeting ended with a discussion about the filming schedule and preparation for the first scenes.

As everyone began gathering their things, Irene approached Cassandra.

"How are you feeling about the role?"

"Excited. A little nervous."

"Good. Keep both feelings. Excitement will give you energy, and nervousness will remind you to prepare."

Cassandra smiled.

"That's a very elegant way of saying I should do my homework."

Irene laughed.

"Years in the industry have taught me to make ordinary advice sound expensive."

Cassandra burst out laughing.

Irene smiled.

"You'll be fine. Keep asking questions. Don't be afraid of looking inexperienced. Everyone starts somewhere."

Cassandra nodded.

She was grateful that Irene had recommended her, but even more grateful that the older actress continued treating her like a person who could learn rather than a young talent who needed constant praise.

That was the kind of mentor Cassandra wanted to become for somebody else one day.

THE FIRST PUBLIC APPEARANCE

A week later, the producers of *Almost on Purpose* invited Cassandra to attend a small promotional event.

The film was approaching its final stages of production, and the team wanted to introduce the principal cast to members of the media and a few invited guests.

Cassandra would be interviewed briefly about her experience.

It was her first time speaking publicly about acting as a professional.

She prepared her answers carefully.

Then she called Vikksy.

"Can you help me practice?"

"Certainly. Please state your name, occupation, and why you have summoned the nation's leading expert in unnecessary confidence."

Cassandra laughed.

"I need interview practice."

"Understood. Let us begin."

He adopted a serious expression.

"Miss Cassandra, how does it feel to be the next great actress?"

Cassandra stared at him.

"That is not how they're going to ask the question."

"You're right. They may ask how it feels to be the next greatest actress."

"Vikksy!"

He laughed.

Then he became more helpful.

"Seriously, keep your answers honest and concise. Talk about what you learned, what you enjoyed, and what the project means to you. You don't have to sound like you've memorized a motivational speech."

Cassandra nodded.

"Okay."

"And if they ask about your future, you can talk about the kinds of stories you want to tell. You don't need to predict how famous you'll become."

"That makes sense."

He paused.

"Also, don't say that working with Tobi was wonderful if you actually spent half the production threatening him over cupcakes."

Cassandra burst out laughing.

"How do you know so much about my life?"

"Because you tell me everything."

She smiled.

"Fair enough."

They practiced several questions.

Vikksy challenged her to answer naturally rather than relying on polished phrases. When she became too rehearsed, he interrupted.

"Stop."

"What?"

"You sound like a brochure."

Cassandra laughed.

"What does that mean?"

"It means you sound as if someone is about to hand me a leaflet about the benefits of choosing you."

She shook her head.

"You're so annoying."

"Yet the rehearsal is working."

Unfortunately, he was right.

By the end of the call, Cassandra felt more comfortable speaking about her work.

She thanked him.

He accepted her gratitude with the modesty of a man receiving a national award.

"You're welcome. Please mention me in your acceptance speech."

"You're not getting mentioned."

"I'll accept that as a challenge."

THE INTERVIEW

The promotional event took place at a small venue in Lagos.

Cassandra wore an elegant outfit and arrived with the production team.

She greeted the cast, spoke with a few guests, and tried not to look at her phone every thirty seconds.

When the interviewer approached, she took a breath.

"Cassandra, welcome. This is your first feature film role. What has the experience been like?"

She smiled.

"It's been exciting and challenging. I've learned so much from the director and the other actors. I've also learned that a scene that looks simple on screen can take a lot of work behind the camera."

The interviewer laughed.

"Any surprises?"

Cassandra thought about the missing cupcakes.

"Let's just say I've discovered that filmmaking requires patience, teamwork, and occasionally an emergency supply of snacks."

The interviewer laughed.

The conversation continued.

They discussed Maya, the romantic comedy's themes, and Cassandra's experience transitioning from studying Film and Multimedia at PAU to working on a professional production.

"What kind of actress do you hope to become?"

Cassandra paused.

It was a question she had considered many times.

"I want to become an actress who can tell different kinds of stories honestly. I love comedy, but I also want to explore drama, adventure, and characters who challenge the audience to see the world differently. I want people to recognize something real in the characters I play."

The interviewer nodded.

"That's a thoughtful answer."

Cassandra smiled.

"Thank you."

After the interview, she stepped away from the cameras and exhaled.

She had done it.

She hadn't tried to sound like somebody else.

She hadn't pretended to know everything.

She had simply spoken about the work she loved and the person she hoped to become.

Tobi approached her.

"That went well."

Cassandra smiled.

"Thank you."

He nodded.

"You handled the questions nicely. You didn't even mention my tragic cupcake experience."

"Some stories are too painful to share publicly."

Tobi placed a hand over his chest.

"I appreciate your discretion."

They laughed.

Then Mrs. Bisi joined them.

"Good interview, Cassandra. You're becoming more comfortable speaking about your work. That matters."

Cassandra thanked her.

It was a small moment, but it felt important.

She was learning how to inhabit the professional side of acting, not just the creative side.

And she was beginning to understand that every opportunity, even a short interview, was another chance to show people who she was.

A MESSAGE FROM THE FUTURE

That evening, Cassandra returned home and found a message from Rebecca.

REBECCA: I watched your interview.

Cassandra smiled.

CASSANDRA: And?

REBECCA: You looked beautiful, confident, and professional.

Cassandra felt a warm rush of happiness.

Then another message arrived.

REBECCA: However, you failed to acknowledge the Business Administration department's contribution to your success.

Cassandra burst out laughing.

CASSANDRA: What contribution?

REBECCA: Emotional support. Strategic consultation. Snack provision. Calendar management. You are welcome.

CASSANDRA: I'll make sure to include you in the next interview.

REBECCA: Excellent. My media training begins tomorrow.

Vikksy joined the conversation.

VIKKSY: I would also like to remind the public that I provided technical support, audition preparation, interview coaching, and several excellent jokes.

REBECCA: Your jokes are under review.

VIKKSY: By whom?

REBECCA: The public.

VIKKSY: The public has poor judgment. It keeps buying phones with insufficient storage.

Cassandra laughed so hard she had to put the phone down.

Then she typed:

CASSANDRA: Both of you should be banned from managing anything.

Rebecca replied:

REBECCA: That sounds like something a person says before becoming famous enough to need management.

Vikksy followed immediately.

VIKKSY: We shall discuss the matter at the next board meeting.

Cassandra shook her head.

She was surrounded by people who genuinely wanted her to succeed, even if their preferred methods involved spreadsheets, technical lectures, and jokes that arrived before she had finished reading the previous message.

She wouldn't trade them for anything.

THE NEXT CHAPTER OF HER LIFE

Later that night, Cassandra sat at her desk.

Her scripts were arranged neatly.

Her calendar was updated.

Her university assignments were listed.

Her next filming dates were marked.

She had made a plan for the coming weeks, including time to call her children and visit home whenever her schedule allowed.

It wasn't a glamorous scene.

There were no cameras, no red carpets, and no interviewer asking her what it felt like to be a rising star.

There was simply a young woman working carefully toward a life she wanted.

She thought about the girl she had been before the first audition.

The girl who had dreamed about acting but wondered whether anyone would ever take her seriously.

That girl would have found the current version of her life almost unbelievable.

Two film roles.

An industry mentor.

A growing professional network.

A public interview.

And more opportunities on the horizon.

Cassandra smiled.

She still had a long way to go.

She knew that.

There would be difficult auditions, disappointing days, unexpected successes, and moments when she would need to rethink her plans.

But she no longer felt as though she were standing outside the door of the life she wanted.

She was inside it now.

Learning.

Working.

Growing.

And discovering that the dream was not a single extraordinary moment waiting somewhere in the future.

It was also the ordinary work she did every day to make that future possible.

Her phone buzzed.

A message from Vikksy.

VIKKSY: Reminder: charge your phone before sleeping.

Cassandra stared at it.

Then she typed:

CASSANDRA: I HAVE 78%.

His response arrived immediately.

VIKKSY: Excellent. For once, your battery management reflects responsible decision-making.

She laughed.

CASSANDRA: Goodnight, Vikksy.

VIKKSY: Goodnight, Cass. Keep going. You're doing well.

She put the phone down.

Tomorrow, there would be another script to study, another responsibility to manage, and another opportunity to prepare for.

But tonight, Cassandra allowed herself to feel proud.

Not because she had become the biggest actress in the world.

Not yet.

Because she was becoming someone who could pursue a big dream without losing sight of the people and values that made the dream worth pursuing.

And that was a beautiful beginning.

CASSANDRA: BORN TO BE A STAR

CHAPTER NINE: EVERY STAR HAS TO SURVIVE A SCREEN TEST

The morning of Cassandra's second-round screen test began with three alarms, two missed calls from Rebecca, and one deeply insulting message from Vikksy.

VIKKSY: Good morning, future international sensation. Please confirm that you are awake, alive, and not negotiating with your pillow.

Cassandra stared at the message.

CASSANDRA: I'm awake.

VIKKSY: Excellent. Your career has survived another night.

CASSANDRA: Do you have anything useful to say?

VIKKSY: Yes. Eat breakfast.

She rolled her eyes.

CASSANDRA: I knew I shouldn't have asked.

VIKKSY: You asked for useful information. I delivered. Your disappointment is not covered by the warranty.

Cassandra laughed despite herself.

She got out of bed, washed up, ate breakfast, and reviewed her notes.

Today's screen test was different from her previous auditions. Instead of performing alone before a small panel, she would act opposite another shortlisted performer while the production team recorded the scene.

They wanted to see how the actors worked together.

Could Cassandra listen naturally?

Could she react when another actor changed the timing?

Could she remain believable when a scene didn't unfold exactly as she expected?

The test was designed to reveal something that a polished monologue could not.

Cassandra understood the assignment.

She also understood that her stomach had apparently misunderstood it as a declaration of war.

OPERATION: DON'T EMBARRASS YOURSELF

At 8:10 a.m., Rebecca called.

"Are you ready?"

"I'm preparing."

"That's not what I asked."

"I'm as ready as I can be."

Rebecca nodded thoughtfully.

"Good. Remember, you're not going there to prove that you're better than everybody else. You're going there to show them what you can do."

Cassandra smiled.

"Vikksy said something similar."

Rebecca looked offended.

"Why is that man always trespassing on my territory?"

"Your territory?"

"Emotional support and unsolicited wisdom. We need clearer boundaries."

Cassandra laughed.

Rebecca continued.

"Seriously, Cass. You've worked hard. Don't spend the entire audition worrying about the result. Concentrate on the scene."

"I will."

"And when you come back, tell me everything."

"Obviously."

"Even the boring parts."

"Rebecca, you want a full report?"

"I want a comprehensive account. Include names, dialogue, facial expressions, and any suspicious behaviour."

Cassandra shook her head.

"You're studying Business Administration, not intelligence gathering."

Rebecca smiled.

"Business is information. Information is power. Power is influence. Influence is how I eventually become the friend of a famous actress."

"You're already my friend."

Rebecca paused.

Then she grinned.

"That was beautiful. Please repeat it while I record."

Cassandra ended the call.

She was smiling when she picked up her bag.

That was the thing about Rebecca. She could make Cassandra laugh without making her dream seem small. Beneath the jokes was a friend who believed in her, sometimes so enthusiastically that Cassandra suspected Rebecca was already planning the celebration for an award that had not yet been invented.

THE OTHER ACTOR

The screen test took place at a larger studio than Cassandra had visited before.

A production assistant welcomed her and led her into a waiting area.

Three other actors were already there.

One of them was a young man in a blue shirt, quietly reading the script. Another was speaking with his agent. The third was checking something on a tablet.

Cassandra greeted them and sat down.

A few minutes later, the young man in the blue shirt looked up.

"You're Cassandra, right?"

"Yes."

"I'm Femi. I'll be reading Daniel's role for the screen test."

She smiled.

"Nice to meet you."

"Same here. I watched your clip from *Almost on Purpose*."

Cassandra laughed.

"That clip is following me everywhere."

"That's usually a good sign."

"Unless I said something embarrassing."

"Then it's a very permanent sign."

They laughed.

Femi had appeared in several television productions and a supporting role in a recent romantic comedy. He was experienced enough to feel comfortable in the room, but not so established that he treated the audition like a casual appointment.

They discussed the script while waiting.

Femi pointed to a line in the scene.

"This part is interesting. Amara says she doesn't care what her brother thinks, but then she immediately asks whether he thinks she's making a mistake."

Cassandra nodded.

"She's trying to convince herself more than she's trying to convince him."

"Exactly."

They discussed the scene's emotional shifts and how their characters might react to each other.

Cassandra liked that Femi didn't treat rehearsal as a competition. He wanted the scene to work.

That mattered.

A good scene required more than one person trying to look impressive. It required both actors to give each other something worth responding to.

The casting assistant opened the door.

"Cassandra? Femi? We're ready for you."

They stood.

Femi smiled.

"Let's go make some imaginary family problems."

Cassandra laughed.

"Please. My real family is already doing enough."

THE SCREEN TEST

Inside the studio, director David Afolayan stood beside the camera.

Casting director Nneka Eze sat near the monitor, reviewing the scene.

Irene Danjuma was present again.

She smiled when Cassandra entered.

"Good morning."

"Good morning, ma."

David explained the setup.

The scene took place in the family home. Amara had discovered that her brother had secretly contacted someone who wanted to purchase their grandfather's journal.

Her brother believed selling it would solve their family's financial problems.

Amara believed the journal was worth more than money.

But underneath the disagreement lay a deeper conflict. Amara feared that her family was losing its connection to the past, while her brother feared that she was sacrificing their present for a memory.

David finished explaining.

"I want the argument to feel like two people who love each other but have reached the limits of their patience. Neither character should be entirely right or entirely wrong."

Cassandra nodded.

"Understood."

"Good. Let's begin."

The camera rolled.

Femi, as Amara's brother, held the journal.

"I spoke to the buyer."

Cassandra looked at him.

"You did what?"

"He made a reasonable offer."

"That wasn't the question."

"I know what the question was."

"Then I'm impressed. We have achieved the first miracle of the morning."

Femi's expression tightened.

"Amara, we're struggling. You know that. Mum is worried about the bills. We can't keep pretending that everything will work itself out."

Cassandra stepped closer.

"I'm not pretending anything."

"Then why are you acting as if this book is going to save us?"

She looked at the journal.

For a moment, her anger softened.

"Because it mattered to him."

"He isn't here anymore."

The words struck harder than Amara expected.

Cassandra fell silent.

Femi continued.

"And I'm sorry, but we can't keep making decisions based on what Granddad might have wanted. We have to live with what we have now."

Cassandra looked at him.

"And what if what we have now is all we've got because nobody bothered to understand what came before it?"

Femi shook his head.

"Not everything is a mystery waiting for you to solve."

"Not everything is a problem waiting for you to sell."

The words came out sharper than she intended.

For a moment, neither character spoke.

Then Cassandra looked down at the journal.

Her voice softened.

"I know you're trying to help. I know you're tired. I'm tired too."

She took a breath.

"But I don't want us to reach a point where we can't remember anything about him except how much his things were worth."

Femi looked away.

Cassandra continued.

"You can disagree with me. You can tell me I'm being unreasonable. You can even tell me that I'm making a mistake."

She paused.

"But please don't make the decision before we've had the chance to understand what we're giving up."

The scene ended in silence.

"Cut," David said.

Cassandra returned to herself.

David looked at the monitor.

"Good. Let's adjust the next take."

He gave Femi a different instruction. This time, the brother would be less defensive and more visibly exhausted.

He asked Cassandra to let Amara's anger emerge from fear rather than certainty.

They tried again.

The second take was different.

Femi played the brother as someone who had been carrying the family's worries for months. Cassandra responded with more tenderness, allowing Amara to recognize her brother's exhaustion even while disagreeing with him.

The argument became less about winning and more about two people trying to protect their family in different ways.

When the scene ended, the room remained quiet.

David nodded.

"That's closer to what I'm looking for."

Nneka made a note.

Irene smiled at Cassandra.

"Good work."

Cassandra thanked them.

But David wasn't finished.

"One more thing. I'd like you to improvise a short scene. Amara discovers a letter from her grandfather addressed to her. You haven't read it before. Femi, you'll be her brother. You enter the room while she's reading."

Cassandra nodded.

They took their positions.

The camera rolled.

Cassandra imagined unfolding the letter.

She read the first few lines silently.

Then her expression changed.

Femi entered.

"What is it?"

She didn't answer.

"Amara?"

Cassandra looked up.

"He wrote to me."

Femi stepped closer.

"What does it say?"

She looked down at the letter.

"He says he always knew I'd be the one to ask questions."

A faint smile appeared on her face.

"He says I remind him of himself."

Femi smiled.

"That sounds like a compliment."

Cassandra shook her head.

"It sounds like a warning."

Femi laughed softly.

Then Cassandra's smile faded.

"He says he was afraid when he was young. Afraid of leaving home. Afraid of disappointing his parents. Afraid of choosing the wrong life."

She swallowed.

"And he says he wishes somebody had told him that being afraid doesn't mean you're making the wrong decision."

The room was still.

Cassandra looked at the letter again.

"I wish I'd known him."

Femi sat beside her.

"Maybe you do."

She looked at him.

He nodded toward the letter.

"Maybe this is how you get to know him."

Cassandra smiled through her emotion.

For a few seconds, she remained in the moment.

Then David called, "Cut."

He looked at Nneka.

Nneka nodded.

"Thank you, both of you. That was excellent."

Cassandra stepped away from the camera, feeling a little unsteady.

She had done it.

She had found something truthful in an unfamiliar scene without needing a prepared speech or a carefully rehearsed expression.

Irene approached her.

"That last scene was very good."

"Thank you, ma."

"Do you know what I liked most?"

Cassandra shook her head.

"You didn't rush the emotion. You allowed yourself to discover it. That's important. Keep working on that."

Cassandra nodded.

"I will."

Irene smiled.

"And keep your sense of humour. Serious acting doesn't require you to become a permanently miserable person."

Cassandra laughed.

"I'll remember that."

"Good. Some people enter this industry and begin behaving as if happiness is a sign of insufficient artistic depth."

Cassandra burst out laughing.

"That's a very specific description, ma."

"I've been around for a while."

THE WAITING GAME

Cassandra returned to the hostel that afternoon.

She had performed well, but she knew that other actors had also performed well. The role was important, and the production team had several strong candidates to consider.

She decided not to spend the entire evening refreshing her email.

Instead, she called her children.

Grandma answered.

Nelson appeared first.

"Mummy!"

"Hello, my love!"

"Are you finished acting?"

"For today, yes."

"Did you win?"

Cassandra smiled.

"Win what?"

"The acting."

She laughed.

"That's not exactly how it works, sweetheart."

Nelson looked confused.

"Then how do you know if you win?"

Cassandra thought about it.

"You do your best, you learn, and sometimes people choose you for a role. Sometimes they choose somebody else. Either way, you keep learning."

Nelson considered this.

"So if they don't choose you, you try again?"

"Exactly."

He nodded with great seriousness.

"Okay. But I think they should choose you."

Cassandra felt her heart melt.

"Thank you, baby."

Kayla appeared beside him.

"Mummy, are you a princess now?"

"Not yet."

"Why?"

Cassandra laughed.

"Because I'm auditioning to be an actress, not a princess."

Kayla frowned.

"Can't you be both?"

Cassandra looked at the screen.

Her daughter had just presented a career strategy more appealing than several business proposals she had encountered.

"That," Cassandra said, "is an excellent question."

Grandma laughed in the background.

They talked a little longer before Cassandra ended the call.

She sat quietly, smiling.

Whatever happened with the audition, she had learned something important.

Her children didn't need her to be the most famous woman in the world.

They needed her to be their mother.

And she could pursue a great dream without forgetting that simple truth.

THE CALL

The decision came two days later.

Cassandra was at PAU, leaving a lecture with Sarah and John, when her phone rang.

The caller was Nneka Eze.

Cassandra stepped away from her friends.

"Good afternoon, ma."

"Good afternoon, Cassandra. I hope you're well."

"Yes, ma. Thank you."

"We've completed the screen tests. The director and production team were very impressed with your work."

Cassandra held her breath.

"We would like to offer you the role of Amara in *The Map of Tomorrow*."

For a moment, she heard nothing else.

The campus noise seemed to fade.

She pressed a hand against her chest.

"Thank you, ma. Thank you so much."

Nneka explained the next steps, including the production schedule, script discussions, contract review, and a meeting with the director.

Cassandra listened carefully, asked a few questions, and thanked her again before ending the call.

Then she stood completely still.

Sarah approached.

"Cass? What happened?"

Cassandra turned toward her.

"They offered me the role."

Sarah screamed.

John nearly dropped his bag.

"WHICH ROLE?"

"The film! *The Map of Tomorrow*! I'm playing Amara!"

Sarah grabbed her in a hug.

John began celebrating.

A few students turned to look.

Cassandra laughed, crying a little now that the shock had finally caught up with her.

She had been selected for a larger production.

A role that demanded a different kind of performance.

A chance to work with an experienced director and a cast that included actors she admired.

She was moving forward.

Not because somebody had handed her a dream without asking anything of her.

Because she had prepared, listened, learned, and shown them what she could do.

She called Rebecca.

Rebecca answered with her usual greeting.

"Tell me good news."

Cassandra laughed.

"How do you know it's good news?"

"Because if it were bad news, you would have sent me a message saying, 'Are you busy?'"

Cassandra told her.

Rebecca screamed so loudly that Cassandra pulled the phone away from her ear.

"I KNEW IT!"

"No, you didn't!"

"I HAD FAITH!"

"Those are different things!"

"Let me enjoy my prophetic moment!"

Cassandra laughed.

Then she called Vikksy.

He listened quietly while she explained.

When she finished, he exhaled.

"Cass, that's huge. Congratulations."

"Thank you."

"You went into that audition prepared, you trusted yourself, and you earned their confidence. I'm genuinely happy for you."

She smiled.

"I couldn't have prepared as well without your help."

"I helped you prepare. You did the audition. Both things can be true."

She was quiet for a moment.

Then he added, "Now, please don't forget your university assignments because your fictional grandfather has left you a letter."

Cassandra burst out laughing.

"I hate you."

"No, you don't. You're just experiencing the emotional complexity of friendship."

"Goodbye, Vikksy."

"Congratulations again, Cass."

She ended the call.

And this time, she allowed herself to celebrate without immediately worrying about what could go wrong next.

She had earned the moment.

She was allowed to enjoy it.

CHAPTER TEN: TWO MOVIES, ONE MOTHER, AND A VERY FULL CALENDAR

The next few weeks changed Cassandra's life in ways she had not anticipated.

She was still filming *Almost on Purpose*.

She was preparing for *The Map of Tomorrow*.

She was still a 200-level Film and Multimedia Studies student at Pan-Atlantic University.

And she was still the mother of Nelson and Kayla, two children who considered her career exciting but remained deeply suspicious of any activity that prevented her from attending to their immediate requests.

One afternoon, Nelson called while Cassandra was reviewing her new script.

"Mummy?"

"Yes, baby?"

"Are you working?"

"Yes, sweetheart."

"Can you stop?"

Cassandra smiled.

"Not right now. I need to finish reading something."

"Why?"

"Because I have to prepare for my next film."

Nelson considered this.

"Can the film wait?"

Cassandra laughed.

"Unfortunately, the film has a schedule."

"So do I."

She raised an eyebrow.

"What schedule?"

"My eating schedule."

Cassandra burst out laughing.

"Nelson, you ate less than an hour ago!"

"I'm planning ahead."

Kayla's voice came from somewhere in the background.

"Mummy! I want to show you my drawing!"

"Bring it, sweetheart."

Kayla appeared holding a picture of a woman wearing a crown, standing beside two smaller figures.

Cassandra examined it carefully.

"Who's this?"

"That's you."

Cassandra smiled.

"And who are these two?"

"Me and Nelson."

"Why am I wearing a crown?"

Kayla looked at her as if the answer should have been obvious.

"Because you're a queen."

Cassandra's eyes softened.

"That's beautiful, my love."

Kayla nodded.

"I want a crown too."

Nelson appeared beside her.

"I want one as well."

Grandma laughed.

"Now everybody wants to be royalty."

Cassandra smiled at the screen.

"There's enough crown for everybody."

Then she added, "But the king and queen still have to brush their teeth."

Nelson looked offended.

"That's not in the royal rules."

"It is now."

Kayla giggled.

Cassandra promised to call again after rehearsals.

When the call ended, she looked at the drawing for another moment.

She had spent so much time imagining the day she would become a famous actress that she had occasionally forgotten to imagine how she would feel along the way.

This was part of it.

The long days.

The difficult choices.

The moments when work demanded her attention and her children wanted her beside them.

She didn't want to choose between being a good mother and becoming a successful actress.

She wanted to learn how to honour both responsibilities.

That would take planning, support, and the willingness to admit when she needed help.

Fortunately, she knew people.

Unfortunately, those people were very annoying.

THE GREAT CALENDAR SUMMIT

Cassandra called Rebecca and Vikksy that evening.

Rebecca answered first.

"Why have you summoned this meeting?"

"Because I need help organizing my schedule."

Vikksy joined the call.

"Excellent. A meeting about scheduling. Nothing says entertainment quite like a spreadsheet."

Rebecca pointed at the screen.

"Don't mock spreadsheets. Civilization depends on them."

"That explains several things about civilization."

Cassandra laughed.

"Please. Both of you. I need to organize my university work, filming schedule, preparation for the new film, and time with the children."

Rebecca's expression changed.

"Okay. Let's take it seriously."

Vikksy nodded.

"Agreed."

For the next forty minutes, they worked through the problem.

Rebecca helped Cassandra list her deadlines and identify which tasks needed to be completed first. They discussed her class schedule, assignments, filming days, and the amount of time she needed to prepare for the new role.

Vikksy suggested creating a shared calendar with separate categories for university, production, family, and personal time.

He also helped her set reminders and organize the script files on her phone.

"Back everything up," he advised. "If your phone develops a sudden interest in retirement, you don't want your scripts disappearing with it."

Cassandra nodded.

"Good point."

Rebecca added a list of weekly priorities.

"Don't schedule every minute," she said. "Leave room for unexpected things. If you plan every hour perfectly, one delayed meeting will destroy the entire week."

Vikksy looked impressed.

"That was intelligent."

Rebecca smiled.

"I have my moments."

"Don't worry. I'll notify the authorities."

Cassandra laughed.

They continued until she had a workable schedule.

It wasn't perfect.

Some days would be difficult. Some filming sessions would run late. Some university deadlines would require extra effort.

But she now had a clearer picture of what needed to happen and when.

When they finished, Cassandra looked at both of them.

"Thank you. Seriously."

Rebecca smiled.

"That's what friends are for."

Vikksy nodded.

"Exactly. We provide emotional support, organizational assistance, and occasional insults."

"Mostly insults," Cassandra said.

"Those are premium features."

Rebecca laughed.

Then she became thoughtful.

"Cass, I know you're excited about these opportunities. And you should be. But don't feel like you have to prove that you can do everything alone."

Cassandra listened.

"Ask for help when you need it. Rest when you need to. And if the schedule becomes too much, say so before you reach the point where your body files a resignation letter."

Vikksy nodded.

"She's right. You can't do your best work if you're permanently exhausted."

Cassandra smiled.

"I'll try to remember."

Rebecca pointed at her.

"Don't just remember. Put it in the calendar."

Cassandra groaned.

"Rebecca!"

"Rest is now a scheduled activity."

Vikksy nodded solemnly.

"Finally, a spreadsheet with moral value."

MEETING THE DIRECTOR

The following Monday, Cassandra attended her first production meeting for *The Map of Tomorrow*.

The film's director, David Afolayan, had assembled the principal cast to discuss the story, characters, and production plan.

Irene Danjuma would play Amara's mother.

Femi had been cast as her older brother.

Another experienced actor, **Bode Williams**, would play their uncle, a warm but stubborn man who knew more about the family's history than he was initially willing to reveal.

Cassandra sat around the table with the other actors, listening as David explained the film's central theme.

"This is a story about what we inherit," he said. "Not just money or property. We inherit memories, expectations, fears, habits, and sometimes questions that nobody before us had the courage to answer."

He looked around the room.

"But I don't want this film to feel heavy all the time. These characters love one another. They tease one another. They make mistakes, eat together, argue about ordinary things, and find reasons to laugh even when life is difficult."

Cassandra smiled.

She liked that.

David continued.

"The adventure matters, but the family is the heart of the story. If we get the relationships right, the journey will mean something."

The cast discussed their characters.

Cassandra learned more about Amara's childhood, her relationship with her brother, and the memories that had shaped her.

She asked questions about how Amara's confidence changed throughout the story.

David answered thoughtfully.

"At the beginning, she believes courage means doing everything herself. By the end, she understands that courage can also mean trusting other people."

Cassandra wrote that down.

It was a lesson she was beginning to understand in her own life.

She had once believed that becoming successful meant proving she could handle everything.

Now she was learning that growth sometimes meant allowing people to help without feeling that she had become less capable.

The meeting ended with a discussion about the filming schedule and preparation for the first scenes.

As everyone began gathering their things, Irene approached Cassandra.

"How are you feeling about the role?"

"Excited. A little nervous."

"Good. Keep both feelings. Excitement will give you energy, and nervousness will remind you to prepare."

Cassandra smiled.

"That's a very elegant way of saying I should do my homework."

Irene laughed.

"Years in the industry have taught me to make ordinary advice sound expensive."

Cassandra burst out laughing.

Irene smiled.

"You'll be fine. Keep asking questions. Don't be afraid of looking inexperienced. Everyone starts somewhere."

Cassandra nodded.

She was grateful that Irene had recommended her, but even more grateful that the older actress continued treating her like a person who could learn rather than a young talent who needed constant praise.

That was the kind of mentor Cassandra wanted to become for somebody else one day.

THE FIRST PUBLIC APPEARANCE

A week later, the producers of *Almost on Purpose* invited Cassandra to attend a small promotional event.

The film was approaching its final stages of production, and the team wanted to introduce the principal cast to members of the media and a few invited guests.

Cassandra would be interviewed briefly about her experience.

It was her first time speaking publicly about acting as a professional.

She prepared her answers carefully.

Then she called Vikksy.

"Can you help me practice?"

"Certainly. Please state your name, occupation, and why you have summoned the nation's leading expert in unnecessary confidence."

Cassandra laughed.

"I need interview practice."

"Understood. Let us begin."

He adopted a serious expression.

"Miss Cassandra, how does it feel to be the next great actress?"

Cassandra stared at him.

"That is not how they're going to ask the question."

"You're right. They may ask how it feels to be the next greatest actress."

"Vikksy!"

He laughed.

Then he became more helpful.

"Seriously, keep your answers honest and concise. Talk about what you learned, what you enjoyed, and what the project means to you. You don't have to sound like you've memorized a motivational speech."

Cassandra nodded.

"Okay."

"And if they ask about your future, you can talk about the kinds of stories you want to tell. You don't need to predict how famous you'll become."

"That makes sense."

He paused.

"Also, don't say that working with Tobi was wonderful if you actually spent half the production threatening him over cupcakes."

Cassandra burst out laughing.

"How do you know so much about my life?"

"Because you tell me everything."

She smiled.

"Fair enough."

They practiced several questions.

Vikksy challenged her to answer naturally rather than relying on polished phrases. When she became too rehearsed, he interrupted.

"Stop."

"What?"

"You sound like a brochure."

Cassandra laughed.

"What does that mean?"

"It means you sound as if someone is about to hand me a leaflet about the benefits of choosing you."

She shook her head.

"You're so annoying."

"Yet the rehearsal is working."

Unfortunately, he was right.

By the end of the call, Cassandra felt more comfortable speaking about her work.

She thanked him.

He accepted her gratitude with the modesty of a man receiving a national award.

"You're welcome. Please mention me in your acceptance speech."

"You're not getting mentioned."

"I'll accept that as a challenge."

THE INTERVIEW

The promotional event took place at a small venue in Lagos.

Cassandra wore an elegant outfit and arrived with the production team.

She greeted the cast, spoke with a few guests, and tried not to look at her phone every thirty seconds.

When the interviewer approached, she took a breath.

"Cassandra, welcome. This is your first feature film role. What has the experience been like?"

She smiled.

"It's been exciting and challenging. I've learned so much from the director and the other actors. I've also learned that a scene that looks simple on screen can take a lot of work behind the camera."

The interviewer laughed.

"Any surprises?"

Cassandra thought about the missing cupcakes.

"Let's just say I've discovered that filmmaking requires patience, teamwork, and occasionally an emergency supply of snacks."

The interviewer laughed.

The conversation continued.

They discussed Maya, the romantic comedy's themes, and Cassandra's experience transitioning from studying Film and Multimedia at PAU to working on a professional production.

"What kind of actress do you hope to become?"

Cassandra paused.

It was a question she had considered many times.

"I want to become an actress who can tell different kinds of stories honestly. I love comedy, but I also want to explore drama, adventure, and characters who challenge the audience to see the world differently. I want people to recognize something real in the characters I play."

The interviewer nodded.

"That's a thoughtful answer."

Cassandra smiled.

"Thank you."

After the interview, she stepped away from the cameras and exhaled.

She had done it.

She hadn't tried to sound like somebody else.

She hadn't pretended to know everything.

She had simply spoken about the work she loved and the person she hoped to become.

Tobi approached her.

"That went well."

Cassandra smiled.

"Thank you."

He nodded.

"You handled the questions nicely. You didn't even mention my tragic cupcake experience."

"Some stories are too painful to share publicly."

Tobi placed a hand over his chest.

"I appreciate your discretion."

They laughed.

Then Mrs. Bisi joined them.

"Good interview, Cassandra. You're becoming more comfortable speaking about your work. That matters."

Cassandra thanked her.

It was a small moment, but it felt important.

She was learning how to inhabit the professional side of acting, not just the creative side.

And she was beginning to understand that every opportunity, even a short interview, was another chance to show people who she was.

A MESSAGE FROM THE FUTURE

That evening, Cassandra returned home and found a message from Rebecca.

REBECCA: I watched your interview.

Cassandra smiled.

CASSANDRA: And?

REBECCA: You looked beautiful, confident, and professional.

Cassandra felt a warm rush of happiness.

Then another message arrived.

REBECCA: However, you failed to acknowledge the Business Administration department's contribution to your success.

Cassandra burst out laughing.

CASSANDRA: What contribution?

REBECCA: Emotional support. Strategic consultation. Snack provision. Calendar management. You are welcome.

CASSANDRA: I'll make sure to include you in the next interview.

REBECCA: Excellent. My media training begins tomorrow.

Vikksy joined the conversation.

VIKKSY: I would also like to remind the public that I provided technical support, audition preparation, interview coaching, and several excellent jokes.

REBECCA: Your jokes are under review.

VIKKSY: By whom?

REBECCA: The public.

VIKKSY: The public has poor judgment. It keeps buying phones with insufficient storage.

Cassandra laughed so hard she had to put the phone down.

Then she typed:

CASSANDRA: Both of you should be banned from managing anything.

Rebecca replied:

REBECCA: That sounds like something a person says before becoming famous enough to need management.

Vikksy followed immediately.

VIKKSY: We shall discuss the matter at the next board meeting.

Cassandra shook her head.

She was surrounded by people who genuinely wanted her to succeed, even if their preferred methods involved spreadsheets, technical lectures, and jokes that arrived before she had finished reading the previous message.

She wouldn't trade them for anything.

THE NEXT CHAPTER OF HER LIFE

Later that night, Cassandra sat at her desk.

Her scripts were arranged neatly.

Her calendar was updated.

Her university assignments were listed.

Her next filming dates were marked.

She had made a plan for the coming weeks, including time to call her children and visit home whenever her schedule allowed.

It wasn't a glamorous scene.

There were no cameras, no red carpets, and no interviewer asking her what it felt like to be a rising star.

There was simply a young woman working carefully toward a life she wanted.

She thought about the girl she had been before the first audition.

The girl who had dreamed about acting but wondered whether anyone would ever take her seriously.

That girl would have found the current version of her life almost unbelievable.

Two film roles.

An industry mentor.

A growing professional network.

A public interview.

And more opportunities on the horizon.

Cassandra smiled.

She still had a long way to go.

She knew that.

There would be difficult auditions, disappointing days, unexpected successes, and moments when she would need to rethink her plans.

But she no longer felt as though she were standing outside the door of the life she wanted.

She was inside it now.

Learning.

Working.

Growing.

And discovering that the dream was not a single extraordinary moment waiting somewhere in the future.

It was also the ordinary work she did every day to make that future possible.

Her phone buzzed.

A message from Vikksy.

VIKKSY: Reminder: charge your phone before sleeping.

Cassandra stared at it.

Then she typed:

CASSANDRA: I HAVE 78%.

His response arrived immediately.

VIKKSY: Excellent. For once, your battery management reflects responsible decision-making.

She laughed.

CASSANDRA: Goodnight, Vikksy.

VIKKSY: Goodnight, Cass. Keep going. You're doing well.

She put the phone down.

Tomorrow, there would be another script to study, another responsibility to manage, and another opportunity to prepare for.

But tonight, Cassandra allowed herself to feel proud.

Not because she had become the biggest actress in the world.

Not yet.

Because she was becoming someone who could pursue a big dream without losing sight of the people and values that made the dream worth pursuing.

And that was a beautiful beginning.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

THE PREMIERE, THE POPCORN, AND THE GIRL SOMEBODY RECOGNIZED

The first time Cassandra saw her face on a cinema screen, she forgot how to breathe.

Not permanently, fortunately. The cinema had enough problems without someone fainting during the opening credits.

She sat between Rebecca and Sarah, her hands folded tightly in her lap. John occupied the seat behind them, armed with a bucket of popcorn so enormous that Cassandra suspected he had purchased supplies for the entire cinema.

Vikksy had arrived late.

Naturally.

He slipped into the seat beside John just as the lights dimmed.

"Sorry, guys. Traffic."

Rebecca turned around. "Traffic? We came here together."

"Exactly. The traffic was emotional. I had to prepare myself."

"You were buying popcorn."

"Emotional support popcorn."

John extended the bucket. "Take some before Rebecca reports you to the authorities."

The cinema darkened completely.

On the screen appeared the opening credits of *Almost on Purpose*.

Cassandra's name appeared.

CASSANDRA.

For a moment, she couldn't hear the audience settling into their seats. She couldn't hear John chewing. She couldn't hear Rebecca whispering that she had always known Cassandra would make it.

She simply stared.

Her name was there.

Not in a notebook where she had written down her dreams. Not in a message encouraging her to keep trying. Not on an audition list she had nervously checked three times.

On a cinema screen.

People she had never met were about to watch her work.

Rebecca squeezed her hand.

"You did that," she whispered.

Cassandra swallowed. "I'm about to watch myself do that."

"Same thing."

"Not emotionally."

"Girl, breathe."

"I'm breathing."

"You're holding your breath."

Cassandra released it.

Behind them, Vikksy leaned forward.

"If you faint, please fall toward Rebecca. She's studying Business Administration. She'll know how to manage the situation."

Rebecca turned sharply. "I'll manage you into the next state."

"See? Leadership skills."

The film began.

Cassandra watched the opening scene with the strange sensation of meeting an old version of herself. There she was, standing in a fictional café, delivering lines she had once practiced in her room while her children occasionally interrupted to ask questions that were considerably more urgent than cinema dialogue.

She noticed things she hadn't noticed while filming. A slight movement of her hand. A pause before a line. The way her character's expression changed when she tried to hide embarrassment.

Then came a scene that made her stomach tighten.

It was a quiet moment between her character and Tobi's character, when a misunderstanding had finally begun to unravel. Cassandra remembered filming it. She remembered being nervous, wondering whether she was doing too much or not enough.

On the screen, the scene worked.

The audience laughed at the right moment.

Then it grew quiet.

Cassandra felt tears prick her eyes, though she quickly blinked them away.

Rebecca noticed.

"Don't start crying," she whispered. "Your face is on the screen. You need to look emotionally available to your own career."

Cassandra laughed silently.

When the film ended, the audience applauded.

Not everyone stood. Not everyone cheered. It wasn't the kind of premiere where a person became a global celebrity before the final credits disappeared.

But people clapped.

People smiled.

A woman two rows ahead turned to her friend and said, "That girl who played the friend was really good."

Cassandra froze.

The friend nodded. "Yes. She felt natural. I liked her."

Rebecca's eyes widened.

John leaned forward. "Did you hear that?"

"Everybody heard that," Sarah whispered.

Vikksy folded his arms with the satisfaction of a man who had personally negotiated the existence of cinema.

"Please, no autographs until I establish a proper system."

Cassandra elbowed him.

"Ow. That's how famous people treat their management?"

"That's how I treat people who embarrass me."

"Then I'm glad I'm not your manager," Rebecca said. "Your business would collapse before lunch."

"Your business would have a spreadsheet for the collapse."

"And yours would have a motivational speech."

"Both are necessary."

They were still arguing when a young woman approached their group.

She looked to be in her early twenties and held her phone against her chest.

"Excuse me," she said. "Are you Cassandra?"

Cassandra stared at her.

For one dangerous second, every line she had ever learned abandoned her brain.

"Yes," she managed.

The young woman smiled. "I just watched the film. I really liked your performance. You looked so natural. Especially that scene where you were trying to act like nothing was wrong, but obviously everything was wrong."

Cassandra laughed. "That describes most of my life, actually."

The young woman laughed too.

"My name is Ifeoma. I'm studying at LASU. I'm trying to get into acting, but I'm always scared I'm not good enough."

Something in Cassandra's expression softened.

She remembered that fear.

She remembered waiting outside an audition room, wondering whether the people inside would see anything worth remembering.

"You don't have to be fearless before you start," Cassandra said. "I was nervous today, and I was nervous at my auditions. You learn by doing the work. Take classes when you can, practice, audition, and keep learning. Don't wait until you feel perfect. You might wait until retirement."

Ifeoma laughed.

"Can I take a picture with you?"

"Of course."

They took the picture.

When Ifeoma left, Cassandra remained still for a moment.

Rebecca nudged her shoulder.

"Your first fan."

"She was just being nice."

"She asked for a picture."

"People take pictures with their friends."

"Did you see her call you her friend?"

Cassandra smiled. "Rebecca, please."

"I'm only stating facts. Business Administration has taught me the importance of documenting evidence."

Vikksy nodded solemnly. "The court recognizes the evidence."

John raised his popcorn bucket. "I would like to submit Exhibit A: Cassandra is famous."

"Objection," Cassandra said.

"On what grounds?" Sarah asked.

"Because I haven't even finished my degree."

"Overruled," Vikksy replied. "The court has eaten all the popcorn and is no longer impartial."

They left the cinema laughing.

Outside, the night air was warm, and Lagos traffic continued its usual argument with the concept of movement.

Cassandra checked her phone.

There were messages from classmates, family members, and people who had seen her promotional posts. Her mother had sent a voice note. Grandma had sent a photograph of Nelson and Kayla sitting together on the sofa.

Nelson held a handmade sign that read:

MUMMY IS ON TV!

Kayla's sign read:

MUMMY IS A PRINCESS.

Someone had helped them spell the words correctly. Cassandra suspected Grandma.

She called home immediately.

Nelson answered with the urgency of a child reporting a national emergency.

"Mummy!"

"Hello, my superstar."

"No, Mummy. You're the superstar!"

"Is that so?"

"Yes! Grandma said your film finished, and we watched your picture on her phone."

Kayla pushed into the conversation.

"Mummy, did everybody clap?"

"Some people did."

"Did they clap loudly?"

"Quite loudly."

Kayla considered this.

"Next time, tell them to clap louder."

Cassandra laughed, covering her mouth.

"I'll send them a formal request."

"Tell them I'm your daughter," Kayla added. "They will listen."

"Naturally. You're the boss."

Nelson took over again.

"Did you win?"

Cassandra leaned against the car while her friends waited nearby.

"There wasn't a competition, sweetheart. We made a film, and people watched it."

"But they liked you?"

"I think some of them did."

"Then you won."

The simplicity of his answer caught her off guard.

Children had a way of dismantling complicated adult explanations with one sentence. It was frankly inefficient of them to be so good at it.

"Maybe you're right," she whispered.

After the call, Cassandra looked up at the night sky.

She wasn't the biggest actress in Nigeria. She wasn't internationally famous. She hadn't bought a mansion or appeared on a magazine cover.

But a stranger had watched her work and felt something.

A young woman had approached her because Cassandra's performance made her believe that perhaps she could try too.

Her children had watched her on a screen.

And for the first time, her dream seemed to exist outside her own imagination.

That night, she sat on her bed at the hostel and opened her messages.

Rebecca had sent a photograph of the group outside the cinema.

The caption read:

THE NIGHT WE WITNESSED THE BEGINNING.

Sarah had sent a video of Cassandra's name appearing in the credits.

John had sent a picture of the popcorn bucket.

The caption read:

I ALSO CONTRIBUTED TO THE PRODUCTION.

Then came a message from Vikksy.

VIKKSY: First film premiere completed. First fan encounter completed. First public evidence that people appreciate your work completed.

CASSANDRA: Thank you, manager.

VIKKSY: You're welcome. My management fee is one plate of food and the right to say "I told you so" at least twice per year.

CASSANDRA: You already say it every week.

VIKKSY: Inflation.

Cassandra laughed.

Then another message arrived.

VIKKSY: Seriously, Cass. You did well tonight. Don't measure everything by how famous you become. Remember the feeling of doing the work properly and connecting with someone. Keep that. The rest can grow from there.

Cassandra read it twice.

CASSANDRA: I will. Thank you for always encouraging me.

VIKKSY: Always. Now charge your phone.

CASSANDRA: It's on 81%.

VIKKSY: That's what people say immediately before their phones die during an important call.

She put the phone on charge.

For once, she did it without arguing.

Mostly because she had no convincing counterargument.

The next morning, Cassandra returned to campus with the same backpack, the same unfinished assignments, and the same lecturer who had once asked her why she was late.

The university had not transformed into a palace overnight.

Her classes still required attendance. Her notes still needed organizing. Her children still needed their mother.

But something had changed.

As she walked toward the lecture hall, a student from another department smiled at her.

"Hi, Cassandra. I watched *Almost on Purpose*. You were really good."

Cassandra thanked her, cheeks warming.

Then another student greeted her.

Then someone asked where the film could be watched.

By lunchtime, Rebecca had received a message from a girl in her own department asking whether she knew the actress Cassandra.

Rebecca stared at the screen.

Then she called Cassandra.

"Your fame has entered Business Administration."

Cassandra laughed. "What does that even mean?"

"It means my classmates are asking about you. I may have to establish a public-relations department."

"Please don't."

"Too late. I've already appointed myself director."

"You appointed yourself?"

"Nobody else applied."

Cassandra shook her head, smiling.

The attention was small, scattered, and sometimes awkward. A few people recognized her. Others simply said they enjoyed the film. Some forgot her name and described her as "the girl who played that friend."

She treasured all of it.

Not because it proved she had arrived, but because it reminded her that she was moving.

And somewhere beyond the familiar classrooms of Pan-Atlantic University, another story was waiting for her.

A story with a larger cast, a longer shoot, and a character who would demand more of her than she had ever given before.

A story called *The Map of Tomorrow*.

Cassandra had no idea how far it would take her.

But she was ready to find out.

CHAPTER TWELVE

THE EMAIL FROM ABROAD AND THE WOMAN WHO REFUSED TO PANIC

Cassandra was halfway through eating rice when her future decided to interrupt lunch.

Her phone vibrated beside her plate.

She ignored it.

It vibrated again.

She ignored it with greater determination.

Then it vibrated a third time.

Rebecca glanced at the phone.

"Your phone is behaving like someone who owes you money."

"I'm eating."

"It might be important."

"If it's important, it can wait until I finish chewing."

The phone vibrated again.

Rebecca leaned over and read the notification.

"Cassandra."

"What?"

"There's an email from Amara Okafor Productions."

Cassandra stopped chewing.

Rebecca slowly lowered her spoon.

"Now, I know you said you wanted to finish eating, but unless that rice has a career plan, I suggest you check the email."

Cassandra grabbed her phone.

The message was from the production office.

Subject: International Distribution Meeting and Talent Introduction

She opened it.

The email explained that *Almost on Purpose* had attracted interest from a regional streaming distributor exploring African romantic comedies for a broader audience. Separately, the team behind *The Map of Tomorrow* was preparing for an international development meeting with representatives from a London-based production company interested in stories emerging from African filmmakers.

The production office wanted Cassandra to participate in a short recorded introduction and an online meeting with members of the development team.

They were not offering her an international contract.

They were not announcing a global campaign.

They were not promising her a role in a Hollywood blockbuster.

They were asking her to introduce herself, discuss her work, and speak about the character she would play in *The Map of Tomorrow*.

Still, Cassandra read the email three times.

Rebecca watched her.

"What's the verdict?"

Cassandra handed her the phone.

Rebecca read it once.

Then again.

Then she placed the phone on the table with exaggerated care.

"Okay."

Cassandra stared at her. "Okay?"

"Yes."

"Rebecca, they want me to meet people in London."

"Online."

"People in London!"

"I heard you the first time."

"Rebecca!"

Rebecca grabbed both of Cassandra's hands.

"Girl, I am trying to remain professional, but internally, I am doing gymnastics."

Cassandra burst out laughing.

Rebecca stood up.

"I need to walk."

"Why?"

"My friend has an international meeting, and I need to process the implications for our future group outings."

"Our group outings?"

"Yes. When you become internationally known, somebody will suggest a restaurant in London, and I need to know whether your schedule permits it."

Cassandra threw a napkin at her.

Rebecca caught it.

"See? Already throwing things. The pressure of fame."

Cassandra laughed so hard she nearly spilled her drink.

Then, as the laughter settled, the nerves returned.

"What if I say something foolish?"

Rebecca sat down again.

"Then you'll be a human being who said something foolish. Congratulations. You're qualified."

"I'm serious."

"So am I. You don't need to become a different person because the meeting is international. Prepare. Learn about the people attending. Know what you want to say. Ask questions when you need clarification. And don't pretend to know something you don't know."

Cassandra looked at her friend.

"Since when did you become a career counsellor?"

"Since you became a potential international case study."

"Rebecca!"

"I'm kidding. Mostly."

That evening, Cassandra called Vikksy.

He answered on the second ring.

"Before you say anything, I have a question."

"Hello to you too."

"How much battery does your phone have?"

Cassandra looked at the screen.

"Seventy-six percent."

"Excellent. Continue."

She explained the email.

For several seconds, Vikksy said nothing.

Cassandra frowned.

"Are you there?"

"I'm here."

"Why are you quiet?"

"I'm trying to decide whether to congratulate you or start charging you consultation fees."

She laughed.

"Be serious."

"I am serious. This is a good opportunity. Not a guarantee of anything, but a real opportunity. We prepare properly and take it one step at a time."

There it was again: his ability to turn excitement into something practical without crushing it.

Cassandra sat cross-legged on her bed.

"I don't even know what they're going to ask."

"Then we prepare for the questions they are likely to ask, and we prepare you to handle the ones they don't."

"How?"

"First, research the company and the people attending. Second, prepare a short introduction about yourself. Third, be ready to talk about *Almost on Purpose* and *The Map of Tomorrow*. Fourth, practise explaining why you want to act and what you're learning as an actor. Fifth, prepare questions for them."

Cassandra grabbed her notebook.

"Wait. Let me write that down."

"Good. My wisdom is finally being documented."

"Don't spoil it."

"Sorry. Continue documenting."

They spent the next hour preparing.

Vikksy asked her to describe her experience filming *Almost on Purpose*.

Cassandra gave a long answer.

He listened patiently.

Then he said, "That's a very beautiful answer."

She smiled. "Thank you."

"It's also long enough to qualify as a documentary."

Her smile disappeared.

"Vikksy!"

"I'm helping. Start again. Tell them the most important thing you learned, then give one example."

She tried again.

This time, she spoke about learning to listen to her scene partners instead of simply waiting for her next line. She explained how small reactions could make a performance feel more genuine.

"Better," Vikksy said. "Now tell them what interests you about *The Map of Tomorrow*."

Cassandra thought for a moment.

"I like that Amara is brave, but not because she has no fear. She is afraid of disappointing her family, and she doesn't always know what to do with that fear. I want to show how she learns to understand herself without pretending she has everything figured out."

There was a pause.

Then Vikksy said, "Keep that answer."

"Really?"

"Really. It sounds like you understand the character. Because you do."

Cassandra wrote it down.

Next, he asked her to introduce herself in thirty seconds.

She tried.

It took two minutes.

He tried not to laugh.

She noticed.

"Go ahead. Laugh."

"I wouldn't dare."

"You're already laughing."

"I'm smiling professionally."

"You're a nuisance."

"And yet, here I am, improving your international prospects."

She shook her head.

They practised until Cassandra could introduce herself clearly without sounding as though she had memorized a speech written by a government committee.

Before ending the call, Vikksy reminded her of something important.

"Don't go into the meeting trying to prove you're already a superstar. Go in ready to show them you're serious about becoming a better actress. You don't have to pretend you've done everything. Talk about what you've done, what you've learned, and what you're working toward."

Cassandra nodded.

"That makes sense."

"Good. Also, wear something comfortable and professional. Check your internet connection. Test your camera. Find a quiet place. And keep your phone charged."

"Your concern for my battery is becoming suspicious."

"Your battery has disappointed me before."

"It has never personally disappointed you."

"It knows what it did."

She laughed.

The following morning, Cassandra met Sarah and John after class.

They had already heard about the email.

John arrived carrying a notebook.

Cassandra eyed it.

"What's that?"

"My list of questions for when you become internationally famous."

"You haven't even asked whether I have time to answer them."

"I believe in preparation."

Sarah took the notebook from him.

The first question read:

Will you still greet ordinary people?

Cassandra stared at him.

"John."

"What? Fame changes people."

"You are not an ordinary person. You're a man who once forgot his own presentation title while standing beside the projector."

Sarah laughed so hard she had to hold the wall.

John took back his notebook.

"That was a technical issue."

"You were reading the title from the screen," Sarah said.

"The screen was technically unreliable."

Cassandra laughed with them, and the nervousness eased.

Then Sarah became thoughtful.

"Cass, seriously. This is exciting. But don't let the pressure make you feel like you have to become perfect overnight."

"I know."

"You've got school, the children, and two productions to think about. You can be ambitious without trying to do everything at once."

Cassandra appreciated that.

Sometimes encouragement meant telling someone they could reach for the stars.

Sometimes it meant reminding them that they still needed to eat lunch.

In the days that followed, Cassandra prepared for the meeting while continuing work on *The Map of Tomorrow*. She studied her scenes, attended her classes, and called home whenever her schedule allowed.

Nelson wanted to know whether the people in London had seen her film.

"Not necessarily, sweetheart," she explained. "The meeting is about discussing the film and my acting."

"Then why are they meeting you?"

"Because they want to learn about the project."

Nelson thought about that.

"Can they learn about me too?"

Cassandra smiled. "What would you like them to learn?"

"That I'm very good at football."

"That's important information."

"And that Kayla takes my toys."

From the background, Kayla shouted, "They're my toys!"

Nelson shouted back, "They're my toys when I'm using them!"

Cassandra closed her eyes.

International entertainment executives had no idea what kind of negotiations were happening in her household.

"Children," she said, trying to sound authoritative.

Both went quiet.

Then Kayla asked, "Mummy, will you be on the television again?"

"I hope so, darling."

"Then I will wave at you."

Cassandra's heart softened.

"I'll look for you."

Later that night, she spoke with Grandma and thanked her for looking after the children.

Grandma told her not to worry too much.

"Do your work well," she said. "We'll manage here. Just remember that even when people begin calling your name, you are still Cassandra."

Cassandra held the phone close.

"I won't forget."

On the morning of the meeting, she dressed carefully, choosing an outfit that made her feel confident without making her feel like she was attending a royal coronation.

Rebecca inspected her.

"Very good."

"Thank you."

"You look like someone who knows what she is doing."

"I hope I can maintain the illusion."

"Confidence is partly preparation and partly good lighting."

Vikksy joined them on a video call to check her camera setup.

He examined the frame.

"Move slightly to the left."

Cassandra moved.

"Your other left."

She stared at him.

"Are you testing me?"

"I'm testing the camera."

"Then tell the camera to move."

"The camera lacks ambition."

Rebecca appeared behind Cassandra.

"Can you two finish? Some of us have classes."

Vikksy nodded. "Thank you, Rebecca. Your contribution to international cinema has been noted."

"Put it in the minutes."

Cassandra laughed, then took a deep breath.

The meeting began.

There were introductions, polite greetings, and a few technical adjustments. One participant's microphone refused to work. Another appeared to be joining from a room with a rather enthusiastic air conditioner.

For the first minute, Cassandra's nerves tried to convince her that everyone could hear her heartbeat.

Then she remembered her preparation.

She introduced herself, spoke about her experience on *Almost on Purpose*, and explained what drew her to the role of Amara in *The Map of Tomorrow*.

She listened carefully to the questions.

When she didn't understand one, she asked for clarification instead of pretending.

When asked about her long-term ambitions, she spoke honestly.

"I want to build a lasting career as an actress. I want to play different kinds of characters, work with people who challenge me, and keep improving. I'm still learning, but I'm serious about the work."

One of the representatives asked how she balanced acting with university and motherhood.

Cassandra paused.

She could have given a polished answer about discipline and time management.

Instead, she told the truth.

"It's not always easy. I have to plan carefully, accept help when I need it, and remember that I can't do everything at the same time. My family and friends support me, and I'm learning to work more intelligently rather than simply working longer."

The representative nodded.

"That's a thoughtful answer."

By the end of the meeting, Cassandra felt calmer than she had at the beginning.

No one offered her a million-dollar contract.

No one announced that she would be starring in an international blockbuster.

But they discussed the possibility of including her in a future talent showcase connected to the project. They also asked the production team to keep them updated on her work.

It was a beginning.

A real one.

After the meeting, Cassandra sat quietly for a few seconds.

Then she called Rebecca.

"How did it go?" Rebecca asked.

"I think it went well."

"Define well."

"I answered their questions. I didn't forget my name. My internet behaved itself. Nobody asked me to solve mathematics."

Rebecca exhaled dramatically.

"Then we celebrate."

Cassandra laughed.

Vikksy called shortly afterward.

"Report."

"Meeting completed."

"Did you answer the questions?"

"Yes."

"Did you panic?"

"A little."

"Did you survive?"

"Obviously."

"Excellent. We have achieved three major milestones."

She smiled.

"Thank you for helping me prepare."

"You did the meeting, Cass. I just asked questions and insulted your answers until they improved."

"That is a very strange professional service."

"I offer premium packages."

She shook her head, laughing.

Then he grew sincere.

"I'm proud of how you handled it. You didn't pretend to be someone else. Keep doing that."

Cassandra looked at the email still open on her laptop screen.

It wasn't a contract.

It wasn't a guarantee.

It wasn't the finish line.

But it was a door she hadn't even known how to approach a few months earlier.

And she had walked through it herself.

That evening, she wrote in her notebook:

Today, I spoke to people who work beyond the world I know. I was nervous, but I spoke honestly. I still have a lot to learn, and I have a long way to go. But my world is getting bigger.

She paused, then added:

I don't need to become somebody else to reach it.

Outside, Lagos carried on with its usual soundtrack of traffic, conversation, generators, and somebody somewhere insisting that a loud horn could solve a problem.

Cassandra closed her notebook.

Tomorrow, she would return to campus. She would study. She would rehearse. She would call her children. She would laugh with Rebecca, Sarah, and John. She would probably receive another message from Vikksy telling her to charge her phone.

Her life was still her life.

But the horizon had shifted.

And somewhere beyond it, new roles, new audiences, and new possibilities were beginning to take shape.

Cassandra had not become the world's biggest superstar.

Not yet.

But the girl who once wondered whether anyone would take her acting seriously had begun to discover something more powerful than a promise of fame.

People were starting to take notice of her work.

And she was learning how to meet the moment.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

LIGHTS, CAMERA, CASSANDRA!

The first day of filming *The Map of Tomorrow* began with Cassandra standing outside a production trailer, holding her script and wondering whether she had accidentally walked into somebody else's dream.

Everything seemed bigger than it had during *Almost on Purpose*.

There were more cameras, more crew members, more equipment, and enough cables on the ground to make walking a competitive sport. People moved in every direction, carrying costumes, adjusting lights, discussing schedules, and calling out names.

Somewhere nearby, a man shouted, "We need the prop letter!"

Another voice replied, "Which letter?"

"The letter!"

"That is not a helpful description!"

Cassandra looked down at her script.

Good morning, Amara, she told herself.

A production assistant hurried past her.

"Miss Cassandra? They're ready for you in makeup."

"Thank you."

She took three steps, stopped, and checked her script again.

A familiar voice came from behind her.

"You're going to wear a hole through that paper if you keep looking at it."

Cassandra turned.

Irene Danjuma stood there in a simple cream outfit, holding a cup of tea. Even dressed casually, she possessed the kind of elegance that made everyone else feel as though they had forgotten an important appointment.

Cassandra smiled nervously. "I'm just reviewing my lines."

"Good. But tell me something. Do you know your character?"

"I think so."

"Then stop asking the paper for permission to act."

Cassandra laughed.

Irene smiled. "You'll be fine. Remember, this is a story, not a court examination. Nobody is waiting to punish you for making a choice."

"That is comforting."

"It should be. I have seen experienced actors forget their lines, walk into furniture, and accidentally deliver another character's dialogue. One man once thanked the director for a scene he hadn't even filmed."

Cassandra blinked.

"What did the director say?"

"That he was welcome, but his character was still missing."

Cassandra burst out laughing.

Her shoulders relaxed.

That was one thing she was beginning to appreciate about experienced actors. The best ones didn't make the work seem magical by pretending it was effortless. They made it approachable by admitting that even professionals had embarrassing days.

A few minutes later, Cassandra entered makeup.

The makeup artist introduced herself as Boma and began examining Cassandra's face under the lights.

"Have you slept?"

Cassandra hesitated.

"Define slept."

Boma lowered her brush.

"That is the answer of someone who has not slept."

"I was studying my scenes."

"Your character is travelling across Nigeria to discover her family's history. She is not travelling across your face to discover where you hid your sleep."

Cassandra laughed so suddenly that Boma had to stop applying makeup.

"Please don't move," Boma said. "I am trying to make you look like a leading actress, not a woman who has just heard an excellent joke at a funeral."

"Sorry!"

"Save the laughter for after I finish."

By the time Cassandra reached the set, she was dressed as Amara, the young woman whose journey would become the emotional centre of *The Map of Tomorrow*.

The first scene took place in a family living room. Amara was arguing with her older brother, Daniel, about their late grandfather's journal.

Their uncle wanted to sell the family house. Daniel believed the journal contained nothing worth keeping. Amara suspected that their grandfather had left something important behind.

The scene was about more than a notebook.

It was about family, memory, fear, and the different ways people responded to losing someone they loved.

Cassandra had prepared carefully.

She had studied Amara's motivations, worked through the emotional beats, and rehearsed with Vikksy until he threatened to begin charging her for every repeated line.

Now she stood opposite Femi, who played Daniel.

Director David Afolayan sat behind the monitor.

"Let's keep this simple," he said. "You both love each other. You're frustrated because you think the other person is making a terrible mistake. Don't play the argument. Play what you want from each other."

He raised his hand.

"Sound?"

"Rolling!"

"Camera?"

"Rolling!"

"Scene twelve, take one."

The clapperboard snapped.

"Action!"

Femi looked at Cassandra.

"The house is falling apart, Amara. We can't keep preserving every old thing just because Grandpa touched it."

Cassandra held the journal against her chest.

"He didn't preserve things because they were old. He preserved them because they meant something."

"Meaning doesn't pay for repairs."

"And selling everything doesn't make you practical. It just makes you someone who's decided the past is inconvenient."

Femi's expression tightened.

"You're talking as if I'm the one who wants to forget him."

"I'm talking as if you're the one who wants to sell his house before we've even finished reading his journal!"

The argument sharpened.

For a moment, Cassandra forgot about the cameras, the crew, and the people watching her.

She was Amara.

She could see the family home. She could feel the weight of the journal. She could understand the fear beneath Amara's anger: if the family let go of the house, would they slowly let go of the person who had made it home?

"Cut!" David called.

Cassandra blinked and returned to the set.

The director looked at his monitor.

Then he nodded.

"Good. Very good. Let's do another take. This time, Cassandra, don't let the anger arrive before the hurt. She's fighting because she's scared, not because she enjoys arguing."

Cassandra nodded.

"Understood."

They filmed the scene again.

This time, she allowed a small hesitation before her sharpest line. Her voice softened when she mentioned their grandfather, then strengthened when Daniel dismissed the journal.

When David called cut, he smiled.

"That's it. Keep that instinct."

Cassandra tried not to look too pleased.

She failed.

During the lunch break, she found a quiet corner and called Rebecca.

"How's the superstar?" Rebecca answered.

"I'm still a student. Please respect my academic status."

"Your academic status is noted. How's the film?"

Cassandra described the set, the scene, and the director's feedback.

Rebecca listened carefully.

Then she asked, "Have you eaten?"

"Not yet."

Rebecca went silent.

"Cassandra."

"I was going to."

"That sentence has destroyed more plans than poor management and bad Wi-Fi combined."

"I have lunch."

"Then eat it. You cannot act out a family crisis while your stomach is staging its own protest."

Cassandra laughed.

"I'll eat."

"Good. Also, I have informed our friends that filming has begun. Sarah says she's praying for you. John says he wants a premiere invitation. Abiodun says he can provide emotional support."

"What kind?"

"He didn't specify."

"That sounds dangerous."

"He also says he can act."

Cassandra nearly choked.

"Abiodun?"

"Those were my exact words."

"Please tell him the film has enough actors."

Rebecca laughed.

After the call, Cassandra opened her lunch container and finally ate.

A message from Vikksy appeared.

VIKKSY: First day report?

CASSANDRA: Good so far. Director liked my scene.

VIKKSY: Excellent. Did you remember the advice?

CASSANDRA: Which one? You give advice like a radio station.

VIKKSY: Play what the character wants, not just what the character says.

Cassandra smiled.

CASSANDRA: Yes. It helped.

VIKKSY: Good. I shall now add "acting coach" to my résumé.

CASSANDRA: You have never been on a film set.

VIKKSY: I have watched films.

CASSANDRA: That doesn't qualify you.

VIKKSY: I have also watched you rehearse.

CASSANDRA: Still doesn't qualify you.

VIKKSY: My application has been rejected by an industry that fears innovation.

Cassandra laughed.

Then another message arrived.

VIKKSY: Seriously, I'm glad the first day is going well. Keep listening, keep learning, and don't be afraid to ask questions. You're there to do the work, not to impress people by pretending you know everything.

She replied with a heart emoji and returned to set.

The afternoon brought a different challenge.

The crew filmed a scene in which Amara discovered an old envelope hidden inside the journal. The envelope contained a letter from her grandfather, but Cassandra's character wasn't supposed to read it immediately. First, she had to notice something unusual about the handwriting.

It was a quiet moment.

No argument. No dramatic speech. No tears.

Just a woman, an old journal, and the uneasy feeling that someone had left her a message she wasn't yet ready to understand.

Cassandra performed the scene.

David watched the monitor.

"Again, please."

They repeated it.

"Again."

On the third take, Cassandra became aware of every movement she made. Was she looking at the letter for too long? Was her expression too subtle? Should she raise the journal? Should she turn toward the window?

The more she thought about the performance, the less natural it felt.

David noticed.

"Let's pause."

The crew stepped back while the director approached her.

"What are you trying to show us?" he asked.

"That Amara realizes the letter is important."

"Yes. But what does she feel?"

Cassandra thought.

"Curiosity. Maybe fear."

"Good. Does she know why she's afraid?"

"No."

"Then don't show us that she knows. Let her discover it."

He returned to the monitor.

"Take a moment. Then we'll go again."

Cassandra closed her eyes briefly.

She thought of Nelson bringing her a drawing and insisting that she look at every detail. She thought of Kayla hiding a toy behind her back, convinced that the secret was impossible to detect because she had closed her eyes while hiding it.

She thought of the way ordinary objects could suddenly become precious when connected to someone you loved.

Then she opened her eyes.

"Ready," she said.

The camera rolled.

Cassandra picked up the journal.

She turned the page.

Her fingers stopped at the envelope.

She studied the handwriting, slowly tracing the first letter of her grandfather's name. Her expression changed, almost imperceptibly. She looked toward the doorway, as though expecting someone to explain what she had found.

No one did.

She lowered her eyes to the envelope again.

For a moment, she looked like someone standing at the entrance to a place she had spent her whole life trying not to enter.

"Cut," David said softly.

He looked at the monitor for a few seconds.

Then he turned to Cassandra.

"Beautiful. That's the moment."

Cassandra felt a warmth spread through her chest.

Not because she had performed a grand emotional scene, but because she had finally understood what the director wanted.

Sometimes acting wasn't about displaying an emotion.

Sometimes it was about allowing the audience to discover one.

As the crew prepared for the next setup, Irene approached her.

"You found it," she said.

Cassandra smiled. "I think I did."

"Remember that feeling. You won't always get it immediately. Some days you'll work hard and still feel uncertain. That doesn't mean you're failing. It means you're working."

Cassandra nodded.

"Thank you."

Irene squeezed her shoulder before returning to her trailer.

At the end of the day, Cassandra sat in the back of the production vehicle, exhausted in a way that felt entirely different from studying for an examination.

Her phone rang.

Grandma had arranged for Nelson and Kayla to speak with her before bedtime.

"Mummy!" Nelson shouted. "Did you act today?"

"I did."

"Did you act well?"

Cassandra smiled. "I tried my best."

Kayla appeared beside him.

"Did you wear a crown?"

"No crown today, sweetheart."

"Why?"

"Because Amara doesn't wear a crown."

Kayla looked genuinely disappointed.

"Then they should give her one."

Cassandra laughed.

"I'll submit the suggestion."

Nelson leaned closer to the phone.

"Mummy, when you become famous, will you still come home?"

The question was so simple that it took Cassandra a moment to answer.

"Always, sweetheart. I'll always make time for you and Kayla. My work is important, but so are you."

Nelson nodded, apparently satisfied.

Kayla waved both hands at the screen.

"Goodnight, Princess Mummy!"

"Goodnight, my princess."

After the call, Cassandra leaned back and closed her eyes.

The first day had taught her that a bigger production did not require her to become a bigger person.

It required her to listen better, prepare more carefully, and trust the work she had done.

She still had plenty to learn.

But she was exactly where she needed to be.

And tomorrow, the cameras would roll again.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

ONE SCENE, A THOUSAND CONVERSATIONS

Three weeks into filming *The Map of Tomorrow*, Cassandra discovered that there were two types of exhaustion.

The first came from doing the work.

The second came from trying to convince herself that she wasn't tired.

She was currently experiencing both.

Her days had developed a predictable rhythm. She attended classes when the production schedule allowed, studied her scripts during breaks, filmed scenes, and called home in the evenings. Rebecca checked in regularly, Vikksy continued offering advice disguised as complaints, and her children remained committed to asking the most difficult questions at the least convenient times.

One Tuesday morning, Cassandra arrived on set to discover that the production team had rearranged the schedule.

The scene originally planned for Friday would be filmed that day instead.

It was the emotional centre of the film's second act.

Amara would finally read her grandfather's letter.

In it, she would discover that he had once abandoned his own ambitions because he feared disappointing his family. He had spent years regretting the choice, not because he disliked his life, but because he had never been honest about the dreams he had sacrificed.

Amara would realize that her grandfather's journey was connected to her own.

The scene required Cassandra to move through several emotions without making the performance feel like a collection of dramatic expressions.

She had to begin with curiosity, discover the letter's meaning, struggle to accept it, and finally confront the fear that she might repeat the same mistake.

David explained the scene during rehearsal.

"Amara thinks this letter will give her answers about her grandfather. Instead, it forces her to ask questions about herself. Don't rush to the ending. Let the discovery change her."

Cassandra nodded.

Femi, standing beside her, glanced at the script.

"Are you ready?"

"Define ready."

He laughed.

"That's not encouraging."

"It's a very useful phrase. It gives me time to think."

"Then I hope your character doesn't need an immediate answer."

"She doesn't. That's why we're filming a movie."

Femi grinned.

"You've been spending too much time with the crew."

"I've been spending too much time with you."

"That's hurtful."

"You'll recover."

The crew prepared the room.

The scene was set in the old family house, late in the afternoon. Warm light came through the windows. Dust floated in the air. The journal lay open on a wooden table, beside a photograph of Amara's grandfather as a young man.

Cassandra took her position.

David sat behind the monitor.

"Let's have a quiet set, please."

The room settled.

"Sound?"

"Rolling."

"Camera?"

"Rolling."

"Scene forty-seven, take one."

The clapperboard snapped.

"Action."

Cassandra picked up the letter.

At first, Amara smiled faintly at the familiar handwriting.

Then she began reading.

Her expression changed.

She stopped.

Read the line again.

Her eyes moved across the page, but her breathing became slower, as though she were trying to make sense of something that had always been there without her knowing it.

She lowered the letter.

"No," she whispered.

The camera held on her face.

She looked at the photograph of her grandfather.

"You never told anyone."

Her voice trembled slightly.

"You let everybody believe you were happy with the choice."

She pressed her lips together.

A tear gathered in her eye, but she did not immediately wipe it away.

"You told me to be brave."

She looked back at the letter.

"How could you tell me that when you were afraid too?"

Her voice broke on the final word.

She sat down slowly.

For a few seconds, she simply held the paper.

Then she laughed once, quietly and without happiness, as though she had suddenly recognized something painfully familiar.

"All this time," she whispered. "I thought I was the only one."

The scene ended in silence.

"Cut."

Nobody spoke immediately.

Cassandra remained seated, still holding the letter.

Then David rose from behind the monitor.

"That was excellent."

The tension in the room released.

Someone adjusted a light. A crew member moved a chair. Femi exhaled loudly.

"I was beginning to think none of us was allowed to breathe."

A few people laughed.

David approached Cassandra.

"Let's do one more take. Not because the first was bad. I want to see what happens if you give the final line a little more space."

Cassandra nodded.

They filmed another take.

This time, she allowed the silence to last longer after the words *I thought I was the only one.*

The scene felt even more intimate.

When David called cut, he smiled.

"That's the one."

Cassandra stood, her legs slightly unsteady.

Femi handed her a bottle of water.

"Congratulations. You have officially made a room full of adults emotionally uncomfortable."

She laughed.

"That's the job."

"Then you're very good at your job."

For the rest of the afternoon, the production continued filming other scenes.

Cassandra thought little about the letter scene. She had performed emotional work before, and she knew that a successful take did not automatically translate into a successful film.

Still, she felt proud.

That evening, the cast gathered briefly to review selected footage with the director and cinematographer.

Cassandra sat near the back.

When her scene appeared on the monitor, she watched it with the uncomfortable curiosity of someone overhearing a conversation about herself.

The lighting was beautiful.

The room felt lived in.

The camera stayed close enough to catch the smallest changes in her expression without making the moment feel intrusive.

And her performance was better than she had expected.

She saw Amara, not Cassandra.

That was what made her smile.

David paused the footage.

"This is why we give scenes time to breathe," he told the group. "The audience needs room to think and feel. We don't have to explain every emotion."

Irene nodded.

"Sometimes the most important line is the one that comes after the character stops speaking."

Cassandra wrote that down.

She was beginning to collect lessons the way other students collected lecture notes.

Only these lessons seemed to rearrange the way she understood people.

After the screening, she sent Vikksy a voice message.

"Today we filmed the letter scene. I think it went well. David liked it, and we watched some of the footage. I actually believed the character. It was strange seeing it on the monitor."

Vikksy replied a few minutes later.

"That sounds like progress. The goal isn't to look like you're acting. It's to make the audience believe they're watching a person living through something."

Cassandra smiled as she listened.

Then another message arrived.

"Also, please don't become one of those actors who starts describing every ordinary experience as a masterclass in the human condition."

She burst out laughing.

CASSANDRA: I was about to say the lighting taught me something about life.

VIKKSY: Delete the sentence.

CASSANDRA: The camera angle revealed my inner truth.

VIKKSY: Cassandra, I'm begging you.

CASSANDRA: Art is the mirror through which humanity discovers itself.

VIKKSY: I'm blocking you for your own protection.

She laughed until her stomach hurt.

For a few moments, the pressures of work and school faded. She was simply herself, talking to a friend who had known her long enough to celebrate her progress without treating her like a museum exhibit.

She needed that balance.

Because the next morning, something unexpected happened.

A short behind-the-scenes video from the production appeared on the film's official social media page.

It showed the cast preparing for a scene, the crew adjusting the lights, and David giving Cassandra a direction before filming the letter sequence.

The clip included a few seconds of her performance.

It wasn't the full scene.

It wasn't even the final edited version.

But the moment was powerful enough to stand on its own.

The production team had shared the clip to introduce the characters and give audiences a glimpse of the film's emotional tone.

By lunchtime, people were commenting.

Some praised the cinematography.

Others wanted to know more about the story.

Several viewers mentioned Cassandra's performance.

"Who is the actress playing Amara? Her expression at the end gave me chills."

"This looks like a beautiful film. I need to know what the letter says!"

"That final line. Whoever wrote this understood something about family."

"Please tell me this is coming to cinemas. I'm interested already."

The clip began circulating beyond the production company's usual audience.

A film student reposted it with a note about the power of restrained acting.

Another creator discussed how Cassandra communicated hurt without turning the scene into an exaggerated display of sadness.

By evening, the production office had noticed the increased attention.

Amara Okafor called David.

David called the publicity team.

The publicity team informed the cast that the response was encouraging and that they planned to release more material when appropriate.

Cassandra, meanwhile, was in her hostel, trying to finish an assignment.

Her phone began vibrating repeatedly.

She ignored it for twelve minutes.

Then Rebecca called.

"Cassandra."

"Hello."

"Have you seen the internet?"

Cassandra looked at her laptop.

"Not recently. Is it still there?"

Rebecca made an impatient sound.

"Your scene is everywhere!"

"Everywhere where?"

"Everywhere on the internet that I have personally checked."

"Rebecca, that's not a measurable area."

"It is to me. Open the video."

Cassandra opened the link.

She watched it once.

Then again.

Then she read the comments.

Her heart began beating faster.

"These people are talking about me."

"Yes," Rebecca said. "That is generally what happens when people discover your work."

"But I didn't expect this."

"Neither did I. I expected at least another month before I needed to prepare a celebrity-management spreadsheet."

Cassandra laughed nervously.

"Please don't start."

"I have already created the file."

"You what?"

"It's a joke."

There was a pause.

"Mostly."

Cassandra covered her face.

"Oh, Rebecca."

"Listen to me. Enjoy this. Don't let the numbers become your entire life, but don't pretend it means nothing either. People are responding to your work. That's worth celebrating."

Cassandra looked at the screen again.

The comments were still coming.

She felt excited, grateful, and slightly frightened.

What if people expected more from her now?

What if the finished film didn't live up to the promise of the clip?

What if this attention disappeared tomorrow?

She told Rebecca what she was thinking.

Her friend listened before answering.

"You cannot control every person's reaction. You can control how seriously you prepare, how honestly you work, and how you treat people. Do those things well. Let the rest happen."

Cassandra smiled.

"You're becoming wise."

"Please don't spread that rumour. It will damage my reputation."

They laughed.

Then Cassandra called Vikksy.

He answered with a suspiciously formal voice.

"Good evening. You have reached the office of the unofficial management department. Please state your business after the tone."

Cassandra laughed.

"Stop it!"

"I'm sorry. Our client has recently experienced increased online visibility, and we are updating our procedures."

"Vikksy!"

"Fine, fine. I've seen the clip."

"And?"

"And you did well. The performance is restrained, and that makes it stronger. You didn't force the emotion. You trusted the scene."

Cassandra smiled.

"Thank you."

"Now, important advice. Don't spend all night refreshing the comments. Don't respond to every opinion. Don't let one compliment make you think you've mastered acting, and don't let one criticism convince you that you cannot act."

She sat quietly.

"That sounds reasonable."

"I occasionally produce a useful sentence."

"Occasionally?"

"Let's not exaggerate."

She laughed.

Then he added, more gently, "I'm happy for you, Cass. People are starting to notice something you've been working on for a long time. Enjoy it. You've earned the chance to be seen."

Cassandra looked down at her hands.

"Thank you for always believing in me."

"You're welcome. Now, did you finish your assignment?"

She froze.

"Why would you ask that?"

"Because I know you."

"I was about to."

"That's what you said about lunch."

"Goodnight, Vikksy."

"Goodnight. Finish the assignment."

She ended the call while he was still laughing.

The following day, the publicity team informed the cast that the clip had generated enough interest to justify a more substantial preview closer to the film's premiere.

It was not a guarantee of commercial success.

It did not mean Cassandra had suddenly become a household name.

But the attention had opened a door.

A film journalist requested a short interview with her and David about the making of the film. The production team also received questions from viewers who wanted to know when *The Map of Tomorrow* would be released.

Cassandra found herself preparing answers again.

This time, she was less afraid of the questions.

She knew what she had worked on. She knew what she had learned. She knew that a performance was not created by one person's talent alone, but by the work of actors, writers, directors, cinematographers, editors, and countless others.

When the journalist asked what she hoped audiences would take away from Amara's story, Cassandra answered:

"I hope people see that you can love your family deeply and still have dreams of your own. You don't have to reject where you come from to discover who you can become. And you don't have to stop being afraid before you take the next step."

The journalist paused.

"That's beautifully put."

Cassandra smiled.

"I've been thinking about it for a while."

It was the truth.

As the days passed, the online conversation continued. The clip reached people who had never heard of Cassandra before. Some followed the production account. Others asked about her previous work and discovered *Almost on Purpose*.

The audience was still small compared with the enormous fan bases she would one day encounter.

But for Cassandra, the experience was extraordinary.

For years, she had imagined a future in which people watched her act.

Now, people were discussing her work when she wasn't even in the room.

One evening, she sat with Rebecca, Sarah, and John on campus, sharing snacks while the sun lowered over the university grounds.

John showed her a comment he had found.

"Someone said you're going to be a big star."

Cassandra smiled. "That's kind of them."

Sarah nudged him.

"Don't start treating her differently."

John looked offended.

"I have never treated Cassandra differently."

Rebecca raised an eyebrow.

"You once asked her to help you with an assignment because she was 'the closest thing to a celebrity you knew.'"

"That was networking."

"That was academic laziness."

"It was collaborative learning."

Cassandra laughed.

Then her phone rang.

It was Grandma, calling on behalf of Nelson and Kayla.

Nelson spoke first.

"Mummy, Grandma showed me your video."

"You saw it?"

"Yes! You looked sad."

"I was acting, sweetheart."

"But you looked like you were really sad."

Cassandra smiled.

"That's part of acting. I want people to believe the character."

Nelson considered this.

"You're very good at pretending."

Cassandra laughed.

"Thank you. I think."

Kayla took the phone.

"Mummy, I saw you!"

"You did, darling."

"Are you famous now?"

Cassandra looked at the evening sky.

She thought about the comments, the interview request, and the way her name was beginning to travel beyond the people who knew her personally.

"I'm becoming known to more people," she said. "But I still have work to do."

Kayla accepted this with the effortless confidence of a four-year-old.

"Okay. When you're famous, buy me a big doll."

Nelson shouted from somewhere behind her, "And buy me football boots!"

Cassandra laughed.

"I see that my future success has already been allocated."

Grandma's voice came from the background.

"Don't encourage them!"

"It's too late, Grandma," Cassandra replied. "They have a business plan."

When the call ended, she remained seated for a moment, smiling at her phone.

The video had travelled farther than she expected.

The response had been warmer than she had dared to hope.

And for the first time, Cassandra began to understand how a career could change.

Not always through a dramatic announcement or a life-changing phone call.

Sometimes it began with a scene that connected with a stranger.

A moment of honesty.

A performance that made someone stop scrolling and pay attention.

She put her phone away and returned to the conversation around her.

There would be more work tomorrow.

More lines to learn. More scenes to film. More mistakes to correct. More lessons to carry forward.

She was still a student, still a mother, still Cassandra.

But somewhere out there, new people were learning her name.

And the story she had spent years imagining was finally beginning to reach an audience.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

WHEN THE WORLD LEARNS YOUR NAME

Three months after filming began, Cassandra stood in front of a mirror and tried to decide whether she looked like a rising actress or a university student who had accidentally wandered into a very expensive event.

She turned slightly to the left.

Then to the right.

Then she leaned closer to inspect her makeup.

A voice came from behind her.

"If you inspect your face any harder, it will request legal representation."

Cassandra turned.

Rebecca was sitting on the edge of the bed, wearing a beautiful outfit and looking far too pleased with herself.

"Can you please be serious for five minutes?" Cassandra asked.

"I have been serious for at least four minutes. I'm exceeding expectations."

Tonight was the premiere of *The Map of Tomorrow*.

The film had taken months of preparation, filming, editing, and promotion. The short behind-the-scenes clip had generated interest, and the production team had gradually released trailers introducing the characters and the story.

Now, the finished film was ready.

Cassandra had watched an early cut with the cast and crew, but tonight would be different. The film would be screened for invited guests, journalists, industry professionals, and members of the public.

People would finally see Amara's entire journey.

And Cassandra was terrified.

Not because she believed she had performed badly, but because she cared about the result.

She wanted the story to work.

She wanted the audience to understand Amara.

She wanted all the work everyone had put into the film to mean something.

Rebecca stood and adjusted Cassandra's sleeve.

"Listen to me. You've prepared for this. You've done the interviews. You've attended the rehearsals. You've worked hard. Tonight, you get to enjoy the result."

"What if people don't like the film?"

"Then some people won't like the film. Humanity has survived worse."

Cassandra laughed.

"What if they don't like my performance?"

"Then you'll learn from the feedback and keep working. You are not required to control the opinions of every human being on the planet."

Rebecca paused.

"Although, as your friend, I would appreciate it if the planet developed excellent taste."

Cassandra shook her head.

"You're impossible."

"I'm also dressed beautifully, so let's not focus on my flaws."

A car horn sounded outside.

Their ride had arrived.

Cassandra picked up her handbag, checked that her phone was charged, and took one final look at herself.

For a moment, she remembered the girl who had attended her first audition with a script full of notes and a head full of doubts.

That girl was still there.

She was simply learning to walk forward with the doubts instead of waiting for them to disappear.

"Ready?" Rebecca asked.

Cassandra took a breath.

"Ready."

"Excellent. Let's go before I begin charging you for emotional support."

The premiere venue was already alive when they arrived.

Cameras flashed near the entrance. Guests greeted one another. Journalists interviewed members of the cast, and the production team moved between groups, ensuring that everyone knew where they were supposed to be.

Cassandra stepped out of the car.

For one brief moment, the noise seemed to fade.

Then she heard someone call her name.

"Cassandra! Over here, please!"

She turned toward the photographers.

Another voice called out.

"Cassandra, how does it feel to be part of *The Map of Tomorrow*?"

She smiled and answered as naturally as she could.

"It's exciting. We've worked hard on this film, and I'm looking forward to sharing the story with everyone."

A photographer asked her to turn slightly.

She did.

Another asked for a picture with Rebecca.

Rebecca stepped beside her and smiled.

After the photographs, Rebecca leaned close.

"I hope you appreciate that I have contributed to your public image."

"You posed for photographs."

"Exactly. Years of training."

"What training?"

"Looking good under pressure."

Cassandra laughed as they entered the venue.

Inside, she found Sarah, John, and Abiodun waiting near the reception area.

John greeted her with an exaggerated bow.

"Madam International Actress."

Cassandra rolled her eyes.

"John, please."

"I have prepared a speech."

"Don't."

"I have prepared two speeches."

"Absolutely not."

Abiodun shook her hand solemnly.

"I just want you to know that if you win an award tonight, I always believed in you."

Sarah stared at him.

"You told us last semester that acting was too competitive."

"I was testing her determination."

"You told her to consider accounting."

"I was testing her flexibility."

Rebecca nodded thoughtfully.

"That is a very creative way to describe being wrong."

Everyone laughed.

Then Vikksy arrived.

He walked toward Cassandra, took one look at her outfit, and nodded.

"Excellent."

She smiled. "Thank you."

"Very professional. Very elegant. You look like someone who can negotiate a film contract and still remember her ATM PIN."

Cassandra closed her eyes.

"I should have known."

"That is a compliment."

"It's a strange compliment."

"I specialize in those."

He turned to Rebecca.

"How's the client?"

"She's doing well. You, on the other hand, are on probation."

"What did I do?"

"You're breathing near the client without an appointment."

Vikksy placed a hand over his chest.

"This industry is becoming hostile to independent consultants."

Cassandra laughed.

Then Amara Okafor approached.

She looked elegant in a deep-blue dress and greeted Cassandra warmly.

"You look wonderful."

"Thank you so much."

"How are you feeling?"

Cassandra hesitated.

"Excited. Nervous. A little of everything."

Amara smiled.

"Good. It means the work matters to you. Remember, tonight isn't a final judgment on your career. It's one moment in a long journey."

Cassandra nodded.

"Thank you for giving me this opportunity."

"You earned the opportunity when you showed us what you could do. Now enjoy the evening."

Amara moved on to greet another guest.

Cassandra watched her for a moment, feeling grateful for the producer who had first noticed her at PAU.

Then the lights dimmed.

The audience took their seats.

The film began.

For nearly two hours, Cassandra watched Amara's story unfold.

She saw the family home, the old journal, the argument between siblings, and the journey across Nigeria. She watched Amara confront family secrets, discover her grandfather's abandoned dreams, and begin questioning the assumptions she had made about her own future.

The film was beautiful.

The landscapes felt alive. The dialogue was warm and honest. Femi's performance brought humour and tenderness to Daniel, while Irene gave Amara's mother a quiet strength that held the family scenes together.

Then came Cassandra's letter scene.

The room became still.

She watched herself read the letter, struggle with its meaning, and whisper, "All this time, I thought I was the only one."

When the scene ended, the audience remained quiet for a moment.

Then the film continued.

Cassandra sat motionless.

She knew what happened next. She had read the script, rehearsed the scenes, and filmed them repeatedly.

Yet watching the completed film made everything feel new.

She could finally see how her performance fitted into the larger story.

She could see the work of the cinematographer, the editor, the sound team, the writers, and the director.

It wasn't just her performance.

It was a story everyone had built together.

When the final scene ended, the audience applauded.

The applause grew louder.

Some people stood.

Cassandra blinked rapidly, trying to hold back tears.

Rebecca squeezed her hand.

"Look at you," she whispered.

Cassandra laughed through her tears.

"Don't start."

"I'm not starting anything. I'm simply observing that your face is becoming suspiciously wet."

Cassandra nudged her.

The cast and director were invited to the front for a brief discussion with the audience.

David spoke about the film's themes. Irene discussed the importance of portraying complicated family relationships honestly. Femi made the audience laugh by describing how many times he had been instructed to look at Cassandra as though she had personally offended his ancestors.

Then Cassandra was handed a microphone.

She stood.

For a moment, she looked at the audience.

She had prepared a few sentences, but the words suddenly seemed too formal.

So she spoke honestly.

"Thank you for watching our film. Amara's story means a lot to me because she's trying to understand her family while also figuring out who she wants to become. I think many of us know what it's like to love the people around us and still wonder whether we're brave enough to follow our own dreams."

She paused.

"I hope the film reminds people that it's never too late to ask themselves what kind of life they want to build. And I hope you enjoy watching it as much as we enjoyed making it."

The audience applauded again.

Afterward, guests approached the cast to share their reactions.

One woman told Cassandra that the letter scene had reminded her of her late father.

A young actor asked how Cassandra prepared for emotional scenes.

Another guest praised the way she had portrayed Amara's fear without making the character seem weak.

Cassandra listened carefully.

She thanked them.

She answered questions.

And she began to understand that the work she had done in private had now become something other people could carry into their own lives.

Later that evening, she checked her phone.

Messages filled the screen.

Sarah had posted photographs from the premiere.

John had uploaded a picture of himself beside the film poster, accompanied by a caption claiming that he had personally supervised Cassandra's career.

Rebecca had posted a beautiful photograph of the two of them with the caption:

Some dreams begin as conversations between friends. Tonight, we watched one become real.

Vikksy had posted a photograph of the film poster with a short message:

Proud of Cassandra and the work she's put into this. The world is getting to see what we've been encouraging her to keep developing for a long time. This is one step, and there are many more ahead.

Then, beneath it, he had added:

Unofficial management department remains unpaid.

Cassandra laughed.

She was about to reply when a message from Amara arrived.

Cassandra, congratulations. The early reviews are very encouraging. The film has also received interest from an international festival, and the team will share more information when everything is confirmed. Rest tonight. You've earned a moment to celebrate.

Cassandra read the message twice.

An international festival.

The words seemed almost too large to fit on her phone screen.

She showed Rebecca.

Rebecca stared at it.

Then she slowly sat down.

"Cassandra."

"I know."

"Cassandra."

"I know!"

Rebecca looked toward the ceiling.

"I need to thank God, the university, the entire entertainment industry, and whoever invented Wi-Fi."

Cassandra burst out laughing.

Vikksy approached.

"What's happening?"

Rebecca handed him the phone.

He read the message.

For once, he didn't immediately make a joke.

He looked at Cassandra and smiled.

"That's a meaningful step. Let yourself enjoy it."

She nodded.

"There's still so much to do."

"Naturally. But you don't have to postpone happiness until you've achieved everything."

Cassandra looked at him.

Then she smiled.

For years, she had imagined what it would feel like to succeed.

She had imagined the applause, the interviews, the opportunities, and the possibility that one day her name might mean something to people who had never met her.

But she had never imagined how much she would want to share those moments with the people who had been there before the applause.

Her mother.

Her children.

Her friends.

The people who had watched her rehearse, listened to her doubts, and encouraged her when the future was still uncertain.

Tonight, she wanted to remember all of them.

Because whatever happened next, she hadn't travelled this far alone.

And she wasn't going to forget that.

Two weeks later, the news arrived.

The Map of Tomorrow had been selected for a respected international film festival.

The production team announced the selection publicly, celebrating the film's cast and crew.

Cassandra's name appeared in the announcement.

It was not yet a major international award nomination. It was not a guarantee that every door would open.

But it meant that a story made by a Nigerian production team had earned a place in an international showcase.

And Cassandra was part of it.

Her phone rang almost immediately.

Rebecca.

"Cassandra, have you seen the announcement?"

"Yes!"

"Good. Because I have prepared a very dignified response."

"What is it?"

Rebecca screamed.

Cassandra screamed back.

Someone in the neighbouring hostel corridor knocked on a wall.

Rebecca lowered her voice.

"Sorry. International development."

Cassandra laughed until she had to sit down.

Later, she called her children.

Nelson listened carefully as she explained that her film would be shown to audiences in another country.

"Does that mean people far away will see you?"

"Yes, sweetheart."

"Even people who don't know you?"

"Even people who don't know me."

Nelson considered this.

"Then you should tell them you're my mummy."

Cassandra smiled.

"I think I can mention that."

Kayla joined the call.

"And tell them you're a princess!"

Cassandra laughed.

"I'll see what I can do."

After the call, she sat quietly for a moment.

Her world was expanding.

Not because she had suddenly become a different person, but because the work she had done was travelling beyond the places she knew.

And somewhere across the ocean, a new opportunity was beginning to take shape.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

THE GIRL FROM LAGOS GOES GLOBAL

The invitation arrived on a Thursday morning.

Cassandra was in the university library, attempting to finish an assignment, when her phone vibrated.

She glanced at the screen.

An email from Amara Okafor Productions.

She opened it.

Then she read it again.

Then she closed it, took a breath, and opened it a third time.

The production team had received an invitation from a London-based film company, Northstar Pictures, to participate in a development showcase for selected African film projects.

The company was assembling a new international feature titled *Beyond the Horizon*, a drama about young people from different countries whose lives intersect while pursuing ambitious dreams.

The filmmakers were looking for an actress to play **Maya**, a Nigerian student who leaves home for an international opportunity and discovers that achieving a dream can be more complicated than imagining it.

The role was substantial.

The production team had recommended Cassandra for an audition.

If selected, she would travel to the United Kingdom for filming.

Cassandra stared at the email.

A girl sitting at the next table glanced at her.

"Are you okay?"

Cassandra slowly looked up.

"I think my future has just sent me an email."

The girl blinked.

Then she returned to her laptop.

Cassandra couldn't blame her. University students had enough problems without investigating other people's inboxes.

She hurried outside and called Rebecca.

Rebecca answered while walking between lectures.

"What's wrong?"

"Nothing."

"Then why do you sound like someone who has just seen a ghost?"

Cassandra explained.

Rebecca stopped walking.

"What?"

"There's an international audition."

"What?"

"They want me to audition for a role in a film being developed in London."

Rebecca became silent.

Cassandra checked the screen.

"Rebecca?"

"I'm here."

"Why aren't you saying anything?"

"I'm calculating."

"Calculating what?"

"The number of times I've told people you were going to become famous."

"Rebecca!"

"I'm going to need an accurate figure for my autobiography."

Cassandra laughed.

Then Rebecca's voice softened.

"Cass, this is wonderful. And it's an audition, not a guarantee, so we're going to celebrate the opportunity and prepare properly."

"That's exactly what Vikksy would say."

"Please don't insult me."

Cassandra laughed harder.

"Sorry."

"Send me the details. I'll help you research the company and organize your preparation schedule. But first, you need to check the dates against your schoolwork and the filming schedule."

Cassandra nodded, even though Rebecca couldn't see her.

"You're right."

"I know. That's why I keep talking."

They ended the call, and Cassandra immediately contacted Vikksy.

He answered with his usual greeting.

"Welcome to the office of the unofficial management department. We are currently accepting congratulations, snacks, and payment."

"Vikksy, I have news."

"Excellent. Is it about my payment?"

"No."

"Then the news has started badly."

She explained the invitation.

For a few seconds, he said nothing.

Then he exhaled.

"Cass, that's big."

"I know."

"How are you feeling?"

"Excited. Scared. Confused. Hungry."

"Good. Hunger is manageable. We can work with that."

She laughed.

He continued.

"First, congratulations. Second, let's separate what we know from what we hope. You have been recommended for an audition. That's a real opportunity. You haven't been cast yet, so we prepare for the audition rather than planning your entire international career tonight."

Cassandra smiled.

"You're very good at bringing me back to earth."

"Someone has to. Rebecca is already planning your autobiography."

"How do you know?"

"Because she sent me a message asking whether I remembered the first time you told us you wanted to act."

Cassandra laughed.

"She did not."

"She absolutely did. The working title is apparently *I Knew Her Before the Posters*."

Cassandra covered her face.

"I cannot believe you two."

"We are a professional support network."

"You are a public nuisance."

"A highly organized public nuisance."

Then Vikksy became practical.

"Send me the audition brief. We'll go through the character, the scene, the format, and the deadline. Also, don't forget to ask the production team about travel arrangements, accommodation, work authorization, and the schedule if you get selected. Those details matter."

Cassandra made notes.

"Thank you."

"You're welcome. Now eat something."

"Why does everyone keep telling me to eat?"

"Because your career is advancing, but your lunch habits remain a national concern."

Over the following days, Cassandra studied the audition brief.

Maya was a young Nigerian woman who had earned a place in an international creative programme. She was intelligent, ambitious, and deeply attached to her family, but she struggled with the fear that pursuing her dreams might make her seem ungrateful for everything she had been given.

In the audition scene, Maya spoke to her mother shortly before leaving home.

Her mother supported her decision, but Maya could sense the sadness beneath the encouragement.

The scene was quiet.

No dramatic argument.

No screaming.

No spectacular revelation.

Just two people who loved each other trying to be brave for one another.

Cassandra understood the emotional territory.

She knew what it meant to pursue something important while worrying about the people who depended on her.

But she also knew that Maya wasn't Cassandra.

The character had her own background, fears, and personality.

Vikksy helped her explore the distinction.

"What's Maya's greatest fear?" he asked during a rehearsal call.

"That she'll fail."

"That's one fear. Go deeper."

Cassandra thought.

"That she'll leave home, disappoint her family, and discover she wasn't capable of doing what she came for."

"Better. What does she want from her mother in this scene?"

"Permission to go?"

"Maybe. But she already has permission. What does she really want?"

Cassandra considered the scene again.

"She wants her mother to tell her that leaving doesn't mean she's abandoning them."

Vikksy paused.

"Keep that."

She wrote it in the margin of her script.

They rehearsed the scene several times.

Vikksy played Maya's mother, which he insisted was an extraordinary demonstration of his acting range.

His interpretation involved an unusually deep voice and a dramatic adjustment of his shoulders.

Cassandra stared at the screen.

"Why are you moving like that?"

"I'm embodying motherhood."

"You look like you're preparing to announce the national budget."

"Motherhood requires financial planning."

She laughed so hard that they had to restart the rehearsal.

Eventually, they completed a serious take.

Cassandra delivered the scene with restraint. She allowed Maya's uncertainty to emerge through pauses and small changes in expression rather than explaining every emotion.

When she finished, Vikksy nodded.

"That's strong."

She smiled.

"Thank you."

"Although my performance as the mother was also exceptional."

"Please don't ruin the moment."

"Art requires honesty."

"Your art requires supervision."

He laughed.

The next day, Cassandra recorded her audition.

She checked the lighting, tested the sound, and ensured that the background was simple enough not to distract from the performance.

She wore a professional outfit, reviewed the instructions, and made sure the file met the submission requirements.

Before pressing send, she paused.

She thought about her first audition for Amara Okafor Productions.

She remembered how nervous she had been, how carefully she had rehearsed, and how uncertain she had felt when she entered the room.

She was still nervous now.

But she knew more than she had known then.

She understood the importance of listening to a scene partner. She had learned to accept direction without treating it as criticism. She had discovered that a character's silence could be as meaningful as a speech.

She had grown.

Cassandra pressed send.

The audition was submitted.

She sat back in her chair.

Then she called Rebecca.

"Done."

Rebecca screamed.

Cassandra held the phone away from her ear.

"Rebecca!"

"I'm celebrating!"

"You're damaging my hearing."

"Your hearing will recover. Your career is expanding."

"Those two things are not related."

"They are now."

They laughed.

For the next several days, Cassandra returned to her normal routine.

She attended classes, worked through assignments, and continued her commitments to *The Map of Tomorrow*. She spent time with her children whenever she could and resisted the temptation to check her email every five minutes.

She resisted it for approximately twenty minutes at a time.

Vikksy remained unimpressed.

VIKKSY: Any update?

CASSANDRA: No.

VIKKSY: Excellent. Continue living.

CASSANDRA: I'm trying.

VIKKSY: Try harder. The email server is not personally plotting against you.

Three days later, an email arrived.

Cassandra was in her room when she saw the notification.

She opened it.

The message was from Northstar Pictures.

The casting team thanked her for submitting the audition and invited her to a live online callback with the director and casting director.

They wanted to explore the character further and see how she responded to direction.

Cassandra stood up so quickly that her chair rolled backward.

She called Rebecca.

Rebecca answered.

"Did you get it?"

"How do you know?"

"Because you called me at an hour when you normally complain about assignments. Did you get it?"

Cassandra laughed.

"I got the callback!"

Rebecca screamed.

Then she screamed again.

Someone shouted from somewhere in the hostel corridor.

Rebecca lowered her voice.

"Sorry! Academic celebration!"

Cassandra laughed until she had tears in her eyes.

Then she called Vikksy.

He listened to the news and congratulated her.

"That's progress. Now we prepare for the callback."

"You don't sound surprised."

"I'm delighted. I simply refuse to be surprised by your progress when you have been working toward it."

Cassandra smiled.

"Thank you."

"Also, I expect my management fee to increase when your career expands internationally."

"Your management fee is currently zero."

"Exactly. There is significant room for growth."

The callback took place the following week.

Cassandra joined the video meeting early and checked her camera.

The director, Eleanor Brooks, appeared on screen alongside casting director Michael Reed.

After introductions, Eleanor asked Cassandra to perform the scene.

Cassandra did.

When she finished, Eleanor nodded.

"Thank you. That was thoughtful. Let's try something different."

She gave Cassandra a new direction.

This time, Maya was less composed. She was trying to sound confident, but her fear kept slipping through.

Cassandra adjusted her approach.

She performed the scene again.

Eleanor watched closely.

"Good. Now I want you to imagine Maya is trying not to cry because she believes her mother will become upset if she does. Don't force the tears. Let her fight to remain composed."

Cassandra nodded.

She took a moment.

Then she performed the scene a third time.

When she finished, Eleanor smiled.

"That's interesting. You made a very different choice without losing the character. Thank you, Cassandra."

They discussed the role, the production's plans, and Cassandra's experience working on *The Map of Tomorrow*.

Michael asked how she approached feedback.

"I try to understand what the director is looking for rather than simply repeating the same performance more dramatically," Cassandra replied. "Sometimes I need a moment to understand the direction, but I want to learn how to serve the story better."

Eleanor nodded.

"That's a good attitude to bring to a production."

The meeting ended with polite goodbyes.

Cassandra closed her laptop and stared at the wall.

She had done it.

She had auditioned for an international production, taken direction from a director she had never met in person, and completed the meeting without losing her train of thought.

Whatever happened next, she had gained something valuable.

She was learning to work beyond the limits of the world she already knew.

Two days later, her phone rang.

The call came from Amara Okafor Productions.

Cassandra answered immediately.

"Hello?"

The production coordinator sounded cheerful.

"Hi, Cassandra. Do you have a moment?"

"Yes."

"I have an update about *Beyond the Horizon*. Northstar Pictures would like to offer you the role of Maya."

Cassandra stopped breathing.

Then she remembered Chapter One of her life, when she had been nervous about attending her first audition.

She remembered the countless rehearsals, the small opportunities, the mistakes, the lessons, and the people who had encouraged her.

"Are you serious?" she whispered.

"We are. Congratulations."

Cassandra pressed a hand over her mouth.

The coordinator explained that the team would send the formal offer, schedule, and contract for review. The role would require filming in the United Kingdom, and the production companies would coordinate the necessary arrangements, including travel and work authorization.

Cassandra listened carefully, asking questions about the dates and the practical details.

She wasn't going to let excitement prevent her from understanding what she was agreeing to.

When the call ended, she sat very still.

Then she called Rebecca.

Rebecca answered.

"What's happening?"

Cassandra tried to speak.

Nothing came out.

"Cassandra?"

"They offered me the role."

Silence.

Then Rebecca screamed so loudly that Cassandra had to move the phone away from her ear.

"THEY OFFERED YOU THE ROLE?"

"Yes!"

"YOU'RE GOING TO BE IN AN INTERNATIONAL FILM!"

"If the arrangements are finalized, yes!"

Rebecca stopped screaming.

"Correct. We celebrate responsibly. Business Administration has trained me to recognize the importance of contracts."

Cassandra burst out laughing.

"Please don't negotiate my entire life."

"I will negotiate your snack allowance."

"Rebecca!"

They laughed together, both of them overwhelmed by the moment.

Cassandra called Vikksy next.

He listened quietly as she explained.

Then he said, "Cass, congratulations. You earned this."

Her eyes filled with tears.

"Thank you."

"You prepared. You listened. You improved. And when the opportunity came, you did the work."

She wiped her eyes.

"I'm going to London."

"Looks that way."

"I can't believe it."

"You can believe it. You just haven't finished processing it."

She laughed softly.

Then he added, "And remember, this is an opportunity, not a reason to put impossible pressure on yourself. Learn everything you can. Ask questions. Be professional. Enjoy the experience."

Cassandra nodded.

"I will."

"Also, I expect a photograph of the airport."

She laughed.

"Why?"

"Research."

"Research for what?"

"My autobiography: *I Knew Her Before the Airport*."

Cassandra laughed so hard she nearly dropped the phone.

Later that evening, she called her mother and told her the news.

Mama Izu was delighted, though she immediately began asking practical questions.

"When are you travelling? Who is arranging your accommodation? Have they sent the contract? What about the children?"

Cassandra smiled.

"I knew those would be your first questions."

"Because somebody has to ask them."

They discussed the details carefully. Cassandra would not leave until the contract and travel arrangements were properly confirmed, and her family would work together to ensure Nelson and Kayla were cared for while she was away.

When Cassandra called the children, Nelson listened with wide eyes.

"Mummy, you're going to another country?"

"Yes, sweetheart. For work."

"Will you come back?"

"Always. We'll talk while I'm away, and I'll come home after filming."

Kayla climbed into the conversation.

"Bring me something!"

Cassandra laughed.

"What would you like?"

"A doll."

Nelson shouted, "Football boots!"

Cassandra shook her head.

"Your international shopping department has opened remarkably quickly."

Kayla giggled.

Nelson looked serious.

"Mummy, will you be on the big screen there too?"

Cassandra smiled.

"I hope so."

"Then do your best."

The simplicity of his encouragement nearly undid her.

"I will, sweetheart."

That night, Cassandra stood by the window of her hostel room.

Lagos glowed beyond the campus, familiar and full of life. Somewhere nearby, a generator hummed. A car horn sounded. Someone laughed in the corridor.

Everything looked the same.

But Cassandra felt different.

A few months earlier, she had been an aspiring actress hoping to be taken seriously.

Now she had completed two films, received recognition for her work, participated in an international development meeting, and secured an offer for a role in a production that would take her beyond Nigeria.

She was still a student.

Still a mother.

Still learning.

Still the same woman who laughed at Rebecca's jokes and received battery warnings from Vikksy.

But the world she could reach was getting bigger.

She opened her notebook and wrote:

Today, an opportunity that once seemed impossibly far away became something I could actually prepare for.

Then she added:

I am not going because I have nothing left to learn. I am going because I am ready to learn more.

She closed the notebook.

Her phone vibrated.

A message from Vikksy.

VIKKSY: One last thing.

CASSANDRA: What now?

VIKKSY: Charge your phone before international travel.

Cassandra burst out laughing.

Some things, apparently, were destined to remain exactly as they were.

And as she prepared for the next chapter of her life, she carried more than a suitcase and a script.

She carried the lessons she had learned, the love of her family, the laughter of her friends, and the growing belief that she was capable of walking into rooms she had once only imagined.

London was waiting.

And Cassandra was ready to meet it.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

FAME HAS A VERY BUSY CALENDAR

London welcomed Cassandra with cold weather, tall buildings, and the immediate suspicion that everyone had somewhere important to be.

She stood outside the hotel window, wrapped in a cardigan, watching the city move beneath a grey morning sky.

Her phone vibrated.

VIKKSY: *Good morning, international woman of mystery.*

CASSANDRA: *Good morning. It's freezing.*

VIKKSY: *That is London's way of asking whether you brought sense from Nigeria.*

CASSANDRA: *I brought a coat.*

VIKKSY: *Excellent. You may survive the first episode.*

Cassandra laughed and set the phone down.

She had come to London to film *Beyond the Horizon*, playing Maya, a Nigerian student who travelled abroad to pursue her dreams while wrestling with the fear that she might disappoint the people she loved.

The irony was not lost on Cassandra.

She had spent years wondering whether she could balance motherhood, university, and acting. Now she was thousands of kilometres from home, working on an international production with actors she had previously admired from a distance.

It was exciting.

It was terrifying.

And the hotel breakfast was so expensive that she briefly considered returning to Lagos and becoming a professional rice consultant.

But she had come to work.

And work she would.

The Set That Never Slept

The *Beyond the Horizon* set was a world of its own.

There were assistants carrying clipboards, technicians adjusting lights, costume designers discussing fabrics with the seriousness of international peace negotiations, and actors who could transform from ordinary people into heartbroken geniuses in less time than it took Cassandra to find her misplaced script.

Director Eleanor Brooks welcomed her warmly.

"Cassandra, we're happy to have you here. How are you settling in?"

"Very well, thank you. I'm still learning the city."

"Anything surprising so far?"

"The weather."

Eleanor laughed. "You'll get used to it."

"I'm Nigerian. We have sunshine that can make you question your life choices. This cold is a different kind of character development."

Eleanor grinned. "I think Maya would appreciate that line."

Their first week was demanding. Cassandra filmed scenes in which Maya argued with her parents over a video call, struggled to find her footing at a new university, and questioned whether chasing an opportunity abroad meant she was abandoning home.

Some scenes required tears. Others demanded restraint. One required Cassandra to deliver a long speech while walking through a crowded station without looking as though she was trying to remember a shopping list.

That last one was harder than it sounded.

During a rehearsal, Cassandra hurried through the speech, determined to get every word right.

Eleanor raised a hand.

"Let's stop there. You're giving me the information, but Maya is trying to convince herself she's making the right decision. She's not delivering a presentation. She's fighting to believe what she's saying."

Cassandra nodded.

"Let's try again," Eleanor said. "This time, don't worry about getting to the end of the speech. Think about the person Maya wishes she could call."

Cassandra thought of her children.

Nelson, who always wanted to know whether she had eaten.

Kayla, who believed every important woman should own at least one crown.

Mama Izu, who could offer advice, prayer, and a stern warning in the same breath.

And the people who had encouraged her when her biggest audience was a classroom full of students waiting for the lecturer to dismiss them.

Cassandra began again.

This time, the words came more slowly. Maya's confidence cracked in the right places. Her determination became something the audience could feel rather than merely hear.

When Cassandra finished, the set was quiet for a moment.

Eleanor smiled.

"That's her."

Cassandra exhaled.

For a young actress who had once been nervous about auditioning in front of a handful of people, hearing those two words from an international director felt enormous.

Still, she resisted the temptation to celebrate too early.

She had another scene in twenty minutes.

And the costume department was looking for her.

Apparently, even emotional breakthroughs had scheduling conflicts.

The Calendar Conspiracy

By the time filming ended, Cassandra's career had begun moving faster than she could comfortably process.

The Map of Tomorrow had received strong reviews at the international festival. Critics praised the film's emotional storytelling, and several mentioned Cassandra's performance as one of its quiet strengths.

Almost on Purpose was finding a wider audience through streaming distribution.

People who had never met Cassandra were beginning to recognize her face.

Her social media following grew. Interviews arrived. Invitations appeared. A fashion brand requested a meeting. An entertainment magazine wanted a profile. Another production company asked whether she would consider auditioning for an upcoming drama.

Her phone became a full-time employee that never applied for leave.

The problem was that Cassandra was still a student, still a mother, and still a human being who occasionally needed to sleep.

One evening, she sat at her hotel desk surrounded by scripts, interview notes, university materials, and a half-eaten packet of biscuits.

She opened her calendar.

Then she closed it.

Then she opened it again, as if the events might have rearranged themselves out of shame.

They had not.

She called Rebecca.

Rebecca answered from her hostel room at PAU, wearing a bonnet and looking prepared to negotiate a corporate merger.

"Talk to me, superstar."

"I think my calendar hates me."

"Your calendar doesn't hate you. Your calendar is a victim of poor management."

"Rebecca, I have filming, two interviews, a university assignment, a meeting with the production team, and a video call with the children. I also promised to read a script."

"And when did you plan to sleep?"

Cassandra considered the question.

"That's not currently in the schedule."

Rebecca stared at the screen.

"Girl. Even your phone needs time to charge. You are not a solar-powered actress."

"I know."

"No, you know the words. I need you to understand the concept."

Cassandra laughed, then rubbed her forehead.

Rebecca's expression softened.

"Listen. We can organize the calendar. But we also need to decide what actually matters. Not every invitation is an opportunity you must accept. Some are just people with your email address."

"That should be printed on a T-shirt."

"It should be printed on the national currency."

Together, they reorganized Cassandra's week. Rebecca helped her identify which invitations required immediate attention, which could wait, and which were not worth accepting at all.

They protected time for her university work and set aside regular calls with Nelson and Kayla.

Rebecca also insisted on a weekly check-in.

"Every Sunday," she declared. "You report your schedule, your stress level, and whether you've eaten something that didn't come in a packet."

"You're becoming my manager."

"No. Your manager gets paid."

"That was unnecessary."

"It was also accurate."

Later that night, Cassandra called Vikksy.

He listened while she described the growing attention, the long days, and the strange pressure to be grateful for every opportunity even when she was exhausted.

When she finished, he was quiet for a moment.

Then he said, "Cassandra, being grateful for an opportunity doesn't mean you must accept every opportunity."

She leaned back in her chair.

"Rebecca said something similar."

"Rebecca is wise. Occasionally, she is even tolerable."

"She says the same thing about you."

"That's how we know the friendship is genuine. We insult each other with consistency."

Cassandra smiled.

Vikksy's voice became more serious.

"You worked hard to get here. Don't let the excitement make you forget that you still have limits. Rest isn't a reward for finishing everything. If you wait until everything is finished, you'll never rest."

She looked at the open calendar.

"I don't want to disappoint anyone."

"You can't make everybody happy, and you shouldn't build your life around trying. Do your work properly. Keep your promises where you can. Be honest when you can't. The people who genuinely respect you will understand that you're a person, not a public utility."

Cassandra laughed softly.

"A public utility?"

"Yes. Available twenty-four hours a day, occasionally interrupted by poor network, and blamed whenever anything goes wrong."

"You're impossible."

"But am I incorrect?"

She shook her head, smiling.

"No."

"Then my work here is complete."

It wasn't the first time Vikksy had reminded her of something she already knew. Sometimes, though, a familiar truth became easier to follow when someone who cared about you said it plainly.

Before they ended the call, he asked about her next scene, listened to her concerns, and helped her think through the emotional transition she was struggling with.

He didn't pretend to be an expert in everything. He simply asked good questions and encouraged her to trust the preparation she had done.

That was one of the things Cassandra valued most about him.

He could make her laugh when she needed a laugh, challenge her when she needed a challenge, and leave the jokes alone when the moment called for honesty.

Their friendship had survived changes in their lives because it was built on something deeper than what either person could gain from the other.

He wanted her to succeed.

She wanted the same for him.

There was no competition in it.

Only friendship, respect, and the occasional argument about who was more annoying.

Vikksy maintained that Rebecca was the winner.

Rebecca maintained that Vikksy was a public menace.

Both arguments had considerable evidence.

Home Is a Video Call Away

On Sunday evening, Cassandra sat on her hotel bed and called home.

Nelson appeared first, holding the phone too close to his face.

"Mummy!"

"Hello, my love!"

"Have you finished the movie?"

"Not yet. We're still filming."

"How many more days?"

Cassandra smiled.

"Some more days, sweetheart."

Nelson thought about that.

"Okay. But when you finish, are you coming home?"

"Yes. I'll come home."

"Promise?"

"I promise."

Kayla pushed into the frame wearing a pink headband.

"Mummy, did you see my drawing?"

"I haven't seen it today."

Grandma appeared in the background and held up a picture. It showed Cassandra wearing a crown, with two smaller figures standing beside her. Above them, Kayla had written a collection of letters that appeared to mean *MUMMY QUEEN*.

"It's beautiful," Cassandra said.

"I made you a queen because you're acting."

"That is very thoughtful."

"Can you bring me a queen dress from London?"

Cassandra laughed.

"We'll discuss the royal budget."

Nelson immediately joined the negotiations.

"And football boots."

"Of course," Cassandra said. "One royal dress and one pair of football boots."

"And sweets," Kayla added.

"Your Majesty, the treasury is under pressure."

Grandma laughed behind the camera.

For the next several minutes, Cassandra forgot about interviews, reviews, schedules, and the fact that strangers were beginning to recognize her.

She was simply their mother.

She listened to Nelson explain a school activity, admired Kayla's drawing, and asked Grandma how everyone was doing.

After the call, she sat quietly for a moment.

She missed them.

There was no clever way around that truth.

She was proud of the life she was building, but missing her children did not mean she had made the wrong decision. It meant she loved them.

She opened her notebook and wrote a sentence beneath her schedule:

Success must make room for the people I love.

Then she underlined it.

Twice.

The Interview That Went Everywhere

A few days later, Cassandra sat for an interview with an international entertainment magazine.

The interviewer asked about her journey from a university student in Lagos to an actress working on an international production.

"What has surprised you most about this experience?" the interviewer asked.

Cassandra thought for a moment.

"How much of acting happens before you enter the scene. People see the finished performance, but they don't see the preparation, the mistakes, the conversations with the director, or the days when you have to try something five different ways before it feels right."

"And has fame changed you?"

Cassandra smiled.

"I think it has made me more aware of how much I still have to learn. People can recognize your face before they know anything about you. That's a strange feeling. But I don't want to spend my life trying to become a person strangers approve of. I want to become a better actress and a better person."

The interviewer nodded.

"You speak often about your family. How do you balance that with your career?"

"I'm still learning. I don't think balance means giving every part of your life the same amount of time every day. Sometimes work needs more attention. Sometimes family does. The important thing is not to let a busy season convince you that the people you love can wait forever."

The interview was published two days later.

The response was immediate.

Readers praised her honesty. Young actors shared her answers. One comment read:

She sounds like someone who knows what she wants without pretending she has everything figured out.

Cassandra saved that one.

Not because it called her inspiring, but because it understood her.

That evening, Rebecca sent a screenshot.

REBECCA: *Your interview is trending.*

CASSANDRA: *What does that mean?*

REBECCA: *It means people are talking about you.*

CASSANDRA: *Are they saying nice things?*

REBECCA: *Mostly.*

CASSANDRA: *Mostly?*

REBECCA: *Congratulations. You have officially entered the stage of fame where somebody dislikes your existence because you wore a blue dress.*

Vikksy joined the conversation.

VIKKSY: *This is a major milestone. Next, somebody will criticize the way you breathe in interviews.*

CASSANDRA: *You two are not helping.*

REBECCA: *We are preparing you for the industry.*

VIKKSY: *Consider us your emotional support troublemakers.*

Cassandra put her phone down, laughing.

Then she picked it up again because another message had arrived.

This one was from Eleanor Brooks.

The director wanted to speak with her about the final scenes of *Beyond the Horizon*. There was also talk of submitting the film to several major festivals after post-production.

Nothing was guaranteed.

There were still scenes to film, edits to make, and months of work ahead.

But Cassandra had learned not to confuse uncertainty with failure.

She had once hoped simply to be chosen for a role.

Now she was learning how to carry the responsibility that came with being chosen.

She looked at the London skyline through the hotel window.

Somewhere in Lagos, her children were preparing for bed. Somewhere at PAU, Rebecca was probably planning three people's futures without their permission. Somewhere, Vikksy was almost certainly preparing a joke at her expense.

And here she was, thousands of kilometres from where her journey had begun, doing the work she had dreamed of doing.

She wasn't at the top yet.

But she was no longer standing at the bottom, wondering whether the climb was possible.

She was climbing.

And the next step was waiting.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

THE NIGHT SHE BECAME A LEGEND

The invitation arrived on a Tuesday afternoon.

Cassandra was in Lagos, back from filming *Beyond the Horizon*, sitting at the dining table while Nelson attempted to explain the rules of a game he had invented and Kayla decorated the corner of a notebook with stars.

Her phone rang.

The number was unfamiliar.

She answered.

"Hello, Cassandra speaking."

"Good afternoon, Cassandra. My name is Olivia Grant. I'm calling from the International Screen Awards."

Cassandra straightened in her chair.

"Good afternoon."

"I'm pleased to tell you that *Beyond the Horizon* has been selected for our annual awards programme. The nominations have just been announced, and your performance as Maya has received a nomination for Best Actress."

For a moment, Cassandra forgot how to respond.

She had heard the words.

She understood the words.

Her mind simply refused to arrange them into something believable.

"I'm sorry," she said at last. "Could you repeat that?"

Olivia kindly did.

Cassandra covered her mouth.

"Thank you. Thank you so much."

"Congratulations. We look forward to seeing you at the ceremony."

When the call ended, she remained still.

Nelson looked up from the floor.

"Mummy?"

She turned toward him, her eyes shining.

"I've been nominated for an acting award."

He blinked.

"Does that mean you won?"

"Not yet, sweetheart. It means they think I might."

Nelson considered this with the seriousness of a six-year-old evaluating a business proposal.

"Then you should win."

Kayla abandoned her notebook.

"Is it a princess award?"

Cassandra laughed through her tears.

"It's an acting award."

"Can princesses get it?"

"Some princesses probably can."

"Then you should win," Kayla declared, as though the matter had been settled by royal decree.

Grandma entered the room and immediately noticed Cassandra's expression.

"What happened?"

Cassandra told her.

Grandma's hands flew to her mouth.

"God has been good to you."

She embraced Cassandra, who held her tightly.

The children joined the hug, although neither seemed entirely certain why everyone was emotional.

Nelson eventually asked whether award ceremonies served food.

Kayla wanted to know whether the award came with a crown.

Cassandra decided that both were reasonable questions.

Then she called Mama Izu.

Then her siblings.

Then Rebecca.

Rebecca answered with her usual greeting.

"Girl, what happened? Why are you calling in the middle of the day? Is somebody in trouble?"

"I've been nominated for Best Actress."

Silence.

Cassandra checked the screen to make sure the call hadn't disconnected.

"Rebecca?"

A scream exploded through the speaker.

Cassandra pulled the phone away from her ear.

"REBECCA!"

"BEST ACTRESS? INTERNATIONAL AWARD? CASSANDRA, ARE YOU TRYING TO MAKE ME COLLAPSE IN THIS HOSTEL?"

"I'm sorry!"

"No, you're not! You're sitting there with your calm voice while I'm experiencing a personal earthquake!"

Cassandra laughed so hard that Nelson asked her to explain the joke.

Rebecca was already talking.

"Listen. We are celebrating. We are celebrating properly. I'm going to organize everything."

"Rebecca, the ceremony is abroad."

"I heard you. I studied Business Administration. Distance is a logistical problem, not a spiritual limitation."

"How exactly are you going to organize a celebration across continents?"

"First, I will develop a strategy. Second, I will develop a better strategy. Third, I will call Vikksy because he knows how to make technology behave."

"Technology doesn't behave," Cassandra said.

"Then he can threaten it until it cooperates."

Rebecca hung up only after extracting the ceremony date, the travel details, and a promise that Cassandra would send her a photograph of the invitation.

Next came Vikksy.

He answered on the second ring.

"Why does your voice sound like someone has given you good news and you're trying not to disturb the neighbours?"

Cassandra told him.

There was a pause.

Then he said, quietly, "Cassandra. That's huge."

She smiled.

"It is."

"I'm genuinely proud of you. Not just because you've been nominated, but because I know how much work you've put into this. The practice, the rejection, the studying, the days you had to keep going when nobody could promise you anything. You earned the right to be in that room."

Her eyes filled again.

"Thank you."

"Now, having delivered this excellent emotional speech, I must address the practical issue."

She laughed.

"What issue?"

"If you win, I expect a formal acknowledgement of my contributions as unofficial acting adviser, emergency motivational speaker, and part-time technology consultant."

"You helped me prepare for auditions."

"Exactly. My services are clearly extensive."

"Rebecca helped me prepare too."

"Rebecca will receive an award for strategic planning and shouting."

"She's going to love that."

"Good. Also, do not forget your charger."

Cassandra burst out laughing.

"Vikksy!"

"What? History has shown that important events and low battery percentages have an unhealthy relationship."

She shook her head.

"Thank you for being there for me."

"Always, bestie. Go do your thing."

There was no grand declaration, no complicated promise, no attempt to make her achievement about him.

Just a friend, proud of someone he cared about, telling her to keep going.

It was exactly what she needed.

Preparing for the Biggest Night of Her Life

The International Screen Awards ceremony was held several months later, after *Beyond the Horizon* completed its festival run and gained a wider international release.

The nomination itself had brought new attention to Cassandra. The film had been praised for its thoughtful writing, and her portrayal of Maya had become one of the performances critics discussed most.

But the weeks before the ceremony were not a magical montage of effortless success.

Cassandra still had to finish university assignments. She still had responsibilities at home. She still needed to prepare for interviews and review the speech she had written in case she won.

And she still had moments when she looked at the nomination announcement and wondered whether somebody had accidentally selected the wrong name.

During one video call, Rebecca caught her staring at the screen.

"Stop looking at that nomination like it owes you money."

"I'm just thinking."

"You're overthinking. There is a difference."

"What if I lose?"

"Then you will still be the same actress who earned the nomination."

Cassandra looked down.

Rebecca continued.

"Listen to me. Winning would be wonderful. But the nomination already means your work reached people who took it seriously. Don't turn the possibility of losing into a reason to be afraid of winning."

Cassandra nodded.

"You're right."

"I know. It's one of my most exhausting qualities."

"Your humility?"

"My intelligence."

"Naturally."

Rebecca leaned closer to the camera.

"And wear something beautiful. If you are going to make history, please do not dress like you are attending a compulsory departmental meeting."

"I'll keep that in mind."

Vikksy helped her prepare for the interviews.

He advised her to remember the people who had contributed to her journey, answer questions honestly, and avoid feeling pressured to tell the same rehearsed story every time.

"You're allowed to be nervous," he told her. "Just don't let the nerves answer the questions for you."

"What if they ask me something I don't know?"

"Then say you don't know. You are an actress, Cassandra, not an encyclopedia with cheekbones."

She laughed.

"That might be the strangest advice you've ever given me."

"But did you understand it?"

"Unfortunately."

He also reminded her to enjoy the evening.

"You've spent years working toward opportunities like this. When you arrive, don't spend the whole night worrying about what happens next. Be there. Look around. Take it in."

That advice stayed with her.

The Red Carpet

On the evening of the ceremony, Cassandra stood before a mirror in her hotel suite.

Her gown was elegant and beautifully tailored, with a flowing silhouette that caught the light when she moved. Her hair framed her face, and her makeup brought out the confidence that had slowly grown through years of work.

She looked like a star.

Not because the dress was expensive or because a camera might capture her.

She looked like a star because the young woman who had once stood nervously outside an audition room had learned to trust the work she brought inside.

Her phone rang.

Rebecca appeared on the screen, dressed for the occasion despite being thousands of kilometres away.

"Cassandra, turn around."

"Why?"

"Turn around. I need to inspect the outfit."

Cassandra turned slowly.

Rebecca pressed a hand to her chest.

"Good heavens."

"Is it okay?"

"Okay? If confidence were a building, you would be the entire estate."

Cassandra laughed.

Rebecca's expression softened.

"You look beautiful. And I'm so proud of you."

"Thank you."

"Now go out there and remember that you belong. Not because you're nominated. Not because people are watching. Because you did the work."

Cassandra swallowed the sudden lump in her throat.

"I will."

After the call, she checked her bag.

Phone. Invitation. Makeup. Notes.

Charger.

She smiled at that last item.

Vikksy's influence had become a permanent part of her packing routine.

When Cassandra stepped onto the red carpet, cameras flashed around her.

Reporters called her name.

"Cassandra! Over here!"

"Cassandra, how does it feel to be nominated for Best Actress?"

"What's it like representing Nigeria on this stage?"

She paused, took a breath, and answered.

"It's an honour. I'm proud of the work we've done on *Beyond the Horizon*, and I'm grateful to everyone who helped bring Maya's story to life. I'm also proud to be here as a Nigerian actress. I hope this is one of many opportunities for audiences to see the stories we have to tell."

A reporter asked what her younger self would think if she could see her now.

Cassandra smiled.

"I think she would be shocked. Then she would ask whether the dress came with the nomination."

The reporters laughed.

"And after that?" another asked.

"After that, I hope she would be proud that we kept going."

The interview was brief, but the clip spread online.

Back home, Rebecca sent a voice note that began with a scream and ended with the declaration that Cassandra's younger self would definitely approve of the dress.

Vikksy sent a simpler message.

VIKKSY: *You look like you belong there. Because you do.*

Cassandra read it twice before putting her phone away.

Then she walked into the ceremony.

And the Winner Is...

The auditorium glittered with lights.

Actors, directors, writers, and filmmakers filled the tables. A large screen displayed the names of the nominees.

Cassandra sat beside members of the *Beyond the Horizon* team, her hands folded in her lap.

She had promised herself she would enjoy the evening regardless of the result.

She meant it.

Mostly.

When the award for Best Actress approached, the host stepped onto the stage.

"Ladies and gentlemen, our next award celebrates performances that remind us why stories matter. This year's nominees brought us courage, vulnerability, humour, heartbreak, and extraordinary humanity."

The screen displayed the nominees.

Cassandra's face appeared.

For one strange second, she saw herself as though she were watching somebody else's story.

The host opened the envelope.

"And the International Screen Award for Best Actress goes to..."

Cassandra stopped breathing.

"...Cassandra, for *Beyond the Horizon*!"

The room erupted.

For a moment, she did not move.

The actress beside her grabbed her hand.

"Cassandra! That's you!"

She stood.

The applause grew louder.

Cassandra walked toward the stage, aware of the lights, the cameras, and the fact that her legs had suddenly become unreliable employees.

She accepted the award with trembling hands.

It was heavier than she expected.

The host congratulated her, and Cassandra stepped to the microphone.

She looked out at the audience.

For a moment, she could not speak.

Then she smiled.

"Thank you."

Her voice shook slightly, and she took a breath.

"Thank you to the International Screen Awards, to the entire team behind *Beyond the Horizon*, to our director, Eleanor Brooks, and to every person who helped Maya's story become real."

She looked at the award.

"When I started acting, I didn't know exactly where the journey would lead. I knew I loved telling stories. I knew there were characters I wanted to bring to life. And I knew that sometimes I would be afraid, sometimes I would fail, and sometimes I would have to learn how to try again."

The room grew quiet.

"I'm standing here tonight because many people gave me opportunities, taught me, encouraged me, and trusted me with their stories. I'm grateful to every one of them."

She paused.

"I'm also proud to be a Nigerian actress. There are so many beautiful, complicated, funny, brave, and extraordinary stories from home that deserve to be told. I hope more of us get the opportunity to tell them to the world."

Applause rose around the room.

Cassandra's eyes shone.

"To my family, thank you for loving me through the busy days, the difficult days, and the days when I was so tired that I probably wasn't making much sense."

A ripple of laughter moved through the audience.

"To my children, Nelson and Kayla, this is for you. You have reminded me that love can make you brave in ways you never expected. I hope you grow up knowing that you can pursue your dreams and still make room for the people you love."

She took a breath.

"And to every person who is working toward something they cannot yet see clearly, please keep learning. Keep doing the work. Ask for help when you need it. Rest when you need it. A difficult beginning does not have to decide how your story ends."

Her voice softened.

"I used to think success would arrive one day and tell me I was finally good enough. I'm learning that the work matters long before anyone applauds. And the people who believe in you can help you remember that on the days when you forget."

She smiled through her tears.

"Thank you for making tonight a part of my story."

The applause rose again, filling the auditorium.

Cassandra stepped away from the microphone with the award held against her chest.

She had won.

Not a participation certificate. Not a polite mention. Not an encouraging email saying the team would keep her details on file.

She had won Best Actress at an international awards ceremony.

And she was still Cassandra.

The People Who Were There Before the Applause

After the ceremony, the *Beyond the Horizon* team surrounded her with hugs and congratulations.

Eleanor Brooks held her shoulders.

"You gave Maya a life that people could recognize. You should be proud."

"I am. I really am."

"You worked for this."

Cassandra thanked her, then found a quiet corner to call home.

The video connected.

Grandma appeared first, smiling so broadly that Cassandra began crying again.

"We saw it!" Grandma exclaimed. "We saw everything!"

Nelson squeezed into the frame.

"Mummy! You won!"

"I did, sweetheart!"

Kayla appeared wearing a homemade paper crown.

"I told you she was a princess!"

Cassandra laughed.

"You did tell me."

"Where is my crown?"

"Your crown?"

"The one you got from the award."

Cassandra held up the trophy.

"This is not a crown, my love."

Kayla studied it.

"It looks like one."

Nelson leaned toward the screen.

"Mummy, are you the best actress in the whole world now?"

Cassandra thought carefully before answering.

"Tonight, I was chosen for this award. And I'm very happy."

"But are you the best?"

She smiled.

"There are many wonderful actresses in the world, Nelson. I can celebrate what I've achieved without needing to be better than everybody else."

Nelson appeared to consider this.

"Okay. But you're still my best actress."

Cassandra's face crumpled into the kind of smile that only a child could produce.

"That is the award I wanted most."

After the call, she phoned Mama Izu and spoke with her siblings. There were prayers, congratulations, happy tears, and several questions about where the trophy would be kept.

Miracle wanted to know whether it was heavy.

Emmanuel wanted photographs.

Joshua asked whether the ceremony had served food.

Nuella simply told Cassandra she was proud of her.

The calls continued until Cassandra finally had to promise everyone a longer conversation the next day.

Then Rebecca called.

Her face appeared on the screen, and for once, she seemed temporarily short of words.

Cassandra raised an eyebrow.

"Rebecca? Are you all right?"

Rebecca blinked.

"I am processing."

"Should I call somebody?"

"Do not ruin my moment."

Cassandra burst out laughing.

Rebecca wiped her eyes.

"You did it, girl."

"We did a lot of work to get here."

"Yes, we did. But you stood in those audition rooms. You learned those scenes. You faced those cameras. You kept going when it was hard. I was cheering from the side, but you were the one doing the work."

Cassandra nodded.

"Thank you for reminding me who I am when I get carried away."

"Someone has to. Fame is a very expensive way to forget common sense."

"That sounds like something you read in a management textbook."

"It should be in every textbook."

Later, Vikksy called.

He didn't scream.

He didn't demand credit.

He didn't even begin with a joke.

He simply smiled at her through the screen.

"Congratulations, Cassandra."

She looked at him, her eyes still bright.

"Thank you, bestie."

"You know what makes me happiest about this?"

"What?"

"You've worked toward this for so long, and now you get to enjoy a moment that belongs to you. I hope you let yourself enjoy it properly."

She nodded.

"I will."

"Good. And when you bring that trophy home, keep it somewhere safe."

"Naturally."

"Somewhere Nelson can't use it as a football."

Cassandra laughed.

"Goodnight, Vikksy."

"Goodnight, award-winning bestie."

She was about to end the call when he added, "And Cassandra?"

"Yes?"

"I'm proud of you. Keep becoming the actress you want to be. One award is a beautiful achievement, but it doesn't have to be the final destination."

She smiled.

"I know."

"Excellent. Now sleep. You have been famous for several hours, and your body has not received the official memo that it is allowed to collapse."

She shook her head.

"You're still annoying."

"Consistency is the foundation of friendship."

The call ended.

Cassandra stood by the window, the award resting on the table beside her.

The city glittered beyond the glass.

She thought of the girl at PAU who had been nervous before her first audition. The young mother who had practised lines between responsibilities. The actress who had stood in front of directors, heard corrections, tried again, and slowly learned to trust herself.

She thought of the people who had supported her, and the children who had loved her before the world knew her name.

The award was beautiful.

The recognition was extraordinary.

But the thing that moved her most was knowing that she had not needed to become somebody else to reach this moment.

She had grown.

She had learned.

She had made mistakes, accepted help, and kept working.

And now, the world was listening.

Cassandra picked up her phone and opened the photograph she had taken of the award.

She sent it to her children, Rebecca, and Vikksy.

Then she opened her notebook and wrote:

Tonight, the world called me an award-winning actress.

She paused, smiling.

Tomorrow, I will get up and keep learning.

She closed the notebook.

Outside, the city continued to shine.

And somewhere beyond the lights, a little girl named Kayla was already planning the outfit she would wear when her mother came home.

The world had given Cassandra an award.

Her family was preparing to give her something even more important.

A hug.

Several hundred questions.

And, if Nelson had anything to do with it, a football match in which the trophy would be strictly forbidden from participating.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

FAME HAS A VERY BUSY CALENDAR

London welcomed Cassandra with cold weather, tall buildings, and the immediate suspicion that everyone had somewhere important to be.

She stood outside the hotel window, wrapped in a cardigan, watching the city move beneath a grey morning sky.

Her phone vibrated.

VIKKSY: *Good morning, international woman of mystery.*

CASSANDRA: *Good morning. It's freezing.*

VIKKSY: *That is London's way of asking whether you brought sense from Nigeria.*

CASSANDRA: *I brought a coat.*

VIKKSY: *Excellent. You may survive the first episode.*

Cassandra laughed and set the phone down.

She had come to London to film *Beyond the Horizon*, playing Maya, a Nigerian student who travelled abroad to pursue her dreams while wrestling with the fear that she might disappoint the people she loved.

The irony was not lost on Cassandra.

She had spent years wondering whether she could balance motherhood, university, and acting. Now she was thousands of kilometres from home, working on an international production with actors she had previously admired from a distance.

It was exciting.

It was terrifying.

And the hotel breakfast was so expensive that she briefly considered returning to Lagos and becoming a professional rice consultant.

But she had come to work.

And work she would.

The Set That Never Slept

The *Beyond the Horizon* set was a world of its own.

There were assistants carrying clipboards, technicians adjusting lights, costume designers discussing fabrics with the seriousness of international peace negotiations, and actors who could transform from ordinary people into heartbroken geniuses in less time than it took Cassandra to find her misplaced script.

Director Eleanor Brooks welcomed her warmly.

"Cassandra, we're happy to have you here. How are you settling in?"

"Very well, thank you. I'm still learning the city."

"Anything surprising so far?"

"The weather."

Eleanor laughed. "You'll get used to it."

"I'm Nigerian. We have sunshine that can make you question your life choices. This cold is a different kind of character development."

Eleanor grinned. "I think Maya would appreciate that line."

Their first week was demanding. Cassandra filmed scenes in which Maya argued with her parents over a video call, struggled to find her footing at a new university, and questioned whether chasing an opportunity abroad meant she was abandoning home.

Some scenes required tears. Others demanded restraint. One required Cassandra to deliver a long speech while walking through a crowded station without looking as though she was trying to remember a shopping list.

That last one was harder than it sounded.

During a rehearsal, Cassandra hurried through the speech, determined to get every word right.

Eleanor raised a hand.

"Let's stop there. You're giving me the information, but Maya is trying to convince herself she's making the right decision. She's not delivering a presentation. She's fighting to believe what she's saying."

Cassandra nodded.

"Let's try again," Eleanor said. "This time, don't worry about getting to the end of the speech. Think about the person Maya wishes she could call."

Cassandra thought of her children.

Nelson, who always wanted to know whether she had eaten.

Kayla, who believed every important woman should own at least one crown.

Mama Izu, who could offer advice, prayer, and a stern warning in the same breath.

And the people who had encouraged her when her biggest audience was a classroom full of students waiting for the lecturer to dismiss them.

Cassandra began again.

This time, the words came more slowly. Maya's confidence cracked in the right places. Her determination became something the audience could feel rather than merely hear.

When Cassandra finished, the set was quiet for a moment.

Eleanor smiled.

"That's her."

Cassandra exhaled.

For a young actress who had once been nervous about auditioning in front of a handful of people, hearing those two words from an international director felt enormous.

Still, she resisted the temptation to celebrate too early.

She had another scene in twenty minutes.

And the costume department was looking for her.

Apparently, even emotional breakthroughs had scheduling conflicts.

The Calendar Conspiracy

By the time filming ended, Cassandra's career had begun moving faster than she could comfortably process.

The Map of Tomorrow had received strong reviews at the international festival. Critics praised the film's emotional storytelling, and several mentioned Cassandra's performance as one of its quiet strengths.

Almost on Purpose was finding a wider audience through streaming distribution.

People who had never met Cassandra were beginning to recognize her face.

Her social media following grew. Interviews arrived. Invitations appeared. A fashion brand requested a meeting. An entertainment magazine wanted a profile. Another production company asked whether she would consider auditioning for an upcoming drama.

Her phone became a full-time employee that never applied for leave.

The problem was that Cassandra was still a student, still a mother, and still a human being who occasionally needed to sleep.

One evening, she sat at her hotel desk surrounded by scripts, interview notes, university materials, and a half-eaten packet of biscuits.

She opened her calendar.

Then she closed it.

Then she opened it again, as if the events might have rearranged themselves out of shame.

They had not.

She called Rebecca.

Rebecca answered from her hostel room at PAU, wearing a bonnet and looking prepared to negotiate a corporate merger.

"Talk to me, superstar."

"I think my calendar hates me."

"Your calendar doesn't hate you. Your calendar is a victim of poor management."

"Rebecca, I have filming, two interviews, a university assignment, a meeting with the production team, and a video call with the children. I also promised to read a script."

"And when did you plan to sleep?"

Cassandra considered the question.

"That's not currently in the schedule."

Rebecca stared at the screen.

"Girl. Even your phone needs time to charge. You are not a solar-powered actress."

"I know."

"No, you know the words. I need you to understand the concept."

Cassandra laughed, then rubbed her forehead.

Rebecca's expression softened.

"Listen. We can organize the calendar. But we also need to decide what actually matters. Not every invitation is an opportunity you must accept. Some are just people with your email address."

"That should be printed on a T-shirt."

"It should be printed on the national currency."

Together, they reorganized Cassandra's week. Rebecca helped her identify which invitations required immediate attention, which could wait, and which were not worth accepting at all.

They protected time for her university work and set aside regular calls with Nelson and Kayla.

Rebecca also insisted on a weekly check-in.

"Every Sunday," she declared. "You report your schedule, your stress level, and whether you've eaten something that didn't come in a packet."

"You're becoming my manager."

"No. Your manager gets paid."

"That was unnecessary."

"It was also accurate."

Later that night, Cassandra called Vikksy.

He listened while she described the growing attention, the long days, and the strange pressure to be grateful for every opportunity even when she was exhausted.

When she finished, he was quiet for a moment.

Then he said, "Cassandra, being grateful for an opportunity doesn't mean you must accept every opportunity."

She leaned back in her chair.

"Rebecca said something similar."

"Rebecca is wise. Occasionally, she is even tolerable."

"She says the same thing about you."

"That's how we know the friendship is genuine. We insult each other with consistency."

Cassandra smiled.

Vikksy's voice became more serious.

"You worked hard to get here. Don't let the excitement make you forget that you still have limits. Rest isn't a reward for finishing everything. If you wait until everything is finished, you'll never rest."

She looked at the open calendar.

"I don't want to disappoint anyone."

"You can't make everybody happy, and you shouldn't build your life around trying. Do your work properly. Keep your promises where you can. Be honest when you can't. The people who genuinely respect you will understand that you're a person, not a public utility."

Cassandra laughed softly.

"A public utility?"

"Yes. Available twenty-four hours a day, occasionally interrupted by poor network, and blamed whenever anything goes wrong."

"You're impossible."

"But am I incorrect?"

She shook her head, smiling.

"No."

"Then my work here is complete."

It wasn't the first time Vikksy had reminded her of something she already knew. Sometimes, though, a familiar truth became easier to follow when someone who cared about you said it plainly.

Before they ended the call, he asked about her next scene, listened to her concerns, and helped her think through the emotional transition she was struggling with.

He didn't pretend to be an expert in everything. He simply asked good questions and encouraged her to trust the preparation she had done.

That was one of the things Cassandra valued most about him.

He could make her laugh when she needed a laugh, challenge her when she needed a challenge, and leave the jokes alone when the moment called for honesty.

Their friendship had survived changes in their lives because it was built on something deeper than what either person could gain from the other.

He wanted her to succeed.

She wanted the same for him.

There was no competition in it.

Only friendship, respect, and the occasional argument about who was more annoying.

Vikksy maintained that Rebecca was the winner.

Rebecca maintained that Vikksy was a public menace.

Both arguments had considerable evidence.

Home Is a Video Call Away

On Sunday evening, Cassandra sat on her hotel bed and called home.

Nelson appeared first, holding the phone too close to his face.

"Mummy!"

"Hello, my love!"

"Have you finished the movie?"

"Not yet. We're still filming."

"How many more days?"

Cassandra smiled.

"Some more days, sweetheart."

Nelson thought about that.

"Okay. But when you finish, are you coming home?"

"Yes. I'll come home."

"Promise?"

"I promise."

Kayla pushed into the frame wearing a pink headband.

"Mummy, did you see my drawing?"

"I haven't seen it today."

Grandma appeared in the background and held up a picture. It showed Cassandra wearing a crown, with two smaller figures standing beside her. Above them, Kayla had written a collection of letters that appeared to mean *MUMMY QUEEN*.

"It's beautiful," Cassandra said.

"I made you a queen because you're acting."

"That is very thoughtful."

"Can you bring me a queen dress from London?"

Cassandra laughed.

"We'll discuss the royal budget."

Nelson immediately joined the negotiations.

"And football boots."

"Of course," Cassandra said. "One royal dress and one pair of football boots."

"And sweets," Kayla added.

"Your Majesty, the treasury is under pressure."

Grandma laughed behind the camera.

For the next several minutes, Cassandra forgot about interviews, reviews, schedules, and the fact that strangers were beginning to recognize her.

She was simply their mother.

She listened to Nelson explain a school activity, admired Kayla's drawing, and asked Grandma how everyone was doing.

After the call, she sat quietly for a moment.

She missed them.

There was no clever way around that truth.

She was proud of the life she was building, but missing her children did not mean she had made the wrong decision. It meant she loved them.

She opened her notebook and wrote a sentence beneath her schedule:

Success must make room for the people I love.

Then she underlined it.

Twice.

The Interview That Went Everywhere

A few days later, Cassandra sat for an interview with an international entertainment magazine.

The interviewer asked about her journey from a university student in Lagos to an actress working on an international production.

"What has surprised you most about this experience?" the interviewer asked.

Cassandra thought for a moment.

"How much of acting happens before you enter the scene. People see the finished performance, but they don't see the preparation, the mistakes, the conversations with the director, or the days when you have to try something five different ways before it feels right."

"And has fame changed you?"

Cassandra smiled.

"I think it has made me more aware of how much I still have to learn. People can recognize your face before they know anything about you. That's a strange feeling. But I don't want to spend my life trying to become a person strangers approve of. I want to become a better actress and a better person."

The interviewer nodded.

"You speak often about your family. How do you balance that with your career?"

"I'm still learning. I don't think balance means giving every part of your life the same amount of time every day. Sometimes work needs more attention. Sometimes family does. The important thing is not to let a busy season convince you that the people you love can wait forever."

The interview was published two days later.

The response was immediate.

Readers praised her honesty. Young actors shared her answers. One comment read:

She sounds like someone who knows what she wants without pretending she has everything figured out.

Cassandra saved that one.

Not because it called her inspiring, but because it understood her.

That evening, Rebecca sent a screenshot.

REBECCA: *Your interview is trending.*

CASSANDRA: *What does that mean?*

REBECCA: *It means people are talking about you.*

CASSANDRA: *Are they saying nice things?*

REBECCA: *Mostly.*

CASSANDRA: *Mostly?*

REBECCA: *Congratulations. You have officially entered the stage of fame where somebody dislikes your existence because you wore a blue dress.*

Vikksy joined the conversation.

VIKKSY: *This is a major milestone. Next, somebody will criticize the way you breathe in interviews.*

CASSANDRA: *You two are not helping.*

REBECCA: *We are preparing you for the industry.*

VIKKSY: *Consider us your emotional support troublemakers.*

Cassandra put her phone down, laughing.

Then she picked it up again because another message had arrived.

This one was from Eleanor Brooks.

The director wanted to speak with her about the final scenes of *Beyond the Horizon*. There was also talk of submitting the film to several major festivals after post-production.

Nothing was guaranteed.

There were still scenes to film, edits to make, and months of work ahead.

But Cassandra had learned not to confuse uncertainty with failure.

She had once hoped simply to be chosen for a role.

Now she was learning how to carry the responsibility that came with being chosen.

She looked at the London skyline through the hotel window.

Somewhere in Lagos, her children were preparing for bed. Somewhere at PAU, Rebecca was probably planning three people's futures without their permission. Somewhere, Vikksy was almost certainly preparing a joke at her expense.

And here she was, thousands of kilometres from where her journey had begun, doing the work she had dreamed of doing.

She wasn't at the top yet.

But she was no longer standing at the bottom, wondering whether the climb was possible.

She was climbing.

And the next step was waiting.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

THE NIGHT SHE BECAME A LEGEND

The invitation arrived on a Tuesday afternoon.

Cassandra was in Lagos, back from filming *Beyond the Horizon*, sitting at the dining table while Nelson attempted to explain the rules of a game he had invented and Kayla decorated the corner of a notebook with stars.

Her phone rang.

The number was unfamiliar.

She answered.

"Hello, Cassandra speaking."

"Good afternoon, Cassandra. My name is Olivia Grant. I'm calling from the International Screen Awards."

Cassandra straightened in her chair.

"Good afternoon."

"I'm pleased to tell you that *Beyond the Horizon* has been selected for our annual awards programme. The nominations have just been announced, and your performance as Maya has received a nomination for Best Actress."

For a moment, Cassandra forgot how to respond.

She had heard the words.

She understood the words.

Her mind simply refused to arrange them into something believable.

"I'm sorry," she said at last. "Could you repeat that?"

Olivia kindly did.

Cassandra covered her mouth.

"Thank you. Thank you so much."

"Congratulations. We look forward to seeing you at the ceremony."

When the call ended, she remained still.

Nelson looked up from the floor.

"Mummy?"

She turned toward him, her eyes shining.

"I've been nominated for an acting award."

He blinked.

"Does that mean you won?"

"Not yet, sweetheart. It means they think I might."

Nelson considered this with the seriousness of a six-year-old evaluating a business proposal.

"Then you should win."

Kayla abandoned her notebook.

"Is it a princess award?"

Cassandra laughed through her tears.

"It's an acting award."

"Can princesses get it?"

"Some princesses probably can."

"Then you should win," Kayla declared, as though the matter had been settled by royal decree.

Grandma entered the room and immediately noticed Cassandra's expression.

"What happened?"

Cassandra told her.

Grandma's hands flew to her mouth.

"God has been good to you."

She embraced Cassandra, who held her tightly.

The children joined the hug, although neither seemed entirely certain why everyone was emotional.

Nelson eventually asked whether award ceremonies served food.

Kayla wanted to know whether the award came with a crown.

Cassandra decided that both were reasonable questions.

Then she called Mama Izu.

Then her siblings.

Then Rebecca.

Rebecca answered with her usual greeting.

"Girl, what happened? Why are you calling in the middle of the day? Is somebody in trouble?"

"I've been nominated for Best Actress."

Silence.

Cassandra checked the screen to make sure the call hadn't disconnected.

"Rebecca?"

A scream exploded through the speaker.

Cassandra pulled the phone away from her ear.

"REBECCA!"

"BEST ACTRESS? INTERNATIONAL AWARD? CASSANDRA, ARE YOU TRYING TO MAKE ME COLLAPSE IN THIS HOSTEL?"

"I'm sorry!"

"No, you're not! You're sitting there with your calm voice while I'm experiencing a personal earthquake!"

Cassandra laughed so hard that Nelson asked her to explain the joke.

Rebecca was already talking.

"Listen. We are celebrating. We are celebrating properly. I'm going to organize everything."

"Rebecca, the ceremony is abroad."

"I heard you. I studied Business Administration. Distance is a logistical problem, not a spiritual limitation."

"How exactly are you going to organize a celebration across continents?"

"First, I will develop a strategy. Second, I will develop a better strategy. Third, I will call Vikksy because he knows how to make technology behave."

"Technology doesn't behave," Cassandra said.

"Then he can threaten it until it cooperates."

Rebecca hung up only after extracting the ceremony date, the travel details, and a promise that Cassandra would send her a photograph of the invitation.

Next came Vikksy.

He answered on the second ring.

"Why does your voice sound like someone has given you good news and you're trying not to disturb the neighbours?"

Cassandra told him.

There was a pause.

Then he said, quietly, "Cassandra. That's huge."

She smiled.

"It is."

"I'm genuinely proud of you. Not just because you've been nominated, but because I know how much work you've put into this. The practice, the rejection, the studying, the days you had to keep going when nobody could promise you anything. You earned the right to be in that room."

Her eyes filled again.

"Thank you."

"Now, having delivered this excellent emotional speech, I must address the practical issue."

She laughed.

"What issue?"

"If you win, I expect a formal acknowledgement of my contributions as unofficial acting adviser, emergency motivational speaker, and part-time technology consultant."

"You helped me prepare for auditions."

"Exactly. My services are clearly extensive."

"Rebecca helped me prepare too."

"Rebecca will receive an award for strategic planning and shouting."

"She's going to love that."

"Good. Also, do not forget your charger."

Cassandra burst out laughing.

"Vikksy!"

"What? History has shown that important events and low battery percentages have an unhealthy relationship."

She shook her head.

"Thank you for being there for me."

"Always, bestie. Go do your thing."

There was no grand declaration, no complicated promise, no attempt to make her achievement about him.

Just a friend, proud of someone he cared about, telling her to keep going.

It was exactly what she needed.

Preparing for the Biggest Night of Her Life

The International Screen Awards ceremony was held several months later, after *Beyond the Horizon* completed its festival run and gained a wider international release.

The nomination itself had brought new attention to Cassandra. The film had been praised for its thoughtful writing, and her portrayal of Maya had become one of the performances critics discussed most.

But the weeks before the ceremony were not a magical montage of effortless success.

Cassandra still had to finish university assignments. She still had responsibilities at home. She still needed to prepare for interviews and review the speech she had written in case she won.

And she still had moments when she looked at the nomination announcement and wondered whether somebody had accidentally selected the wrong name.

During one video call, Rebecca caught her staring at the screen.

"Stop looking at that nomination like it owes you money."

"I'm just thinking."

"You're overthinking. There is a difference."

"What if I lose?"

"Then you will still be the same actress who earned the nomination."

Cassandra looked down.

Rebecca continued.

"Listen to me. Winning would be wonderful. But the nomination already means your work reached people who took it seriously. Don't turn the possibility of losing into a reason to be afraid of winning."

Cassandra nodded.

"You're right."

"I know. It's one of my most exhausting qualities."

"Your humility?"

"My intelligence."

"Naturally."

Rebecca leaned closer to the camera.

"And wear something beautiful. If you are going to make history, please do not dress like you are attending a compulsory departmental meeting."

"I'll keep that in mind."

Vikksy helped her prepare for the interviews.

He advised her to remember the people who had contributed to her journey, answer questions honestly, and avoid feeling pressured to tell the same rehearsed story every time.

"You're allowed to be nervous," he told her. "Just don't let the nerves answer the questions for you."

"What if they ask me something I don't know?"

"Then say you don't know. You are an actress, Cassandra, not an encyclopedia with cheekbones."

She laughed.

"That might be the strangest advice you've ever given me."

"But did you understand it?"

"Unfortunately."

He also reminded her to enjoy the evening.

"You've spent years working toward opportunities like this. When you arrive, don't spend the whole night worrying about what happens next. Be there. Look around. Take it in."

That advice stayed with her.

The Red Carpet

On the evening of the ceremony, Cassandra stood before a mirror in her hotel suite.

Her gown was elegant and beautifully tailored, with a flowing silhouette that caught the light when she moved. Her hair framed her face, and her makeup brought out the confidence that had slowly grown through years of work.

She looked like a star.

Not because the dress was expensive or because a camera might capture her.

She looked like a star because the young woman who had once stood nervously outside an audition room had learned to trust the work she brought inside.

Her phone rang.

Rebecca appeared on the screen, dressed for the occasion despite being thousands of kilometres away.

"Cassandra, turn around."

"Why?"

"Turn around. I need to inspect the outfit."

Cassandra turned slowly.

Rebecca pressed a hand to her chest.

"Good heavens."

"Is it okay?"

"Okay? If confidence were a building, you would be the entire estate."

Cassandra laughed.

Rebecca's expression softened.

"You look beautiful. And I'm so proud of you."

"Thank you."

"Now go out there and remember that you belong. Not because you're nominated. Not because people are watching. Because you did the work."

Cassandra swallowed the sudden lump in her throat.

"I will."

After the call, she checked her bag.

Phone. Invitation. Makeup. Notes.

Charger.

She smiled at that last item.

Vikksy's influence had become a permanent part of her packing routine.

When Cassandra stepped onto the red carpet, cameras flashed around her.

Reporters called her name.

"Cassandra! Over here!"

"Cassandra, how does it feel to be nominated for Best Actress?"

"What's it like representing Nigeria on this stage?"

She paused, took a breath, and answered.

"It's an honour. I'm proud of the work we've done on *Beyond the Horizon*, and I'm grateful to everyone who helped bring Maya's story to life. I'm also proud to be here as a Nigerian actress. I hope this is one of many opportunities for audiences to see the stories we have to tell."

A reporter asked what her younger self would think if she could see her now.

Cassandra smiled.

"I think she would be shocked. Then she would ask whether the dress came with the nomination."

The reporters laughed.

"And after that?" another asked.

"After that, I hope she would be proud that we kept going."

The interview was brief, but the clip spread online.

Back home, Rebecca sent a voice note that began with a scream and ended with the declaration that Cassandra's younger self would definitely approve of the dress.

Vikksy sent a simpler message.

VIKKSY: *You look like you belong there. Because you do.*

Cassandra read it twice before putting her phone away.

Then she walked into the ceremony.

And the Winner Is...

The auditorium glittered with lights.

Actors, directors, writers, and filmmakers filled the tables. A large screen displayed the names of the nominees.

Cassandra sat beside members of the *Beyond the Horizon* team, her hands folded in her lap.

She had promised herself she would enjoy the evening regardless of the result.

She meant it.

Mostly.

When the award for Best Actress approached, the host stepped onto the stage.

"Ladies and gentlemen, our next award celebrates performances that remind us why stories matter. This year's nominees brought us courage, vulnerability, humour, heartbreak, and extraordinary humanity."

The screen displayed the nominees.

Cassandra's face appeared.

For one strange second, she saw herself as though she were watching somebody else's story.

The host opened the envelope.

"And the International Screen Award for Best Actress goes to..."

Cassandra stopped breathing.

"...Cassandra, for *Beyond the Horizon*!"

The room erupted.

For a moment, she did not move.

The actress beside her grabbed her hand.

"Cassandra! That's you!"

She stood.

The applause grew louder.

Cassandra walked toward the stage, aware of the lights, the cameras, and the fact that her legs had suddenly become unreliable employees.

She accepted the award with trembling hands.

It was heavier than she expected.

The host congratulated her, and Cassandra stepped to the microphone.

She looked out at the audience.

For a moment, she could not speak.

Then she smiled.

"Thank you."

Her voice shook slightly, and she took a breath.

"Thank you to the International Screen Awards, to the entire team behind *Beyond the Horizon*, to our director, Eleanor Brooks, and to every person who helped Maya's story become real."

She looked at the award.

"When I started acting, I didn't know exactly where the journey would lead. I knew I loved telling stories. I knew there were characters I wanted to bring to life. And I knew that sometimes I would be afraid, sometimes I would fail, and sometimes I would have to learn how to try again."

The room grew quiet.

"I'm standing here tonight because many people gave me opportunities, taught me, encouraged me, and trusted me with their stories. I'm grateful to every one of them."

She paused.

"I'm also proud to be a Nigerian actress. There are so many beautiful, complicated, funny, brave, and extraordinary stories from home that deserve to be told. I hope more of us get the opportunity to tell them to the world."

Applause rose around the room.

Cassandra's eyes shone.

"To my family, thank you for loving me through the busy days, the difficult days, and the days when I was so tired that I probably wasn't making much sense."

A ripple of laughter moved through the audience.

"To my children, Nelson and Kayla, this is for you. You have reminded me that love can make you brave in ways you never expected. I hope you grow up knowing that you can pursue your dreams and still make room for the people you love."

She took a breath.

"And to every person who is working toward something they cannot yet see clearly, please keep learning. Keep doing the work. Ask for help when you need it. Rest when you need it. A difficult beginning does not have to decide how your story ends."

Her voice softened.

"I used to think success would arrive one day and tell me I was finally good enough. I'm learning that the work matters long before anyone applauds. And the people who believe in you can help you remember that on the days when you forget."

She smiled through her tears.

"Thank you for making tonight a part of my story."

The applause rose again, filling the auditorium.

Cassandra stepped away from the microphone with the award held against her chest.

She had won.

Not a participation certificate. Not a polite mention. Not an encouraging email saying the team would keep her details on file.

She had won Best Actress at an international awards ceremony.

And she was still Cassandra.

The People Who Were There Before the Applause

After the ceremony, the *Beyond the Horizon* team surrounded her with hugs and congratulations.

Eleanor Brooks held her shoulders.

"You gave Maya a life that people could recognize. You should be proud."

"I am. I really am."

"You worked for this."

Cassandra thanked her, then found a quiet corner to call home.

The video connected.

Grandma appeared first, smiling so broadly that Cassandra began crying again.

"We saw it!" Grandma exclaimed. "We saw everything!"

Nelson squeezed into the frame.

"Mummy! You won!"

"I did, sweetheart!"

Kayla appeared wearing a homemade paper crown.

"I told you she was a princess!"

Cassandra laughed.

"You did tell me."

"Where is my crown?"

"Your crown?"

"The one you got from the award."

Cassandra held up the trophy.

"This is not a crown, my love."

Kayla studied it.

"It looks like one."

Nelson leaned toward the screen.

"Mummy, are you the best actress in the whole world now?"

Cassandra thought carefully before answering.

"Tonight, I was chosen for this award. And I'm very happy."

"But are you the best?"

She smiled.

"There are many wonderful actresses in the world, Nelson. I can celebrate what I've achieved without needing to be better than everybody else."

Nelson appeared to consider this.

"Okay. But you're still my best actress."

Cassandra's face crumpled into the kind of smile that only a child could produce.

"That is the award I wanted most."

After the call, she phoned Mama Izu and spoke with her siblings. There were prayers, congratulations, happy tears, and several questions about where the trophy would be kept.

Miracle wanted to know whether it was heavy.

Emmanuel wanted photographs.

Joshua asked whether the ceremony had served food.

Nuella simply told Cassandra she was proud of her.

The calls continued until Cassandra finally had to promise everyone a longer conversation the next day.

Then Rebecca called.

Her face appeared on the screen, and for once, she seemed temporarily short of words.

Cassandra raised an eyebrow.

"Rebecca? Are you all right?"

Rebecca blinked.

"I am processing."

"Should I call somebody?"

"Do not ruin my moment."

Cassandra burst out laughing.

Rebecca wiped her eyes.

"You did it, girl."

"We did a lot of work to get here."

"Yes, we did. But you stood in those audition rooms. You learned those scenes. You faced those cameras. You kept going when it was hard. I was cheering from the side, but you were the one doing the work."

Cassandra nodded.

"Thank you for reminding me who I am when I get carried away."

"Someone has to. Fame is a very expensive way to forget common sense."

"That sounds like something you read in a management textbook."

"It should be in every textbook."

Later, Vikksy called.

He didn't scream.

He didn't demand credit.

He didn't even begin with a joke.

He simply smiled at her through the screen.

"Congratulations, Cassandra."

She looked at him, her eyes still bright.

"Thank you, bestie."

"You know what makes me happiest about this?"

"What?"

"You've worked toward this for so long, and now you get to enjoy a moment that belongs to you. I hope you let yourself enjoy it properly."

She nodded.

"I will."

"Good. And when you bring that trophy home, keep it somewhere safe."

"Naturally."

"Somewhere Nelson can't use it as a football."

Cassandra laughed.

"Goodnight, Vikksy."

"Goodnight, award-winning bestie."

She was about to end the call when he added, "And Cassandra?"

"Yes?"

"I'm proud of you. Keep becoming the actress you want to be. One award is a beautiful achievement, but it doesn't have to be the final destination."

She smiled.

"I know."

"Excellent. Now sleep. You have been famous for several hours, and your body has not received the official memo that it is allowed to collapse."

She shook her head.

"You're still annoying."

"Consistency is the foundation of friendship."

The call ended.

Cassandra stood by the window, the award resting on the table beside her.

The city glittered beyond the glass.

She thought of the girl at PAU who had been nervous before her first audition. The young mother who had practised lines between responsibilities. The actress who had stood in front of directors, heard corrections, tried again, and slowly learned to trust herself.

She thought of the people who had supported her, and the children who had loved her before the world knew her name.

The award was beautiful.

The recognition was extraordinary.

But the thing that moved her most was knowing that she had not needed to become somebody else to reach this moment.

She had grown.

She had learned.

She had made mistakes, accepted help, and kept working.

And now, the world was listening.

Cassandra picked up her phone and opened the photograph she had taken of the award.

She sent it to her children, Rebecca, and Vikksy.

Then she opened her notebook and wrote:

Tonight, the world called me an award-winning actress.

She paused, smiling.

Tomorrow, I will get up and keep learning.

She closed the notebook.

Outside, the city continued to shine.

And somewhere beyond the lights, a little girl named Kayla was already planning the outfit she would wear when her mother came home.

The world had given Cassandra an award.

Her family was preparing to give her something even more important.

A hug.

Several hundred questions.

And, if Nelson had anything to do with it, a football match in which the trophy would be strictly forbidden from participating.

CHAPTER NINETEEN

MORE THAN A SUPERSTAR

The first thing Cassandra did when she returned to Lagos was kneel down.

Not because she had won an international award.

Not because she had finally come home after months of filming.

Not because she had discovered that Lagos traffic could humble a woman who had just conquered an international stage.

She knelt because two small people were running toward her at a speed that suggested the airport had become an Olympic venue.

"MUMMY!"

Nelson reached her first. Kayla arrived a second later, crashing into the hug with all the force her little body could produce.

Cassandra wrapped both arms around them.

"My babies!"

Nelson squeezed her so tightly that she laughed.

"You're back!"

"I'm back, sweetheart."

"You're not travelling tomorrow?"

"No, I'm not travelling tomorrow."

"What about the next day?"

Cassandra pulled back to look at him.

"Nelson, have you been appointed the Minister of Travel?"

He nodded seriously.

"Yes."

Kayla lifted her head.

"I'm the minister of dresses."

"Naturally," Cassandra said. "The government is now complete."

Grandma stood nearby, smiling as she watched them.

Cassandra rose and embraced her.

"Thank you for everything."

Grandma held her face between her hands.

"You don't have to thank me for loving my grandchildren. I only pray that you continue to grow, and that you remember to look after yourself too."

Cassandra nodded.

"I will."

She hoped she would.

Because if the last few months had taught her anything, it was that ambition could fill a calendar very quickly, but love was what made the effort worthwhile.

The Trophy Has Arrived

At home, Nelson insisted that the award be placed on the sitting-room table.

Kayla disagreed.

"It should be in my room."

"Why?" Nelson asked.

"Because I'm the princess."

"I'm the older one."

"That doesn't make you a princess."

Nelson turned to Cassandra.

"Mummy, who should keep it?"

Cassandra considered the situation with the seriousness of a judge hearing a historic dispute.

"The award belongs to me."

Both children looked disappointed.

"But," she continued, "you can both help me choose a special place for it."

They agreed to this arrangement, although Kayla remained convinced that the trophy would look excellent beside her dolls.

Later, Cassandra sat on the floor with them, listening to Nelson recount a football match and watching Kayla demonstrate a dance she had apparently been practising for several weeks.

She had missed these ordinary moments.

The stories that wandered away from their original point.

The sudden questions.

The arguments over who had received the larger piece of chicken.

The way Kayla could turn almost any object into a royal accessory.

For months, Cassandra had spent her days moving between film sets, interviews, and professional meetings. She had loved the work. She was proud of what she had accomplished.

But sitting on the floor with her children, she felt a kind of happiness that no red carpet could reproduce.

She did not need to choose between being proud of her career and being grateful for her family.

Both belonged to her.

Both mattered.

And she wanted the children to grow up knowing that their dreams could be important without making the people they loved less important.

That evening, after the children had gone to bed, Cassandra sat beside Grandma.

"Sometimes I worry that I'll miss too much," she admitted. "There will be more films, more travel, more opportunities. I want to take them, but I don't want the children to feel that I'm always somewhere else."

Grandma took her hand.

"Then keep talking to them. Keep showing up when you can. When you must travel, explain it to them. Let them know they are loved, even when you are far away."

Cassandra listened quietly.

"You don't have to be everywhere at once," Grandma continued. "You only have to keep making room for the things that matter."

Cassandra rested her head against Grandma's shoulder.

For once, she did not try to turn the advice into a schedule.

She simply received it.

A Meeting of Very Important People

A week after Cassandra returned, Rebecca announced that she was organizing a celebration.

Her announcement arrived in the group chat with the confidence of a government press release.

REBECCA: *Saturday. Everyone is coming.*

SARAH: *Coming where?*

REBECCA: *To celebrate our superstar.*

JOHN: *Do we need to bring anything?*

REBECCA: *Your presence.*

ABIODUN: *What about money?*

REBECCA: *Your presence will be accepted in place of money, provided your presence is not accompanied by excessive consumption.*

VIKKSY: *This is a celebration, not a tax audit.*

REBECCA: *And yet, you are already questioning the budget.*

VIKKSY: *Because I know you.*

REBECCA: *And yet you remain in my life. Interesting.*

Cassandra read the conversation while laughing.

When Saturday arrived, she discovered that Rebecca had arranged a small gathering with Sarah, John, Abiodun, Vikksy, and several members of her family.

There was food, music, a cake, and a display of photographs documenting Cassandra's journey from her early days at PAU to her award-winning performance.

Rebecca had even printed a few screenshots of old messages.

Cassandra stared at one of them.

"Rebecca. Why is this here?"

"Historical documentation."

"This is a message where I said I was afraid I'd embarrass myself at an audition."

"Exactly. We are demonstrating character development."

Vikksy leaned over to inspect the display.

"That one should be enlarged and framed."

Cassandra pointed at him.

"You are not helping."

"I'm helping history."

John examined a photograph of Cassandra at the premiere of *Almost on Purpose*.

"Look at this. We were there before the international recognition."

Abiodun nodded.

"We knew her when she was still attending lectures and borrowing people's notes."

Sarah laughed.

"And arriving late."

Cassandra placed a hand on her chest.

"I have changed."

Rebecca looked at her.

"You arrived late to this celebration."

The room erupted.

Cassandra stared at her friend.

"I was delayed."

"By what?"

"Traffic."

Vikksy nodded solemnly.

"A classic antagonist in every Lagos story."

"Thank you, Vikksy."

"You're welcome. I am available for narration."

Rebecca clapped her hands.

"Everyone, please sit down. I have prepared a few words."

Vikksy leaned toward Cassandra.

"This is how we know the celebration is serious. Rebecca has prepared remarks."

Rebecca heard him.

"I can also prepare your eviction from this gathering."

"See? Leadership. Vision. Execution."

She ignored him and stood in front of the group.

For once, her voice was gentle.

"When Cassandra first told me she wanted to take acting seriously, she had so many responsibilities already. She was studying, raising her children, and trying to build a future in a field where nobody could promise her anything."

Cassandra lowered her eyes, listening.

"I've watched her work. I've watched her worry. I've watched her keep going. And I've watched her become more confident, not because she stopped being afraid, but because she stopped letting fear make all her decisions."

Rebecca smiled at her.

"I'm proud of the actress you've become. But I'm even prouder of the friend, mother, and woman you continue to be. Your award is wonderful. Your success is wonderful. But neither one is the reason we love you."

The room grew quiet.

Rebecca's eyes shone.

"We loved you before the cameras knew your name. We will love you when the cameras move on to somebody else. So please enjoy everything you've earned, Cassandra. Let yourself be celebrated. You've worked hard for this."

Cassandra stood and embraced her.

"Thank you."

Rebecca held her for a moment before pulling away.

"You're welcome. Now sit down before I become emotional in public."

Vikksy raised his hand.

"Too late."

Rebecca threw a cushion at him.

The celebration returned to laughter.

Later, when everyone had eaten, Cassandra thanked them one by one.

Sarah and John reminded her of the classmates who had encouraged her from the beginning. Abiodun reenacted the disastrous classroom improvisation that had first made everyone laugh. Rebecca told the story of the time Cassandra had practised an audition scene so intensely that she had forgotten her food was burning.

Cassandra protested every detail.

Nobody believed her.

Then Vikksy stood.

"I would like to say something."

Rebecca immediately looked suspicious.

"Is it a joke?"

"It may contain one."

"Proceed carefully."

Vikksy turned to Cassandra.

"When you started this journey, you had talent, but talent alone doesn't carry a person through every difficult day. You learned to prepare. You learned to listen to criticism without treating it as an attack. You learned that rejection isn't always a verdict on your ability. Sometimes it's simply one opportunity that wasn't yours."

Cassandra listened, moved.

"And you kept going. That part matters most."

He smiled.

"I'm proud of you, bestie. Not because the world has recognized you, but because you've continued becoming the person you wanted to be. I hope you remember that the next time a project doesn't work out, or a review is unfair, or someone on the internet decides your face has personally offended them."

The room laughed.

"Thank you for letting your friends celebrate you," he continued. "And thank you for being the kind of person who celebrates other people too. Keep doing that. Fame is temporary, but the way you treat people can stay with them for a long time."

Cassandra wiped her eyes.

Then Vikksy raised his glass.

"To Cassandra. Award-winning actress, devoted mother, loyal friend, and a woman who has officially made all of us look underachieving."

The room burst into laughter.

"Vikksy!" Cassandra exclaimed.

"What? I am celebrating your achievements honestly."

Rebecca raised her glass.

"To Cassandra!"

Everyone joined in.

"To Cassandra!"

For the rest of the evening, they talked, laughed, ate, and took photographs. Nelson attempted to pose beside the trophy like a professional footballer signing a major contract. Kayla insisted that the photograph should include her crown.

Cassandra let them.

She wanted to remember this day.

Not as the day she had been surrounded by people who were impressed by her fame, but as the day she had been surrounded by people who were happy simply because she was happy.

The Next Dream

Several weeks later, Cassandra returned to PAU.

Walking across campus felt different now.

Some students recognized her from *The Map of Tomorrow*. Others had watched *Beyond the Horizon*. A few approached her to ask about acting, auditions, and how to begin building a career.

She answered as honestly as she could.

She told them to learn their craft, practise regularly, seek feedback, and treat people professionally. She explained that opportunities mattered, but preparation helped you make the most of them.

One student asked, "Do you think someone like me can actually make it?"

Cassandra recognized the question.

She had asked herself the same thing many times.

"I can't promise you that a particular outcome will happen," she said. "But I can tell you that your dream deserves a serious attempt. Learn what you need to learn. Start with what you have. Keep improving. Don't reject yourself before anyone else has even had the chance to consider you."

The student smiled.

"Thank you."

As Cassandra walked away, she realized that she wanted to do more than build her own career.

She wanted to help create opportunities for others.

She began discussing an idea with Amara Okafor and several colleagues: a small mentorship programme for young African actors who lacked access to professional guidance.

It would offer workshops, audition practice, script analysis, and opportunities to learn from experienced performers.

It was only an idea at first.

There would be funding questions, schedules, and a long list of practical details.

Rebecca volunteered to review the business plan.

Vikksy volunteered to help organize the digital side.

Then he sent Cassandra a message.

VIKKSY: *I have reviewed the proposed programme.*

CASSANDRA: *And?*

VIKKSY: *It is ambitious, meaningful, and potentially excellent.*

CASSANDRA: *Thank you!*

VIKKSY: *It also requires a budget.*

CASSANDRA: *Rebecca is handling that.*

VIKKSY: *Then I am confident the budget will be handled with frightening efficiency.*

REBECCA: *I can see this chat, Vikksy.*

VIKKSY: *Good. Transparency is important in leadership.*

Cassandra laughed.

Her life was still busy. She would have more auditions, more roles, more mistakes, and more lessons to learn.

She would sometimes succeed and sometimes struggle.

She would continue being a mother, a daughter, a friend, a student, and an actress.

And she would keep making room for the person she wanted to become.

One afternoon, after a meeting about the mentorship programme, Cassandra stood alone outside the building where she had once attended her first acting lecture.

She remembered the girl who had entered the room nervous, hopeful, and unsure whether her dream was practical.

She wished she could tell that girl everything.

She wished she could explain that the road would take unexpected turns, that some doors would close, that others would open, and that the people she loved would become part of the story in ways she could not yet imagine.

Most of all, she wished she could tell her something she had only recently learned.

You do not have to wait until you become extraordinary to deserve a beautiful life.

You do not have to win an award to be worth celebrating.

You do not have to become famous to prove that your dreams matter.

The girl who had walked into that first lecture had already been worthy of encouragement.

The woman who stood there now was simply beginning to understand it.

Cassandra smiled, adjusted her bag, and headed toward her next class.

There were still things to learn.

There always would be.

And that, she had discovered, was not a reason to be afraid.

It was a reason to keep going.

CHAPTER TWENTY

CASSANDRA, THE STAR WHO WAS ALWAYS ENOUGH

A Little Something for the Superstar

The evening began with an ordinary message.

VIKKSY: *Bestie, I need you to do something for me.*

Cassandra was sitting at home, reviewing a script while Kayla coloured at the table and Nelson tried to convince Grandma that he required a second dinner.

CASSANDRA: *What did you break?*

VIKKSY: *Why must you assume I have broken something?*

CASSANDRA: *Experience.*

VIKKSY: *This friendship is built on disrespect.*

CASSANDRA: *And yet you remain.*

VIKKSY: *Unfortunately, I have become emotionally invested in the friendship.*

Cassandra laughed.

CASSANDRA: *What do you need?*

VIKKSY: *I want you to find a quiet moment tomorrow evening. No meetings, no rehearsals, no unnecessary stress. Just give yourself a little time.*

CASSANDRA: *Why?*

VIKKSY: *Because I have made a request, and you are making it unnecessarily difficult.*

CASSANDRA: *That isn't an explanation.*

VIKKSY: *It is a very clear request.*

CASSANDRA: *You're suspicious.*

VIKKSY: *I have been called worse by people with less evidence.*

She shook her head, smiling.

CASSANDRA: *Fine. Tomorrow evening.*

VIKKSY: *Excellent. Also, charge your phone.*

Cassandra stared at the screen.

CASSANDRA: *I knew you couldn't finish a conversation normally.*

VIKKSY: *Goodnight, superstar.*

She put the phone down and returned to her script.

She had no idea that the next evening would become one of the most personal moments of her life.

The Final Scene

The following evening, Cassandra settled into a comfortable chair after putting the children to bed.

The house was quiet.

A warm light filled the room. Her award sat on the shelf nearby, beside a framed photograph of her family.

She had spent the day doing ordinary things.

She had answered messages, reviewed a script, checked on the children, and spoken with Rebecca about the mentorship programme. She had laughed at one of Nelson's stories and negotiated with Kayla over the proper number of bedtime kisses.

Nothing about the day would have made a newspaper headline.

And yet, by the time she sat down, she felt grateful.

Her phone lit up.

A message from Vikksy appeared.

VIKKSY: *Ready?*

CASSANDRA: *For what?*

VIKKSY: *For the final chapter.*

Cassandra frowned at the screen.

Then a link appeared.

She opened it.

The screen faded to black.

A soft melody began to play.

Words appeared slowly, one line at a time.

CASSANDRA: BORN TO BE A STAR

A story about a girl who dreamed.

A woman who kept going.

A mother who loved fiercely.

And a star who never needed permission to shine.

Cassandra went still.

A scene unfolded before her.

There was a young woman walking across a university campus in Lagos, holding her books and hurrying toward a lecture.

Cassandra recognized the beginning of the story.

Her beginning.

She watched as the scenes changed.

The classroom.

The first audition.

The nervous preparation.

The first film.

The premiere.

The long days on set.

The phone calls home.

The international production.

The award ceremony.

The faces of people who had believed in her.

The story she had just finished reading was becoming something more personal, a reflection of the journey she had imagined for herself and the person she hoped to become.

Then the screen changed again.

It showed a quiet room filled with warm light.

A woman stood near a window, holding an award.

She looked successful.

She looked happy.

But when she turned, she was not looking at the trophy.

She was looking toward the people she loved.

Nelson ran into the room first.

Kayla followed, carrying her paper crown.

They wrapped their arms around their mother.

The woman knelt to embrace them.

The image faded.

New words appeared.

THE WORLD MAY CELEBRATE THE STAR.

BUT THE PEOPLE WHO LOVE HER KNOW THE WOMAN.

Cassandra pressed a hand against her mouth.

She continued watching.

The next scene showed a small gathering of friends.

Rebecca was laughing.

Sarah, John, and Abiodun were taking photographs.

Vikksy stood nearby, looking as though he was preparing to say something completely unnecessary.

The screen displayed a line of text.

SOME PEOPLE WILL CHEER WHEN THE WORLD LEARNS YOUR NAME.

THE BEST ONES WILL REMEMBER YOU FROM BEFORE IT DID.

Cassandra's eyes filled with tears.

She understood now.

This was not just another story about becoming famous.

It was a story about being seen.

About the people who knew her beyond the photographs, beyond the achievements, beyond the version of herself that the world might someday applaud.

The screen faded to black once more.

Then a final message appeared.

CASSANDRA, THIS STORY IS FOR YOU.

She leaned closer.

And the birthday message began.

A Message for Cassandra

The words appeared slowly, giving her time to read each one.

Dear Cassandra,

Happy Birthday, Superstar.

If this were a film, this would be the scene where the music rises, the camera moves closer, and the audience finally understands why the story began.

But your life is not a film.

It is something far more beautiful, because it is real.

You have dreams that deserve room to grow. You have talents that deserve to be developed. You have a heart that has made room for people, responsibilities, laughter, and hope.

You have had days when things were uncertain.

Days when you had to be strong even though you were tired.

Days when the future seemed far away and the next step was not obvious.

And yet, here you are.

Still learning.

Still growing.

Still imagining the things you could become.

I hope you never lose that part of yourself.

I hope you keep discovering new things that make you excited to wake up in the morning. I hope you find opportunities that challenge you, people who encourage you, and places where your talents can flourish.

I hope you walk into rooms you once thought were beyond your reach and discover that you belong there.

I hope you tell stories that move people, make them laugh, help them understand one another, and remind them of something good about being alive.

I hope you get to experience the kind of success that makes you proud of your hard work.

And when those wonderful moments come, I hope you remember to enjoy them.

Do not become so busy reaching the next destination that you forget to celebrate how far you have travelled.

Do not allow a difficult day to convince you that your entire journey is difficult.

Do not let the opinions of people who barely know you become louder than the truth you have learned about yourself.

You are allowed to grow at your own pace.

You are allowed to change your mind.

You are allowed to begin again.

You are allowed to be proud of yourself before the world catches up.

And you are allowed to rest.

Even superheroes need to sit down sometimes. Besides, your children will probably find a way to defeat you in a game of hide-and-seek regardless of how many awards you win.

Nelson and Kayla will have their own dreams as they grow. I hope they watch you pursue yours and learn that determination does not mean never being afraid. It means discovering that fear does not have to make every decision for you.

I hope they remember your laughter.

I hope they remember the way you listened to their stories, celebrated their little victories, and made them feel loved.

I hope they grow up knowing that their mother was a woman with dreams of her own, and that loving them was never a reason she had to stop believing in herself.

And I hope that, whatever happens in your career, you always have people around you who can make you laugh when you take life too seriously, tell you the truth when you need to hear it, and remind you who you are when the world becomes noisy.

People who will celebrate your victories without competing with you.

People who will encourage you without trying to control your journey.

People who will care about your happiness even when there is nothing to gain from it.

Those people are treasures.

Keep them close.

And remember to be that kind of person for others, too.

Cassandra, I hope this new year of your life brings you beautiful surprises.

I hope it brings peace where you have felt pressure, clarity where you have felt uncertain, laughter where you have felt tired, and courage for the dreams you have not yet dared to pursue.

I hope you get more reasons to smile than reasons to worry.

I hope you discover strengths you did not know you had.

I hope you create memories that you will still be smiling about many years from now.

And when life does not go according to plan, I hope you remember that a difficult chapter is not the same thing as a disappointing story.

You do not need every chapter to be perfect.

You only need to keep living it.

Today, celebrate the person you are.

Celebrate the person you have been.

And look forward to the person you are still becoming.

Because your story is not finished.

There are still places to see, people to meet, characters to play, lessons to learn, laughter to share, and beautiful moments waiting to surprise you.

The world may one day know your name.

It may applaud your performances, celebrate your achievements, and place awards in your hands.

But long before any of that, you were already somebody worth celebrating.

You were already enough.

You still are.

And you always will be.

Happy Birthday, Cassandra.

Keep dreaming. Keep growing. Keep shining.

Your next chapter is waiting.

With love,

Vikksy

The Girl Behind the Crown

When the final words disappeared, Cassandra remained still.

The melody continued softly.

She wiped her cheeks, then laughed at herself for crying so much.

Her phone vibrated.

VIKKSY: *So?*

Cassandra stared at the screen for several seconds before replying.

CASSANDRA: *You made me cry.*

VIKKSY: *I suspected the writing might have emotional consequences.*

CASSANDRA: *You are so annoying.*

VIKKSY: *And yet, the birthday message has received an excellent review.*

CASSANDRA: *Thank you.*

This time, his reply came without a joke.

VIKKSY: *You're welcome, bestie. I meant every word.*

Cassandra looked at the photograph on the shelf.

Her children.

Her family.

Her friends.

Her life.

There were dreams she had already begun to fulfil, and others she had not yet found the courage to name.

There would be more work to do. More lessons to learn. More opportunities to pursue.

But she did not need to wait for the next achievement to be happy with the woman she was becoming.

She stood, walked to the shelf, and picked up her award.

For a moment, she held it in her hands.

Then she placed it beside the family photograph.

Not in front of it.

Beside it.

Because the award belonged to her career, and the photograph reminded her of the life that made the career meaningful.

She switched off the light and walked toward her bedroom.

Tomorrow, she would wake up and continue her story.

There would be scripts to read, plans to make, children to hug, friends to call, and probably another message from Vikksy reminding her to charge her phone.

Some things never changed.

And perhaps that was part of the beauty of it.

The world could call her a superstar.

Her children could call her Mummy.

Rebecca could call her a dramatic person who needed better time management.

Vikksy could call her his bestie and continue being a public menace.

And Cassandra could simply be Cassandra.

A woman with dreams.

A woman with responsibilities.

A woman with people who loved her.

A woman whose story was still unfolding.

THE END.

Or perhaps, more accurately...

TO BE CONTINUED.

Happy Birthday, Cassandra. May the next chapter of your life be even more beautiful than the story you have just finished reading.